

Lady Chatterley's Lover



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF D. H. LAWRENCE

D. H. Lawrence was born to working-class parents in the English Midlands, not far from Teversal (the village on which the fictional Tevershall in *Lady Chatterley's Lover* is based). Despite his family's lack of wealth, Lawrence won a scholarship to a prestigious high school, further supplementing his education by reading all of the books in his local library. In his early twenties, Lawrence was mentored by the prominent writer Ford Madox Ford, who introduced Lawrence to many of the most prolific modernist writers of the day. Though initially Lawrence was motivated to write social realist stories about class conflict (like his debut novel, [Sons and Lovers](#)), his 1914 elopement with his wife Frieda caused Lawrence to shift towards more explicitly sexual subject matter. The graphic nature of Lawrence's work made it the subject of much controversy and censorship. In his later years, Lawrence fled his native England for Taos, New Mexico and Florence, Italy, preferring to be anonymous in the face of scandal. Though his work was not critically acclaimed during his lifetime, Lawrence rose to great renown posthumously—until the 1970s, when feminists began to question the gender politics of his work.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

The novel begins just after the conclusion of World War I, which lasted from 1914 to 1918 and was the first conflict in which more of the fighting was done via large machines (guns, tanks, and airplanes) than with hand-to-hand combat; the fear of machines replacing men is thus an important theme in *Lady Chatterley's Lover*. The war, the most devastating event in human history at that point in time, also killed millions and wounded millions more. World War I was especially destructive for England, which had the highest number of casualties of any nation—and which, post-war, began to lose its status as the world's most powerful state. In the story, therefore, Clifford Chatterley's wounded body both reflects the widespread reality of personal injury and captures the nation's more symbolic pain.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

Lawrence—who wrote poetry, memoirs and essays in addition to novels—was inspired by many of his modernist contemporaries, especially his mentor Ford Madox Ford and his close friend Ezra Pound. Lawrence's willingness to write explicitly sexual prose was also likely inspired by James Joyce, whose novel [Ulysses](#) was at the heart of a very famous

censorship trial for its own protracted sex scenes. The plot of *Lady Chatterley's Lover* was allegedly sparked by E. M. Forster's then-unpublished novel *Maurice*, which Lawrence is known to have read. Forster's novel follows an upper-class man who falls in love with a gamekeeper, a plotline that would later form the backbone (albeit with key details changed) of Lawrence's narrative.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** *Lady Chatterley's Lover*
- **When Written:** 1920s
- **Where Written:** Florence, Italy
- **When Published:** 1928 (Lawrence's private edition), 1932 (authorized edition), 1960 (uncensored edition)
- **Literary Period:** Modernism
- **Genre:** Romance Novel, Erotic Literature
- **Setting:** The English Midlands in the years after World War I
- **Climax:** Constance decides she wants to leave her husband Clifford for his gamekeeper, Oliver Mellors.
- **Antagonist:** Clifford Chatterley
- **Point of View:** Third Person

EXTRA CREDIT

Connie in Court. Though a heavily censored version of the novel was published in 1932, Lawrence's full manuscript was not made available to readers until 1960. But before Penguin could release the book, the British government charged the publishers with obscenity under the Obscene Publications Act of 1959. Fortunately, the defense summoned a slate of famous authors—including E. M. Forster—to defend the novel's artistic merit (plus, the Bishop of Woolwich testified to what he saw as the book's Christian values)! After a six-day trial, the jury found that *Lady Chatterley's Lover* was more artistic than obscene, and Penguin was allowed to go through with publication.

Midlands on the Movie Screen. *Lady Chatterley's Lover* has been adapted for the screen several times, but the most recent film was released in 2022. The movie stars Emma Corrin (famous for playing Princess Diana on *The Crown*) as Connie.



PLOT SUMMARY

Constance and her sister Hilda, the daughters of prominent British R.A. Sir Malcolm Reid, lived a carefree youth: they spent their days with their father's artistic friends or at boarding school in Dresden, learning music and having love affairs with

talkative young men. But when World War I started, the German lovers were killed, the pre-war parties ground to a halt, and the girls were sent back home to London. While war raged on, Hilda tied the knot with an older man, and Constance fell for and married Clifford Chatterley, a soft-spoken member of England's aristocracy.

Now, the war is over, and Constance and Clifford have settled in Wragby Hall, the Chatterley's mansion in the English Midlands. Clifford's stint as a soldier has left him paralyzed from the waist down and sexually impotent. Though Connie does not mind her husband's dependency (he relies on her to bathe him and get him in and out of his mechanized **wheelchair**), she does lament her lack of a baby. She also struggles with her new proximity to downcast Tevershall village, the mining town that has long supplied the Chatterleys with their wealth. The working-class miners (colliers) and their wives resent Connie, and the smoke and sound from the mines pollute the once-beautiful landscape.

Clifford starts writing short stories, which get published in prominent magazines. Inspired by Clifford's work, a group of intellectual men begins visiting Wragby; Connie resents some of these men (like astronomer Charles May) and admires others (like military general Tommy Dukes). These men endlessly debate "the life of the mind," minimizing sex and romance as vestigial and unimportant. Though Connie listens to these conversations, they make her anxious and bored. When Sir Malcolm visits, he frets that his daughter has become thin and sickly, even suggesting to Clifford that Connie should have an affair to alleviate stress. Clifford then tells Connie that he would accept it if she had a baby with another man, as long as she raised the child as Clifford's.

In a bid to increase his fame, Clifford befriends Michaelis, an Irishman whose satirical plays have recently brought him international fame. Though Michaelis has money now, he was born without wealth, and the playwright's outsider status makes him attractive to Connie. Shortly after Michaelis's first visit to Wragby, he and Connie sleep together. Though they keep it secret from Clifford, Connie and Michaelis continue their tryst for the next several months. It ends only when Michaelis insults Connie, criticizing her for focusing too much on her own orgasm during sex.

Spring rolls around and the **flowers** bloom, but without Michaelis, Connie falls deeper into depression. One day, while Clifford and Connie are on a walk through the Wragby grounds, they stumble on Oliver Mellors, the property's gamekeeper. Connie is surprised by Mellors's gentlemanly bearing, given that he has such a working-class job (and that he sometimes speaks with the thick Midlands dialect). Privately, Connie asks Clifford about Mellors, and Clifford explains that Mellors rose through the military ranks in World War I, learning upper-crust habits as he climbed. Clifford also shares that Mellors is legally married to a woman named Bertha

Coutts, though Bertha has left him for another man.

When Hilda visits Wragby, she sees what a burden taking care of Clifford has become for Connie, and she forces Clifford to hire a nurse. Clifford is reluctant, but eventually he agrees to bring on Ivy Bolton, a well-respected local widow. Mrs. Bolton bonds with both Chatterleys: she stays up late playing chess with Clifford, and she introduces Connie to the swirl of Tevershall gossip. But still, Connie feels miserable.

To break up the endless monotony, Connie begins visiting the little hut where Mellors tends to a group of mother hens. After a few weeks, the hens' eggs start to hatch, which causes Connie to burst into tears; the chickens' "brooding female bodies" remind her of her own plight, "forlorn and unused." Connie's tender crying sparks a flame of attraction in Mellors, and the two have sex. Though the actual sex is underwhelming, both Connie and Mellors feel a new sense of "life" after this brief encounter. The next day, Connie returns to Mellors's hut, and they have sex again. Mellors is eager to touch Connie's naked body, and his desire enchants and overwhelms her.

Wanting to clear her head, Connie stays away from Mellors's hut for a few days. To distract herself, she visits Leslie Winter, Clifford's godfather, and Mrs. Flint, one of Clifford's tenants. Mrs. Flint has just had a baby, and Connie cannot help feeling jealous of this woman's motherhood. On the way back from Mrs. Flint's house, Connie runs into Mellors, who wonders why she has been avoiding him. The two have sex in the woods. This time, Connie and Mellors orgasm at the same time, which Mellors feels is a rare and beautiful experience. As she walks home, Connie considers having a child with Mellors.

Connie's affair with Mellors continues, and their feelings for each other deepen, though Mellors does not want to have a child; he is deeply pessimistic about the future, which he believes is being ruined by emasculating, polluting machines. Mrs. Bolton realizes what is going on, while Clifford remains ignorant, only feeling angry that Connie is spending less and less time at home. Clifford now gives most of his time to the mines, shifting his focus from short stories to new chemical and industrial technologies. His interest in maximizing the Tevershall mines' profits and efficiency makes him feel a renewed sense of manhood, and he (deludedly) begins to believe that he could one day conceive a child, after all.

Connie's father suggests a family trip to Venice, and Connie decides to go—not because she wants to travel, but to pretend that she conceived a child on the trip (while secretly getting pregnant via Mellors). Clifford makes Connie promise that she will come back to him after the trip is done, though she privately plans to run off with Mellors as soon as she returns. Before she leaves, Connie introduces Mellors to Hilda, and the two instantly spar over their differences in class and their conflicting mannerisms. Then Connie and Mellors share one final night together, in which they decorate each other's genitalia with flowers.

In Venice, Connie finds herself disgusted with all the consumerism and materialism that goes into tourism. She reconnects with Duncan Forbes, an old family friend who has earned some acclaim from his modern art; she also discovers that she is pregnant. Clifford writes to tell Connie that Mellors's wife has returned with a vengeance, spreading the news that Mellors is having an affair with Connie—so Clifford has fired Mellors.

Connie leaves Venice and reunites with Mellors, who is now living in London. Connie tells Mellors about her pregnancy, and though he is nervous at first, she reassures him that all will be fine: “be tender” to the child, she instructs, “and that will be its future.” The couple agrees that they need to separate while they both work out their complex divorces, but they hope to be reunited soon. The novel ends with Mellors working on a farm, biding his time and waiting hopefully for his life with Connie to begin.



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Lady Constance Chatterley – Born Constance Reid, Connie Chatterley is Sir Malcolm Reid's daughter, Hilda's younger sister, and Clifford Chatterley's wife. Throughout the novel, Connie is distinguished by her hyper-feminine appearance and her intuitive grace. Though Connie begins the book disinterested in physical pleasure, her devotion to “the life of the mind” wanes early in her sexless, unsatisfying marriage with Clifford. After a brief and painful affair with writer Michaelis, Connie finds her way to Oliver Mellors, her husband's rough-spoken gamekeeper. With Mellors, Connie learns to give in to her bodily instincts, embracing the “piercing, consuming, rather awful sensuality” of their affair over the hyper-verbal, philosophical life she shares with Clifford. In falling for Mellors, Connie also distances herself from the materialism and status she was raised in, preferring instead to live a life close to nature; she identifies with the spring **flowers** she sees and begins to think of herself “like a forest,” brimming with impulsive life. By the end of the novel, Connie is pregnant with Mellors's child, a beacon of hope for the future that suggests the “tenderness” of their love will extend beyond their coupling.

Oliver Mellors – Oliver Mellors is the gamekeeper for Clifford's Wragby estate and the man that Connie begins an affair with. Though Mellors is working-class, his years in the military have endowed him with a degree of sophistication and ease that most of the wealthier characters in the novel lack. This contradiction—between his rugged work and his effortless manners, his use of broad Midlands dialect and his razor-sharp mind—is what draws Connie to Mellors. Their bond is then strengthened by a shared passion for sex and particularly by Mellors's appreciation of Connie's body. Crucially, Mellors

takes a much more traditional view of gender roles than Clifford, emphasizing sexual dominance as the key quality of masculinity. Because of these rigid views, Mellors loathes his estranged wife, Bertha Coutts, critiquing her for stubbornness and sexual aggressiveness. At the same time, however, Mellors is uniquely gentle with Connie, who praises him for being “kind to the female in her,” believing he is the rare man who has “the courage of [his] own tenderness.” Both Mellors's quick temper and his intense warmth show that, unlike the even-keeled and mechanical Clifford, he is a man in tune with his own natural instincts.

Sir Clifford Chatterley – Sir Clifford Chatterley is Constance's husband, Sir Geoffrey's son, and Emma Chatterley's younger brother. After his father dies, Clifford inherits his father's baronet status (making him a low-ranking member of the British aristocracy) and Wragby Hall, the family's large Midlands estate. After his time fighting in World War I leaves him paralyzed from the waist down, Clifford becomes dependent on a mechanized wheelchair to get around; frustrated by his immobility, Clifford turns to a variety of intellectual pursuits, first writing short stories and then studying chemistry and cutting-edge mining technologies. Though Connie is initially charmed by Clifford's quiet intellect, over time, she grows to resent his focus on “the life of the mind” and his insistence on industrial wealth instead of natural simplicity. Clifford, frequently insecure about his masculinity, lashes out at Connie, turning for comfort to his hired nurse, Ivy Bolton. Ultimately, the novel satirizes Clifford's insistence on the superiority of the upper classes while depicting his technological obsessions as a real threat to others' peace and happiness.

Mrs. Ivy Bolton – Ivy Bolton is a local widow in Tevershall, whom Clifford eventually hires as a nurse. Though Mrs. Bolton is bossy and authoritative with the colliers of her small town, with Clifford, she becomes quiet and subservient, a shift in behavior that pleases Clifford and confounds Connie. Mrs. Bolton resents the aristocracy for the way they hoard wealth and neglect the miners (including her dead husband) who make them rich, but she also wants to gain access to these aristocrats—to know “all that the gentry knew, all that made them upper class.” Thus, Mrs. Bolton bonds with Connie, silently supporting her affair with Mellors, but she also stands with Clifford, staying up late into the night to gamble with him. After Connie leaves Clifford, Mrs. Bolton becomes his lover of sorts (or perhaps a stand-in for something like a lover), a role she finds simultaneously thrilling and horrifying. Still, even as she becomes more intimate with Clifford, Mrs. Bolton never forgets “the touch” of her deceased husband Ted, bolstering the novel's idea that truly passionate sex is rare but transformative.

Michaelis – Michaelis is an Irish writer, known and beloved across the US and the UK for his popular plays satirizing wealthy society. Though Clifford does not like Michaelis, he

invites him to Wragby in a bid to increase his own fame. Connie is immediately drawn to Michaelis, with his stark features, his childlike interest in wealth, and his rebellious outsider status. Connie and Michaelis begin a love affair, and though Michaelis pressures Connie to leave Clifford, he is also cruel to her, insulting her for caring too much about her own orgasms during sex. This behavior deeply wounds Connie, and she distances herself from Michaelis, though he continues to write to her, making contact whenever she is in London (and even when she goes off to Venice with her sister Hilda).

Sir Malcolm Reid – Sir Malcolm Reid is a prominent R.A. and painter, the father of both Hilda and Constance. Though Sir Malcolm has earned great social status and wealth by the time the novel begins, he still frets that his working-class, Scottish roots will prevent him from joining the highest echelons of English society. For that reason, Sir Malcolm at first disapproves of Connie's affair with Mellors—though once he actually meets Mellors, the two bond over their shared love of vigorous sex and old-fashioned masculinity. Sir Malcolm favors Connie over Hilda (and often goes to great lengths to ensure Connie's happiness), largely because he admires his younger daughter for being so in touch with her sexual desires.

Hilda – Hilda is Sir Malcolm's eldest child and Connie's older sister. Though the two girls were close in their youth, as they get older, Hilda becomes more similar to her mother: snobby and easily frustrated, claiming socialist values at dinner parties but refusing to actually "mix" with the working classes. Though Hilda initially defends Connie in her marriage, forcing Clifford to hire Mrs. Bolton to protect her sister's mental health, she turns against Connie once Mellors comes into the picture. Like Clifford, Hilda is satirized in the novel, as her sense of superiority is juxtaposed with her bad manners and awkward behavior.

Duncan Forbes – Duncan Forbes is a well-known painter and a longstanding friend of Sir Malcolm Reid. Constance likes Duncan for his easy-going manners, even if she (and Mellors) think his art, with its abstract "tubes and valves and spirals," is ugly and a little insidious. Duncan has had a crush on Connie for decades, so when she needs someone to pretend to be the father of her illegitimate baby, Duncan agrees—on the condition that Connie will model for one of his paintings.

Sir Geoffrey Chatterley – Sir Geoffrey Chatterley is Clifford and Emma's father and the wealthy gentleman in charge of Wragby. Sir Clifford is a baronet—meaning he is a low-ranking member of the English aristocracy—and he values his Midlands estate for its sprawling landscapes and long history, though he pays little attention to the mines that have actually made the Chatterleys rich. Clifford initially finds his father ridiculous (especially because of Sir Geoffrey's nostalgic, useless patriotism), but he must step into his father's shoes when, soon after the end of World War I, Geoffrey passes away.

Miss Emma Chatterley – Emma Chatterley is Sir Geoffrey's

middle child and Clifford's older sister. She resents Clifford for marrying—the siblings had once sworn they would never do so—and she makes Connie feel unwelcome when she first arrives at Wragby. Eventually, however, Emma moves to London, leaving Connie and Clifford to deal with Wragby on their own.

Squire Leslie Winter – Leslie Winter is Clifford's godfather and a well-known squire (meaning major landowner) in the Midlands. Winter lives in a beautiful estate called Shipley; though Winter once encouraged the local colliers to spend time on his property, he now resents their encroachment. Winter is one of the people who most hopes that Clifford will regain his potency and give birth to an heir.

General Tommy Dukes – Tommy Dukes is a respected military general and a member of Clifford's philosophical, male-dominated social circles. Dukes is more thoughtful and less misogynistic than his friends, and he and Connie quickly bond. Dukes also shares Connie's frustration with the constant discussion of "the life of the mind"; Dukes feels that real knowledge stems from "your belly and your penis as much as your brain." Though Dukes becomes an important confidante for Connie, Connie struggles with the idea that Dukes views attraction and friendship as mutually exclusive.

Charles May – Charles May is an astronomer and part of Clifford's academic friend group (alongside Hammond and Tommy Dukes). May is a bachelor, and he believes that sex is merely a necessity, like food—important for survival, but not nearly as interesting as "the life of the mind." Connie resents May for his cavalier attitude towards romance and for his insistence on language and philosophical thought above all else.

Bertha Coutts – Bertha Coutts is Mellors's estranged wife and the mother of his daughter, Connie Mellors. Mellors and Bertha grew up together. Though he was initially impressed by her worldliness and "sensuality," the couple soon grew to resent each other's sexual habits. Bertha disliked how much Mellors craved sex, while Mellors felt that Bertha was selfish in the pursuit of her own orgasm. During the war, Bertha left Mellors for another man, but after Mellors files for divorce, Bertha tries to stop him by spreading rumors about his affair with Connie. In the novel, Bertha exemplifies the aggressive sexuality that Mellors—and later Connie—comes to see as deviant.

Giovanni – Giovanni is the gondolier that Connie and Hilda hire during their time in Venice. Giovanni is depicted as sleazy and greedy, especially because he hopes that the sisters want to hire him as a male sex worker. He introduces Connie and Duncan Forbes to his friend Daniele, who is quieter and more intriguing.

Daniele – Daniele is one of Giovanni's friends in Venice. Though he seems introverted and lonely, he actually has a wife and two children, prompting Connie to reflect that "only people who are capable of real togetherness have that look of being

alone.” Daniele is also notable for his extraordinary physical beauty.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Hammond – Hammond is a prominent British writer and one of Clifford’s philosophical friends. Connie dislikes Hammond, in part because she finds him to be snobby and in part because he seems to understand women (including his own wife) as property to accrue.

Mrs. Flint – Mrs. Flint is one of Clifford Chatterley’s tenants, leasing a farm from him that she calls Marehay. Mrs. Flint envies Connie for her wealthy, sophisticated lifestyle, though Connie secretly envies Mrs. Flint in turn for her folksier, more freewheeling lifestyle and for her young baby daughter.

Connie Mellors – Connie Mellors is the eight-year-old daughter Oliver Mellors shares with Bertha Coutts. Constance Chatterley meets Connie in the woods, and though she acts warmly towards the little girl, she privately finds her manipulative and frustrating. Connie lives with her grandmother (Mellors’s mother) in the neighboring town of Stacks Gate.

TERMS

Bolshevism – Bolshevism is a strand of communist thought that originated with Vladimir Lenin in early 20th-century Russia. Bolsheviks believed that capitalist governments must be overthrown via an organized, disciplined group of revolutionaries who would then establish a “dictatorship of the proletariat.” In 1920, when *Lady Chatterley’s Lover* begins, Bolshevism had just caught fire in Russia, overtaking the Tsar’s government in the various revolutions of 1917. To **Oliver Mellors**, Bolshevism is the most mechanical—and therefore threatening—of all political philosophies. But to **Tommy Dukes**, Bolshevik communism is just a more honest version of capitalism, as it acknowledges the machinery of wealth and labor instead of trying to obscure it.

Collier – The word “collier” refers primarily to miners, though it could also refer to lower-status coal merchants. In the novel, most of the residents of Tevershall—and the towns that surround it—are colliers. The word is used in both British and American English, though it is especially popular in the Midlands region of England.

Gondola/Gondolier – A gondola is a large, narrow boat with a flat bottom and curved tips. These boats are most commonly used in the canals of Venice, Italy, which is where **Connie** and **Hilda** encounter them. Gondolas are rowed by gondoliers (like **Giovanni** in the novel), who stand on the backs of the boats as they steer.

Midlands – The Midlands is a rural region in the central part of

England. Though the Midlands once signaled rolling hills, peaceful peasants, and Elizabethan-era grandeur—as shown in the stories of Robin Hood—by the time *Lady Chatterley’s Lover* begins, the Midlands have been cut up and polluted by a great number of large-scale mines. The Midlands are also home to a number of dialects, which **Mellors** speaks (and then, at one point, teaches to **Connie**).

R.A. – In Great Britain, the acronym R.A. stands for “Royal Academician,” meaning an artist or architect who has achieved enough renown to become a member of England’s Royal Academy of Arts. **Sir Malcolm Reid** has been made an R.A. for his celebrated paintings. Sir Malcolm’s status as a Royal Academician is especially prestigious given that there are never more than 100 R.A.s at any given time.

Robin Hood – Robin Hood is a character famous in British folk legend, known for his determination to “steal from the rich and give to the poor.” Beginning in the 1300s, Robin Hood was often portrayed as woodsy, heroic, and gallantly romantic; many of his adventures were rumored to take place in Sherwood Forest, in the heart of the English Midlands. In *Lady Chatterley’s Lover*, both **Connie** and **Clifford** see the legend of Robin Hood as a symbol for the former glory of places like Wragby—but Connie in particular laments that the rural adventures depicted in Robin Hood are no longer possible in this new, more mechanized age.



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



INTELLECT VS. BODILY EXPERIENCE

At the beginning of D. H. Lawrence’s novel *Lady Chatterley’s Lover*, Connie Chatterley finds great joy in clever short stories and long-winded conversations, and in her teenage romances, she prizes good conversation above any physical intimacy. But while Connie and her impotent husband, Clifford, originally share an appreciation for the “life of the mind,” Connie’s adventurous affair with game-keeper Oliver Mellors allows her to embrace a more physical form of joy. With Clifford, Connie discusses philosophy and reads famous French authors; with Mellors, Connie tries out profanity and the Midlands dialect, using language not to distance herself from the human body but to praise and explore it. And as her affair deepens, Connie puts increasing emphasis on her body over her mind, growing to “hate” words because they “suck the life-sap” out of physical experience.

Structurally, too, the novel tries to counteract the modern focus

on “the life of the mind” above all else. Throughout *Lady Chatterley’s Lover*, Lawrence uses explicit, detailed language to describe Connie’s most intimate moments, shifting his readers’ attention to the body in the same way that Connie shifts hers. And while Clifford is obsessed with traditional forms of learning (he is always studying chemistry, poetry, or finance), the novel suggests that the most important kind of knowledge is bodily. As one of Connie’s friends, Tommy Dukes, puts it, “real knowledge” comes “out of your belly [...] as much as out of your brain and mind.” In other words, then, *Lady Chatterley’s Lover* shows that “the life of the mind” is something of an illusion, suggesting that it’s only by paying attention to embodied experience that people can find real meaning and understanding.



NATURE VS. MACHINERY

Lady Chatterley’s Lover, D. H. Lawrence’s novel about Constance Chatterley’s affair with her husband’s gamekeeper, is set in the Midlands

region of England, once a land of rugged woods and stunning natural beauty. But by 1920, when Connie arrives, these lovely hills have turned into the mining town of Tevershall; at all hours of the night, Connie smells the smoke and hears the clanging sounds of the nearby mines. And just as the picturesque landscape is overrun by these industrial machines, Connie and her friends feel that people themselves are becoming mechanized. Connie’s lover Oliver Mellors and her husband’s nurse Mrs. Bolton worry that people have been consumed by their love of money and consumption. Connie herself feels that the miners and their employers (including her husband Clifford) are not “not men” but creatures “of the elements, carbon, iron, silicon”—a thought that underscores the extent to which the people around her have succumbed to (and even come to internalize) industrialization.

For Mellors in particular, the increasing mechanization of life signals humanity’s impending collapse. But even as the novel reflects Mellors’s anxiety, it also honors Connie’s hope that natural growth and feeling will ultimately triumph. Over and over again, Lawrence details the beauty of various spring **flowers**, which push through the cold earth and stay “alive” despite the poor air quality and the trampling machines. Similarly, Connie and Mellors often understand their sexual intimacy—the result of a decision to give into their most natural impulses—as a kind of return to nature, threading flowers through each other’s hair and dancing naked in the rain. Indeed, the novel ends on an explicitly “hopeful” note, suggesting that Connie and Mellors’s passion for each other and for the land around them will allow them to triumph over mechanized doom.



CLASS, CONSUMERISM, AND MONEY

Throughout D. H. Lawrence’s novel *Lady Chatterley’s Lover*, protagonist Constance Chatterley finds herself surrounded by

consumerist obsession. Her husband, Clifford, wants only to maximize the wealth he earns from his mining pits; the miners (known as colliers) who work for Clifford pine for the clothes and excursions they want but cannot afford. And while wealthy people like Clifford and Connie’s sister Hilda insist that class hierarchies are “fate[d]” and immovable, Connie thinks that everyone in the modern world has become a “moneyboy” or a “moneygirl”—the only real “difference was how much you’d got, and how much you wanted.”

Throughout the novel, Lawrence contests this consumerist mindset in several ways. First, he demonstrates Connie’s sexual and romantic frustration with the wealthy gentlemen of her own class—only to depict her happiness once she falls in love with the working-class Oliver Mellors, beginning an affair that flies in the face of materialism and upward mobility. And second, Lawrence satirizes wealthy characters like Clifford (bratty and ridiculous) and Hilda (awkward and ill-mannered), showing that status is not a matter of fate but of arbitrary circumstance. Ultimately, then, *Lady Chatterley’s Lover* reveals that people are happiest when they focus less on consumption and more on things that cannot be bought, whether it is sexual pleasure or natural beauty—when they discover, as Mellors puts it, that “living and spending isn’t the same thing.” In turn, the novel demonstrates that while some amount of money is necessary to survive, too much wealth is both unsatisfying and unflattering for the people who possess it.



GENDER AND SEXUALITY

Lady Chatterley’s Lover has made waves for nearly a century due to its frank, explicit descriptions of Connie’s sexual encounters. Lawrence breaks with

tradition from beginning to end, using profanity and paying a great deal of attention to the mechanics and physical realities of sex. In fact, the final line of the novel sees Connie’s lover, Oliver Mellors, tenderly referencing his paramour’s genitalia. But even as *Lady Chatterley’s Lover* takes an open-minded view of sexuality, it also reiterates traditional—and traditionally restrictive—gender norms. Connie begins the novel engaging in spirited conversation with her sister, Hilda, and writing books with her husband, Clifford, but these intellectual pursuits leave her unsatisfied. Only when Connie throws herself wholeheartedly into her affair with Mellors, becoming his “passive, consenting thing,” does she find true happiness, suggesting that Lawrence believed women should primarily define themselves through their relations with men. Similarly, the novel mocks Clifford for not being a true “man” because of his lack of sexual potency, equating masculinity with sexual prowess just as it equates femininity with passivity. Ironically,

therefore, the novel's progressive views on sexuality end up underscoring its regressive views on gender, as Connie's seeming liberation is in fact a return to a more old-fashioned, constrained approach to womanhood.



CATASTROPHE, CONTINUITY, AND TRADITION

D. H. Lawrence's 1932 novel *Lady Chatterley's Lover* begins just after the trauma of World War I. Even from the very opening lines, Lawrence locates his reader in this fractured era: "the cataclysm has happened," the book begins, "we are among the ruins." For many of the characters, including Clifford Chatterley and his band of intellectual friends, the loss and chaos of the war presents a chance to rebuild differently. They focus on new inventions (like the radio) and new forms of industry (like the cutting-edge mining technologies Clifford obsessively studies). But for Clifford's wife, Connie, and her lover, Oliver Mellors, this post-war industrialization feels less like recovery and more like destruction, as if this new version of their country has completely replaced everything that came before it. This kind of development is, in Connie's mind, "not organic, but mechanical"—a sentiment suggesting that she values the idea of continuity, or the notion that the future should somehow be connected to everything that came before it. Whereas Connie and Mellors crave a more "organic" form of continuity, Clifford obsesses over finding more efficient ways to run his mines, thinking that inventions and new beginnings are the best way to forge ahead. By juxtaposing Clifford's "mechanical" rebuilding with Connie's more natural view of continuity and restoration, then, *Lady Chatterley's Lover* suggests that nostalgia, care for nature, and an attention to "history" are all key to moving forward from catastrophe without "blot[ting]" out everything that came before.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



FLOWERS

Throughout *Lady Chatterley's Lover*, flowers symbolize the beauty and strength of nature, even in the face of mechanized threats. Connie's affair with gamekeeper Oliver Mellors begins in the springtime, as violets and daffodils push their way out of the cold ground. It is only fitting, then, that flowers often stand for the—natural, biological—urges that Connie and Mellors feel for each other. Connie, describing the flowers near Mellors's hut as "erect" and "alive," endows them with phallic power and attraction, while Mellors touches Connie during sex as tenderly as "if she were a flower." Eventually, Mellors and Connie even decorate each

other with forget-me-nots and primroses, threading the flowers through each other's pubic hair as a way of expressing their desire and care.

But just as flowers represent the pure, natural love that Connie and Mellors share, they also hint at the fragility of such love in the face of Clifford's more mechanical interests. Connie often reflects that the mines, which Clifford fights so valiantly to grow, are "killing the very air" that the flowers need to grow. Moreover, Clifford's obsession with literature and poetry also does damage to the flowers' straightforward beauty; instead of appreciating flowers as they are, Connie laments that Clifford uses words to "suck [...] all the life-sap out of living things." In *Lady Chatterley's Lover*, then, flowers symbolize not only natural beauty and desire but also the difficulty of preserving these natural pleasures, especially in the face of over-intellectualization and technological destruction.



CLIFFORD'S WHEELCHAIR

Clifford Chatterley's wheelchair symbolizes the destructive, emasculating dangers of mechanical technology. After Clifford is wounded and paralyzed from the waist down (a result of his time fighting in World War I), he becomes dependent on an expensive, high-tech wheelchair for mobility. In what is widely considered to be evidence of Lawrence's own ableist views, Clifford's inability to walk or have sex is equated with a lack of masculinity; at one point, his wife's paramour, Oliver Mellors, mocks Clifford for literally lacking "balls" and thus having "none of that spunky wild bit of a man in him." Clifford's wheelchair is then presented as the way he compensates, as he turns to a machine to replenish his diminished manhood.

Just as the wheelchair represents the novel's anxiety that men are being turned into machines, it also demonstrates the threat mechanization poses to nature. In one particularly important scene, Clifford's wheelchair crushes the **flowers** underneath it as he traverses the Wragby grounds, turning the abstract danger of technology into something tangible and urgent. In another moment, Clifford's wheelchair breaks down, and he himself breaks down, too, screaming at Mellors and Connie to fix the machine so that he can feel less powerless. By this logic, it is unsurprising that Lawrence presents Mellors's strong body and dislike of mechanization as the antidote to Clifford's failures—though again, it is important to note the ableist and gender-normative thinking behind Lawrence's use of disability as symbol of emasculation and deterioration.



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Signet edition of *Lady Chatterley's Lover* published in 2011.

Chapter 1 Quotes

☞ Ours is essentially a tragic age, so we refuse to take it tragically. The cataclysm has happened, we are among the ruins, we start to build up new little habitats, to have new little hopes. It is rather hard work: there is now no smooth road into the future: but we go round, or scramble over the obstacles. We've got to live, no matter how many skies have fallen.

This was more or less Constance Chatterley's position. The war had brought the roof down over her head. And she had realized that one must live and learn.

Related Characters: Lady Constance Chatterley (speaker)

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 1

Explanation and Analysis

This passage, the opening lines of the novel, locates *Lady Chatterley's Lover* in the loss and destruction of post-World War I England. Though all of Europe was devastated by the conflict, no other nation lost as many troops as the UK did. Moreover, the war saw Great Britain—which had for centuries enjoyed its status as the dominant world power—lose influence to the United States. The “cataclysm” this opening paragraph references thus signals both personal grief and political weakness, the grand aspirations of pre-war life replaced by new “little hopes.”

Yet even as the novel immediately grounds readers in “a tragic age,” it also emphasizes the need for pushing through—not by ignoring that life has been reduced to “ruins,” but my “go[ing] round” those ruins and rebuilding. Right away, then, the narrative suggests that the only way to move into the “future” is steadily, with optimism and patience.

Fascinatingly, this passage addresses readers as “we,” allying the novel’s audience with its narrator and then with Constance (“this was more or less Constance’s Chatterley’s position”). By framing its perspective so clearly right at the outset—and by linking that overarching frame to Connie’s personal belief—the novel also links its readers to its protagonist, whose feelings and beliefs shape the third-person narrative.

☞ But a woman could yield to a man without yielding her inner, free self. That the poets and talkers about sex did not seem to have taken sufficiently into account. A woman could take a man without really giving herself away. Certainly she could take him without giving herself into his power. Rather she could use the sex thing to have power over him. For she only had to hold herself back in sexual intercourse, and let him finish and expend himself without herself coming to the crisis: and then she could prolong the connection and achieve her orgasm and her crisis while he was merely her tool.

Related Characters: Lady Constance Chatterley (speaker), Hilda

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 4

Explanation and Analysis

As teenagers, Connie and her sister Hilda have a series of short-lived affairs with the boys at their Dresden boarding school. While Connie loves her passionate conversations with these boys, she hates having sexual intercourse with them, especially because they expect women to “yield” to them physically and emotionally. But while Connie has sex willingly, she holds onto “inner” control as much as possible: she takes charge over her own orgasm rather than experiencing pleasure on her lover’s timeline and refuses to “give into” her lover’s power, instead finding power in her own withholding. Over time, Connie will change her mind about the kind of sex she craves, but at this moment, she wants something almost mechanized, in which her partner is more a “tool” than anything else.

There are several other notable details in this passage. First, the use of the word “crisis” as a euphemistic term for orgasm (in addition to being common practice at Lawrence’s time) implicitly links the experience of orgasm to the political “crisis” of post-war life; in each case, the intensity of conflict or sex creates confusion and complexity around how to move forward. Also, Connie’s dismissal of the way “poets and talkers” address sex shows just how difficult it is to capture intense physical feelings with language.

Chapter 3 Quotes

☞☞ Real knowledge comes out of the whole corpus of the consciousness; out of your belly and your penis as much as that of your brain and mind. The mind can only analyze and rationalize. Set the mind and the reason to cock it over the rest, and all they can do is criticize, and make a deadness. [...] Mind you, it's like this; while you live your life, you are in some way an organic whole with all life. But once you start the mental life you pluck the apple. You've severed the connection between the apple and the tree: the organic connection and if you've got nothing in your life but the mental life, then you yourself are a plucked apple.

Related Characters: General Tommy Dukes (speaker), Sir Clifford Chatterley

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 36

Explanation and Analysis

Clifford's circle of intellectual friends loves to debate politics and philosophy, often dismissing bodily cravings—for food or sex—as irrelevant and undignified. Only Tommy Dukes, a retired general, pushes back against this worldview, arguing that “real knowledge” involves “the whole corpus”; though important realizations can come out of “analyz[ing] and rational[izing],” Dukes feels that those realizations must always remain grounded in the actual experience of “life.”

This vital passage thus challenges “the mental life” that Clifford prides himself on (in fact, Dukes even suggests that Clifford's “emphasis” on reason is sinful, that it “pluck[s] the apple” just as the biblical figure of Eve did in the Garden of Eden). In particular, Dukes values “the belly” and “the penis,” both body parts associated with desire, whether for food or for sex. Moreover, both the belly and the penis have a built-in futurity; just as a person eats to gain energy for the next day, one procreates to extend one's family through the next generation.

Finally, Dukes's focus on “organic connection” is essential. Whereas Clifford's hyper-verbal mode of being (“the life of the mind,” as characters often term it) results in “deadness,” a focus on the body and its revelations allows people to integrate into the “organic whole” of the world around them. Throughout the novel, various characters will following their bodily impulses allows them new agency and comfort in nature and the world at large.

Chapter 4 Quotes

☞☞ It's what endures through one's life that matters; my own life matters to me, and its long continuance and development. But what do the occasional connections matter? And the occasional sexual connections especially! If people don't exaggerate them ridiculously, they pass like the mating of birds. And so they should. What does it matter? It's the lifelong companionship that matters. It's the living together from day-to-day, not the sleeping together once or twice. You and I are married, no matter what happens to us. We have the habit of each other. And habit, to my thinking, is more vital than any occasional excitement. The long, slow, enduring thing...that's what we live by...not the occasional spasm of any sort.

Related Characters: Sir Clifford Chatterley (speaker), Lady Constance Chatterley

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 44

Explanation and Analysis

In this strange monologue, Clifford, desperate for an heir to carry on the Chatterley name and all its riches, encourages Connie to have a child with another man. While Connie will later come to value “sexual connections” above all else, Clifford dismisses the idea that a momentary “spasm” can have any lasting meaning. To Clifford, the physical pleasures and intimacies of sex are almost animalistic, “like the mating of birds.” Clifford instead insists that forced “habits” and the legal and financial institution of “marriage” are the important factors “to live by.”

Later, Clifford will become obsessed with new machines and technologies and the manufactured permanence they suggest. Therefore, his focus here on “what endures”—in this case, the repetitive, almost mechanized vision of marriage he describes—foreshadows his obsession with things made of iron and steel, even as it also explains his disinterest in “excitement”—a disinterest that will eventually drive Connie away.

●● He seemed alert in the foreground, but the background was like the Midlands atmosphere, haze, smoky mist. And the haze seemed to be creeping forward. So when he stared at Connie in his peculiar way, giving her his peculiar, precise information, she felt all the background of his mind filling up with mist, with nothingness. And it frightened her. It made him seem impersonal, almost to idiocy.

And dimly she realized one of the great laws of the human soul: that when the emotional soul receives a wound shock, which does not kill the body, the soul seems to recover as the body recovers. But this is only appearance. It is really only the mechanism of the reassumed habit. Slow, slowly the wound to the soul begins to make itself felt, like a bruise, which only slowly deepens its terrible ache, till it fills all the psyche.

Related Characters: Lady Constance Chatterley, Sir Clifford Chatterley

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 49

Explanation and Analysis

As Connie adjusts to her Wragby life, she becomes more and more aware of the emotional gap between herself and her husband. Connie believes that Clifford, having suffered a transformative injury to his lower body in World War I, has also received a “wound to the soul.” This framing of Clifford’s pain echoes the contemporary concept of “shell shock,” in which post-war psychologists noticed that many returning soldiers struggled to shake the trauma and anxiety of the battlefield. But it also conflates Clifford’s disability with personal shortcomings (Connie notes that she feels “frightened” at her husband’s “idiocy,” which she attributes to his “wound shock”); this ableist framing will recur throughout the novel, which often sets Clifford’s body up as a target for satirical critique.

Connie’s observation of Clifford here also draws an important link between this baronet and the mining village he profits from. Clifford begins to appear “mechan[ized]” and “impersonal,” just like the mines; while the coal smoke pollutes the air, Clifford’s mind is similarly polluted with “smoky mist.” *Lady Chatterley’s Lover* frequently links its characters to their environment—so if flowers come to symbolize Connie, it follows that the novel associates Clifford (as the novel’s de facto villain) with unnatural “haze” and industrial pollution.

Chapter 5 Quotes

●● All the great words, it seemed to Connie, were cancelled for her generation: love, joy, happiness, home, mother, father, husband, all these great, dynamic words were half dead now, and dying from day-to-day. Home was a place you lived in, love was the thing you didn’t fool yourself about, joy was a word you applied to a good Charleston, happiness was a term of hypocrisy used to bluff other people [...] As for sex, the last of the great words, it was just a cocktail term for an excitement that bucked you up for a while, then left you more raggy than ever. Frayed! It was as if the very material you were made of was cheap stuff, and was fraying out to nothing.

Related Characters: Lady Constance Chatterley, Oliver Mellors, Sir Clifford Chatterley, General Tommy Dukes

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 63

Explanation and Analysis

Though Clifford is obsessed with words, roping Connie into his plans to become a famous short story writer, Connie begins to question whether language retains its meaning for her post-war generation. In particular, Connie feels that words that describe feelings (“love, joy, happiness”) and relationships (“mother, father, husband”) have become “dead,” rendered moot by the pain and pessimism of the last decade. Connie is especially devastated that the words “love” and “sex” can now only refer to momentary, semi-ridiculous excitements, a worldview that the detached Clifford epitomizes.

For everyone from Connie to Mellors to Tommy Dukes, language will be a source of much mistrust and frustration. Importantly, this passage links that frustration not only to loss but to an obsession with capitalist gain. Feelings are now manufactured as “cheap stuff,” easy to get and quick to “fray”; “happiness” and “home” come only from cocktails and fancy houses, things that can be bought and sold rather than found in other people. In other words, rather than seeing language as an inherently corrupt thing, Connie reflects here that language has been ruined by materialist consumerism, “the great words” made “raggy” and meaningless like a cheap toy made too quickly.

Chapter 7 Quotes

☞☞ “There might even be real men, in the next phase,” said Tommy. “Real, intelligent, wholesome men, and wholesome nice women! Wouldn’t that be a change, an enormous change from us? We’re not men, and the women aren’t women. Or only celebrating makeshifts, mechanical and intellectual experiments.”

“Give me the resurrection of the body!” said Dukes. “But it’ll come in time, when we’ve shoved the cerebral stone away a bit, the money and the rest. Then we’ll get a democracy of touch, instead of a democracy of pocket.”

Related Characters: General Tommy Dukes (speaker), Lady Constance Chatterley

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 76

Explanation and Analysis

In a rowdy dinner-table conversation about varying forms of government, Tommy Dukes (and, with less force, Connie) argue that Russian Bolshevism and British capitalism are more ideologically similar than they initially appear. In both cases, Dukes feels that human beings have been turned into something machine-like, obsessed with manufacturing, maximization, and “intellectual experiments.” Though Bolshevism (a strand of communist thought) emphasizes sharing wealth instead of accumulating it, it is still obsessed with “money” and material things above all else; in that sense, a Bolshevik government is just as much a money-centric state (a “democracy of pocket”) as a capitalist one.

Dukes’s call for a “democracy of touch” therefore suggests that an attention to bodily instinct and desire has both personal and political implications. But in addition to highlighting “the resurrection of the body” as key to a new line of societal thinking, Dukes also insists on the necessity of clearly defined, highly differentiated gender roles. He emphasizes the need for “real men,” who are intelligent without being hyper-fixated on “cerebral” pursuits, and for “wholesome nice women,” in contrast to the more androgynous flapper girls who were in vogue during the post-war era. Though many characters share such beliefs, this type of thinking may strike contemporary readers as contradictory, for Dukes’s his open-minded emphasis on sexual passion goes arm in arm with his regressive, stereotypical understanding of gender norms.

Chapter 8 Quotes

☞☞ “Thou still unravished bride of quietness,” [Clifford] quoted.—“It seems to fit flower so much better than Greek vases.”

“Ravished is such a horrid word!” [Connie] said. “It’s only people who ravish things.”

“Oh, I don’t know...snails and things,” he said.

“Even snails only eat them, and bees don’t ravish.”

She was angry with him, turning everything into words. Violets were Juno’s eyelids, and windflowers were unravished brides. How she hated words, always coming between her and life: they did the ravishing, if anything did: ready-made words and phrases, sucking all the life sap out of living things.

Related Characters: Lady Constance Chatterley, Sir Clifford Chatterley (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 97

Explanation and Analysis

While Clifford and Connie are out for a walk in the forested Wragby grounds, Clifford uses a line from John Keats’s poem “Ode on a Grecian Urn” to describe the windflowers (after previously quoting Shakespeare to acknowledge a crop of violets). By reflecting that the plants are “still unravished,” Clifford implies that though the flowers—just growing naturally in the earth—have yet to be plucked, they will eventually be uprooted (“ravished”).

To Connie, Clifford’s disruption of the natural world implicitly links him to the larger disruptions of coalmining and industrialization; like someone picking flowers, Clifford “com[es] between” the usual growth processes of the natural environment. And similarly, Clifford’s inability to have sex with Connie is “coming between her and life.” It is telling that while Clifford is the one to use the phrase “still unravished,” the phrase is also an innuendo; for Connie, this wording is a reminder of (in Sir Malcolm’s words) her status a *demi-vierge*, “unravished” and unattended to in her desires.

Finally, Clifford’s use of language is another manifestation of his tendency to disturb natural life. In Connie’s framing, words are extractive and mechanical, “sucking all the life sap out of living things” just as a coal mine sucks energy from the depths of the earth. Even the process of linguistic description is, to Connie, a form of manufacturing: Clifford “turn[s] everything into words,” making life into a series of

“ready-made” parts for easy understanding and consumption.

Chapter 9 Quotes

☛ [Mrs. Bolton] was coming bit by bit into possession of all that the gentry knew, all that made them upper class: apart from the money [...].

She was thrilled by her contact with a man of the upper class, this tidal gentleman, this author who could write books and poems, and whose photograph appeared in the illustrated newspapers. She was thrilled to a weird passion. And his educating her roused in her passion of excitement and response much deeper than any love affair could have done. In truth the very fact that there could *be* no love affair left her free to thrill to her very marrow with this other passion, the peculiar passion of knowing, knowing as he knew.

Related Characters: Sir Clifford Chatterley, Mrs. Ivy Bolton

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 103

Explanation and Analysis

Though Ivy Bolton has long resented the aristocratic classes for their selfish exploitation of the working-class colliers, she finds herself enchanted by Clifford and the world he has access to. But while Mrs. Bolton experiences a “weird passion” for this representative of “the gentry,” her attraction is explicitly unsexual; the “thrill” she feels around Clifford stems not from his body but from his money and status. On the one hand, then, Mrs. Bolton’s desire represents the ultimate perversion of desire—her “peculiar passion” is not for physical intimacy but for capitalist accumulation.

But on the other hand, Mrs. Bolton’s ability to “possess” everything the gentry has, other than the actual “money” suggests the artificial nature of class hierarchies. Though Clifford and his cohort tend to argue that the divide between the nobility and the colliers that work for them is absolute, Mrs. Bolton can claim almost “all that made them upper class” for herself. There is also a meta-textual bent to Mrs. Bolton’s strange “passion”: just as she can imagine her way into Clifford’s life, D. H. Lawrence, who himself grew up as a miner’s son, gains his own power by imagining himself into the living rooms and bedrooms of these upper-crust characters.

Chapter 10 Quotes

☛ Yet it was spring, and the bluebells were coming in the wood, and the leaf-buds on the hazels were opening like the spatter of green rain. How terrible it was that it should be spring, and everything cold-hearted, cold-hearted. Only the hens, fluffed so wonderfully on the eggs were warm with their hot, brooding female bodies! [...]

Life, life! Pure, sparky, fearless new life! New life! So tiny and so utterly without fear! [...]

Connie was fascinated. And at the same time, never had she felt so acutely the agony of her own female forlornness. It was becoming unbearable.

Related Characters: Lady Constance Chatterley, Oliver Mellors

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 112

Explanation and Analysis

As Connie ends her affair with Michaelis and begins her second year at Wragby, she is struck by the contrast between the natural growth of the world around her and her own malaise. This passage is especially salient because it draws a direct connection between the flowers’ growth—the bluebells “coming in the wood,” the buds “opening like the spatter of green” rain—and the gestation that happens in the first months of pregnancy. Here and elsewhere, the novel emphasizes that both pregnancy and plant growth are forms of renewal, bringing “new life” to families and forests alike.

If the novel began with Connie reflecting on the “ruins” of her nation, the “new life” around her should bring her cheer. But instead of seeing the hens’ pregnancy as a hopeful, practical model for her own path forward, Connie can only compare the birds’ “hot, brooding female bodies” to her own “unbearable” state of forced abstinence. (Interestingly, the bird imagery lingers long after this scene: once Connie does begin having sex with Mellors, she starts to understand her own sexual passion as a “bird” inside of her).

But while this metaphorical framing emphasizes just how natural sexual desire really is, it also again asserts the gendered nature of passion in the novel. The birds are happy because they have embraced (as the novel puts it) “their female bodies”; because Connie has not done that, she feels a distinctly “female forlornness.” By conflating all

these different desires, then, the narrative argues that siloed, essentialized gender roles as an immutable, natural fact, just like the coming of spring.

☛ The fault lay there, out there, in those evil electric lights and diabolical rattlings of engines. There, in the world of the mechanical greedy, greedy mechanism and mechanized greed, sparkling with lights and gushing hot metal and whirring with traffic, there lay the vast evil thing, ready to destroy whatever did not conform. Soon it would destroy the wood, and the bluebells would spring no more. All vulnerable things must perish under the rolling and running of iron.

He thought with infinite tenderness of the woman. Poor thing, she too had some of the vulnerability of the wild hyacinth, she wasn't all tough rubber goods and platinum, like the modern girl. And they would do her in! As sure as life, they would do her in as they do in all naturally tender life. Tender! Somewhere she was tender.

Related Characters: Lady Constance Chatterley, Oliver Mellors

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols:  

Page Number: 124

Explanation and Analysis

After Mellors and Connie have sex for the first time, the narrative shifts to focus on Mellors's perspective, as a late-night walk brings his anxieties to the fore. More than any other character in the novel, Mellors links human "greed" to "mechaniz[ation]"; as people hunger for more and more things to consume, like "rubber goods," industrial production will have to expand, destroying the "vulnerable" natural world. And though Mellors's emotions tend to be extreme, the novel gives credence to his fear that mechanization will upend natural reality: these "evil electric lights" are constantly interrupting the normal rhythms of night and day, while a few scenes later, Clifford's modern, mechanized wheelchair ("the rolling and running of iron") literally destroys the ground it rolls over.

It is also important to note Mellors's emphasis on the word "tender." While "hot metal" and "tough rubber" are a synecdoche for the world of machines, Connie appears more "naturally," as the bluebells and hyacinths do. And just as Mellors praises Connie for her "vulnerability," he also

identifies his own "tenderness" as an important animating principle. This focus on fragility is especially surprising given the events of WWI, in which impenetrable machines destroyed perishable men. So while Mellors laments the inevitability of this destruction—"they would do her in as they do all naturally tender life!"—he still bravely chooses his own fragility and "tenderness" rather than "conform" to the "vast evil" mechanized thing.

☛ She could only wait, wait and moan in spirit as she felt him withdrawing, withdrawing and contracting [...] her womb was open and soft, and slowly clamoring, like a sea anemone under the tide, clamoring for him to come in again and make a fulfillment for her. She clung to him unconscious in passion, and he never quite slipped from her, and she felt the soft bud of him within her stirring, and strange rhythms flushing up into her [...] and she lay there crying in unconscious inarticulate cries. The voice out of the uttermost night, the life! The man heard it beneath him with a kind of awe, as his life sprang out into her. And as it subsided, he subsided too and lay utterly still, unknowing, while her grip on him slowly relaxed, and she lay inert. And they lay and knew nothing, not even of each other, both lost.

Related Characters: Lady Constance Chatterley, Oliver Mellors, Sir Clifford Chatterley, General Tommy Dukes

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 140

Explanation and Analysis

With a great deal of sensory detail, this passage zooms in on the first moment in which Connie and Mellors are able to orgasm at the same time. Connie's experience of this climax is primarily passive: she can "only wait" for Mellors to "withdraw" and "contract," letting him set the "strange rhythms" of their encounter. Crucially, this passivity marks a complete reversal of Connie's teenaged sexual habits, in which she would achieve her orgasm on her own time, while her partner was "merely her tool." However, as is often true in the novel, Connie's passivity—waiting for Mellors to "make a fulfillment for her" instead of seeking one out for herself—brings her a great deal of pleasure and "awe." By associating Connie's newfound sexual enjoyment with her less active role in sex, the narrative once again conflates narrow gender roles (often centered on anatomical descriptions) with happiness.

This scene also reveals why exactly, as several of the characters have reflected, it is so difficult to use language in

sexual situations. Here, pleasure literally takes over Connie's ability to think and speak; her mind is unconscious, her cries of delight "inarticulate." And though Tommy Dukes earlier asserted that there was knowledge in "your belly and your penis," the thing Mellors and Connie learn from this encounter is how to be "lost"; whereas Clifford panics when he is confronted with a lack of knowledge, Connie and Mellors "knew nothing" but remain "relaxed." Clifford's "life of the mind" creates greed and a kind of permanent hunger for more; by contrast, Connie and Mellors find satisfaction in their not-knowing, lying "utterly still" and at peace.

despite Connie's failure to realize it, the process of "blotting" is in fact steadier and more "organic" than Connie's panicked assessment would suggest. Indeed, though Connie ascribes this shift to the carnage of World War I, she has actually only been insulated from the slower, subtler losses because of her place in "the leisured classes." And so the history Connie resents, which sees industrialization as "giant and new" instead of foundational and creeping, is a product of her own privileged viewpoint more than it is a reality.

Chapter 11 Quotes

☞ This is history. One England blots out another. The mines had made the halls wealthy. Now they were blotting them out, as they had already blotted out the cottages. The industrial England blots out the agricultural England. One meaning blots out another. The new England blots out the old England. And the continuity is not organic, but mechanical.

Connie, belonging to the leisured classes, had clung to the remnants of the old England. It had taken her years to realize that it was really blotted out by this terrifying new and gruesome England. That the blotting act would go on till it was complete.

Related Characters: Lady Constance Chatterley

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 165

Explanation and Analysis

As Connie drives through Tevershall and the surrounding mining towns, she is struck by the contrast between the wealthy manors (like Wragby) and the cramped, crowded villages. To Connie, the "agricultural" estates, with their large grounds and lush forests, signal the "old England": of romance and Robin Hood, before industry and coal production transformed the landscape. The loss of that nostalgic world to a post-war modernity marks a particularly "gruesome" form of "history," as mechanization almost violently erases the bucolic life of sprawling estates and charming "cottages" that used to exist (at least in Connie's mind).

But even as Connie contrasts the two visions of England, there is in fact more connective tissue between these two eras than she acknowledges. The halls are only wealth because of the very mines that now "blot" them out. And

☞ Yet Mellors had come from such a father. Not quite. Forty years had made difference, an appalling difference in manhood. The iron and the coal had eaten deep into the bodies and souls of men [...]

Creatures of another reality, they were elementals, serving the elements of coal, as the metal workers were elementals, serving the element of iron. Men not men, but animus of coal and iron and clay. Fauna of the elements, carbon, iron, silicon: elementals. They had perhaps some of the weird, inhuman beauty of minerals, the lustre of coal, the weight and blueness and resistance of iron, the transparency of glass. Elemental creatures, weird and distorted, of the mineral world! They belong to the coal, the iron, the clay, as fish belonged to the sea and worms to dead wood. The anima of mineral disintegration!

Related Characters: Lady Constance Chatterley, Oliver Mellors, Sir Clifford Chatterley

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 169

Explanation and Analysis

When Connie surveys the state of her Midlands home, she is struck by the feeling that "there was no next"—that the mechanized world around her is leading only to doom and collapse, and that the working-class colliers are being subsumed into the machines they toil with. The logic that individuals are informed by their environments is pervasive throughout the narrative: Connie often compares her internal state to the forest or a bird, while Mellors usually frames his new love in terms of flowers. But in this dark passage, Connie feels that just as natural life creates internal life, these "dead" materials are killing off the "bodies and souls" of the men that work with them. Rather than being real human animals, the colliers are "fauna of the elements," reduced to the artificial textures of iron and coal and glass. And because these materials are all inorganic, men are losing their natural "manhood," the instinctive vigor

that Connie and Mellors both value so highly.

It is also worth noting the contradictory ideas about class that Connie parses through in this passage. On the one hand, she uses Mellors's working-class roots to suggest that class is not at all fated or permanent; Mellors represents the height of grace and manhood to Connie, though he "c[a]me from such a [working-class] father." But on the other hand, Connie appears to demonize the colliers for their brutal working conditions, dismissing them as "elementals" and emasculating them ("men not men"). Rather than assigning blame for the horrors of industry to men like Clifford, who actually profit from these mines, Connie here blames the people perhaps most victimized by them.

Chapter 12 Quotes

☞ Oh, and far down inside her the deeps parted and rolled asunder, in long, far travelling billows, and ever, at the quick of her, the depths parted and rolled asunder and she was deeper and deeper and deeper disclosed, and heavier the billows of her rolled away to some shore, uncovering her, and closer and closer plunged the palpable unknown, and further and further whirled the waves of herself away from herself, leaving her, till suddenly, in a soft, shuddering convulsion, the quick of all her plasma was touched, she knew herself touched, the consummation was upon her, and she was gone. She was gone, she was not, and she was born: a woman.

Related Characters: Lady Constance Chatterley, Oliver Mellors

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 184

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, the novel again uses imagery to convey the heaving, oceanic experience of Connie's intercourse with Mellors. To capture the intense illogic of sexual pleasure, the novel breaks with standard grammatical conventions; almost all of this description is a single sentence, broken up with commas to reflect the "billow[ing]," wave-like rhythm of Mellors's penetration. Rather than using words to convey meaning, then, Lawrence merely creates an onomatopoeic "shuddering convulsion"—allowing his readers to feel the same sense of traveling "deeper and deeper and deeper" into the "unknown" of pleasure.

Perhaps even more critically, however, this insight into Connie's experience once more asserts the narrative's suggestion that to be truly a "woman" is to be "gone," to lose

one's sense of self and independence in the physical act of sex. At the beginning of *Lady Chatterley's Lover*, Connie prided herself on her ability to keep her "inner, free self" separate from her sexual partners. But now, she experiences an almost religious renewal by letting herself get "away from herself." As the various characters struggle to move on from the "cataclysms" of the war and rapid industrialization, Connie's reversion to a vulnerable, passive sense of womanhood emerges as the novel's preferred form of being "born" again, cleansed of industrial carnage and mechanized pleasure.

Chapter 13 Quotes

☞ "No, my child! All this is a romantic illusion. Aristocracy is a function, a part of fate. And the masses are functioning of another part of fate. The individual hardly matters. It is a question of which function you are brought up to and adapted to. It is not the individuals that make an aristocracy: it is the functioning of the aristocratic whole. And it is the functioning of the whole mass that makes the common man what he is."

"Then there is no common humanity between us all!"

"Just as you like. We all need to fill our bellies. But when it comes to expressive or executive functioning, I believe there is a gulf and an absolute one, between the ruling and the serving classes. The two functions are opposed. And the functions determine the individual."

Related Characters: Lady Constance Chatterley, Oliver Mellors, Sir Clifford Chatterley, General Tommy Dukes (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 194

Explanation and Analysis

Connie, chafing more and more against the responsibilities of being a "Lady" in the English aristocracy, now attacks Clifford for his continued belief in immutable class divides. Clifford's response is telling for several reasons. First, he dismisses the humanism that Connie, Mellors, and Tommy Dukes hold most dear—he puts no stock in personal traits and desires, arguing that the "individual hardly matters." He even mocks the very bodily instincts Dukes once praised. "We all need to fill our bellies," Clifford scoffs, as if feeding oneself is a waste of time.

But more than that, this argument between Clifford and Connie links two of the central themes in the novel. While

Connie has argued for an understanding of personhood based on instinct, Clifford sees human beings only as cogs in a machine, functioning to serve and preserve “the aristocratic whole.” So, while Connie believes—as Mellors himself proves—that an individual can change their life when they follow their instincts, Clifford sees human beings as powerless against the “absolute gulf” created by wealth and status. In other words, Clifford denies instinct and individuality because it allows him to deny the reality of human agency. And after all, as a member of the “ruling” class, Clifford benefits from the lower classes not having agency to change their quality of life.

elaborate words to style himself as an “adventurer,” bringing “civilization” to his family’s long-manicured ground through the “weird wheeled ship” that is his wheelchair. But the hyperbolic, parodic tone makes it clear that Clifford is not like the heroes in his beloved poetry. Instead—in one of the novel’s most explicitly ableist passages—he is “motionless and cautious,” impotent because of his injury. By using the very poetry Clifford extols against him, the novel chides Clifford for his lack of adventurousness and once again suggests that language is untrustworthy, giving a sense of grandeur to men who actually possess none.

Chapter 14 Quotes

☛ And the chair began to advance slowly, joltingly down the beautiful broad riding over with blue encroaching hyacinths. Oh last of all ships, through the hyacinths in shallows! Opinions on the last wild waters, sailing in the last voyage of our civilization! Wither, oh weird wheeled ship, your slow course steering. Quiet and complacent, Clifford sat at the wheel of adventure: in his old black hat and tweed jacket, motionless and cautious. Oh captain, my Captain, our splendid trip is done! Not yet though! Downhill in the wake, came Constance in her grey dress, watching the chair jolt downwards.

Related Characters: Lady Constance Chatterley, Oliver Mellors, Sir Clifford Chatterley

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols:  

Page Number: 196

Explanation and Analysis

While Connie surreptitiously flirts with Mellors, Clifford steers his mechanized wheelchair across the Wragby grounds, not noticing (or perhaps not caring) as he crushes “hyacinths” and other flowers. This scene is important because it makes literal so much of the novel’s symbolism. Here, technology (Clifford’s wheelchair) is literally crushing nature (the flowers); Mellors earlier reflected that “all vulnerable things must perish under the rolling and running of iron,” and now Clifford’s iron chair rolls and runs.

But the most noticeable detail in this passage is its satirical use of heightened language. This intentionally over-the-top description recalls epic verses from Shakespeare and—in the “oh captain, my Captain” line—directly quotes the romantic poetry of Walt Whitman; Clifford uses these

☛ “Did you hate Clifford?” She said at last. “Hate him, no! I’ve met too many like him to upset myself hating him. I know beforehand I don’t care for his sort, and I let it go at that.”

“What is his sort?”

“Nay, you know better than I do. The sort of youngish gentleman a bit like a lady, and no balls.”

“What balls? Balls! A man’s balls!”

She pondered this.

“But is it a question of that?” she said, a little annoyed.

“You say a man’s got no brain, when he’s a fool: and no heart, when he’s mean; and no stomach when he’s a funkier. And when he’s got none of that spunky wild bit of a man in him, you say he’s got no balls when he’s sort of tame.”

Related Characters: Lady Constance Chatterley, Oliver Mellors (speaker), Sir Clifford Chatterley

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 208

Explanation and Analysis

After Clifford’s chair breaks down and Mellors is forced to help his Lord back to Wragby manor, Connie wonders how Mellors stands his unfair boss. In this exchange, Mellors defines gender primarily in anatomical terms—real men are “spunky” and “wild,” sentiments that he locates in the physical fact of their testicles. Implicitly, then, Mellors defines masculinity through men’s sexual potency, seeing manhood as the ability to impregnate women and thus to be dominant rather than “tame.” More than just denigrating Clifford because he is “a bit like a lady,” Mellors makes

personality as a whole a question of anatomy—he locates kindness in the heart and cowardice in the belly (using the slang term “funker” to signify a lack of bravery). This passage, then, takes Mellors’s focus on the physical body to a new extreme: rather than merely celebrating biology as natural, Mellors here sees it as determinative of personality and fate.

“So proud!” she murmured, uneasy. “And so lordly! Now I know why men are so overbearing! But he’s lovely, *really*. Like another being! A bit terrifying! But lovely really! And he came to *me*!”—She caught her lower lip between her teeth, in fear and excitement.

The man looked down in silence at the tense phallos, that did not change [...]. “Tha ma’es nowt o’ me, John Thomas. Art boss? of me? Eh well, tha’rt more cocky than me, an’ that says less. John Thomas! Dost want *her*? Dost want my Lady Jane? [...] Tell Lady Jane tha wants cunt. John Thomas, an’ th’ cunt o’ Lady Jane!”

Related Characters: Lady Constance Chatterley, Oliver Mellors (speaker)

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 223

Explanation and Analysis

As Connie and Mellors grow more comfortable with each other, she allows herself to admire his naked body with the same open lust that he has long displayed with her. Her “fear” at Mellors’s “erect penis” hints that, within the framework of the novel, a real man is “overbearing” and “terrifying,” unlike the more mild-mannered Clifford.

But of more importance here is the way the illicit couple now nicknames their genitalia (Mellors’s penis becomes “John Thomas,” while Connie’s vagina becomes “Lady Jane”). In using the title “Lady” for Connie’s vagina, Mellors at once valorizes the naked body as a source of pleasure and power and mocks the aristocratic terms of “Lady” and “Lord.” Furthermore, Mellors speaks in dialect and uses the word “cunt” alongside his playful “Lady Jane” nickname, making upper-crust titles conform and transform to fit the working-class rhythms of Midlands speech. Implicitly, the way Mellors plays with language here thus demonstrates the power of sexual praise and desire. In this bed, class distinctions and language itself are subsumed into the most basic, primal instinct: Mellors and Connie come together sexually, with John Thomas finding his Lady Jane.

Chapter 15 Quotes

“And he stuck flowers in the hair of his own body, and wound a bit of creeping-jenny round his penis, and stuck a single bell of a hyacinth in his naval. She watched him with amusement, his odd intentness. And she pushed a campion flower in his mustache, where it stuck, dangling under his nose. “This is John Thomas marryin’ Lady Jane,” he said. “And we mun let Constance an’ Oliver go their separate ways. Maybe—” [...] “Maybe what? Go on with what you were going to say,” she insisted.

“Ay, what was I going to say?”

He had forgotten. And it was one of the great disappointments of her life, that he never finished.

Related Characters: Lady Constance Chatterley, Oliver Mellors (speaker), Sir Clifford Chatterley, Hilda

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 242

Explanation and Analysis

Shortly before Hilda arrives to cart Connie off to Venice, Connie and Mellors share a long night together, dancing in the rain before cuddling in the bed. In this scene, flowers, an important symbol in the novel for vulnerability and natural “tenderness,” become a shared language of care for the two lovers. Rather than running over the flowers (as Clifford does) or sticking them in a vase (as Connie does whenever she goes back to Wragby), Mellors and Connie do not bring the flowers in contact with metal or glass. Instead, they merely celebrate the nature outside by intertwining it with their own natural bodies, signifying that neither their flesh nor the flowers themselves need anything additional to be worth admiration.

Mellors’s strange trailing off (“maybe—”) is also worth attention. While he is able to talk, in dialect, about the marriage between his and Connie’s genitalia, Mellors struggles to articulate the depth of his commitment to her in more serious terms. Or at least that’s one way to read this “forgotten” comment—as Connie’s “great disappointment” reflects, the meaning of whatever Mellors was going to say, which might have been touching or irrelevant or hurtful, is lost.

As always, this lack of language between Mellors and Connie is important: there are always unknowns and questions, gaps in the “complete intimacy” that Hilda will later claim to crave. But while Connie feels disappointed at

the things they fail to communicate with each other, this “maybe—” also holds promise and potential, a mystery that will tie Connie to Mellors. Whereas Clifford is an open book to Connie, known and therefore unexciting, there is always something with Mellors that has yet to be “finished.”

Chapter 16 Quotes

“But you’ll be through with him in a while,” [Hilda] said, “and then you’ll be ashamed of having been connected with him. One can’t mix up with the working people.”

“But you were such a socialist! You’re always on the side of the working classes.”

“I may be on their side in a political crisis, but being on their side makes me know how impossible it is to mix one’s life with theirs. Not out of snobbery, but just because the whole rhythm is different.”

Hilda had lived among the real political intellectuals, so she was disastrously unanswerable.

Related Characters: Lady Constance Chatterley, Oliver Mellors, Sir Clifford Chatterley, Hilda (speaker)

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 256

Explanation and Analysis

Like Connie, Hilda was raised by an artistic father and a socialist mother; both sisters were aware of their father’s working-class roots and were taught at an early age to contest the sharp stratifications of English society. Hilda’s hypocrisy thus comes as a surprise: despite spending time with “the real political intellectuals” (her soon-to-be-ex-husband included), Hilda is just as bigoted as Clifford and his cronies. This satirical depiction of Hilda also hints at an important political claim: no amount of socialist talk can make an upper-class person legitimately “on the side” of less wealthy folks; only intimacy like the kind Connie shares with Mellors can really change minds.

Though Hilda insists that “the whole rhythm [of life] is different” for working-class people, the novel’s depiction of Connie and Mellors’s love affair contests this assertion—not only in content but in form. Connie and Mellors quite literally move in sync, orgasming at the same time and getting caught up in each other’s sexual rhythms; similarly, Lawrence’s prose becomes onomatopoeic and fluid, mimicking the shared tempo of Connie’s intercourse with her less-wealthy lover. More than just revealing Hilda’s

narrow-mindedness, then, this passage also demonstrates just how wrong she is—and how essential sex can be in allowing people of different backgrounds to truly “mix.”

“It cost her an effort to let him have his way and his will of her. She had to be a passive, consenting thing, like a slave, a physical slave. Yet the passion licked round her, consuming, and when the sensual flame of it pressed through her bowels and breast, she really thought she was dying: yet a poignant, marvelous death.

[...] She felt a triumph, almost a vainglory. So! That was how it was! That was life! That was how oneself really was! There was nothing left to disguise or be ashamed of. She shared her ultimate nakedness with a man, another being.

Related Characters: Lady Constance Chatterley, Oliver Mellors, General Tommy Dukes

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 263

Explanation and Analysis

Just before Connie heads to Venice, she and Mellors spend one last night together. As she describes having sex, Connie now equates her pleasure and “triumph” not only with passivity but with submission—she becomes Mellors’s “slave,” seeing this subjection as the only way to release her artificial “disguises” and “shames.” Perhaps more than any other passage, this realization encapsulates the novel’s assertion that sex is best when women are submissive and men are dominant.

Interestingly, however, Connie contradicts herself about where this gender divide comes from. On the one hand, she claims that this how “oneself really was”; on the other hand, she admits that it “cost her an effort” to become so submissive (“this passive, consenting thing”). As many feminist critics have pointed out, if this gendered form of “slave[ry]” is Connie’s “ultimate” natural state, why is it such hard work for her to get there?

It is also worth noting how much knowledge Connie acquires from this “passion” with Mellors. “That was how it was,” she concludes, “that was life!” Just as Tommy Dukes once argued that real knowledge was in “your belly and your penis,” Connie now gains a new understanding of what life actually means through the “poignant, marvelous death” of orgasm.

Chapter 18 Quotes

☞☞ “Shall I tell you?” [Connie] said, looking into his face. “Shall I tell you what you have that other men don't have, and that will make the future? Shall I tell you? [...] It's the courage of your own tenderness, that's what it is: like when you put your hand on my tail and say I've got a pretty tail.”

Related Characters: Lady Constance Chatterley (speaker), Oliver Mellors, Sir Clifford Chatterley

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 295

Explanation and Analysis

When Connie tells Mellors that she is pregnant with his child, the game-keeper's reaction is one of anxiety more than excitement; after all, this is a man who believes that “all vulnerable things must perish under the rolling and running of iron.” To convince her beloved that their baby is something to celebrate, Connie reframes that vulnerability, arguing that “tenderness” is not a liability but a “courage[ous]” strength. And if the novel defines Mellors's masculinity through his lust and sexual potency, Connie argues that such power is grounded in her lover's “tender” admiration for Connie's body, his embrace and attention to the “pretty” features of their shared natural world.

But if this is a deeply personal conversation, it is also a political one. For the first time after the “cataclysm” of World War I, Connie is here intentionally trying to “make the future” according to a certain template; now, she is learning how to do the “hard work” she envisioned in the narrative's very first passage. And in contrast to Clifford's efforts to write and invent his way into the future, Connie believes in moving forward with sexual caring (“when you put your hand on my tail”) and “tenderness,” with moments that are intuited instead of created.

Chapter 19 Quotes

☞☞ Clifford was not inwardly surprised to get this letter. Inwardly, he had known for a long time she was leaving him. But he had absolutely refused any outward admission of it. Therefore, outwardly, it came as the most terrible blow and shock to him. He had kept the surface of his confidence in her quite serene.

And that is how we are. By strength of will we cut off our inner intuitive knowledge from admitted consciousness. This causes a state of dread, or apprehension, which makes the blow ten times worse when it does fall. Clifford was like a hysterical child.

Related Characters: Lady Constance Chatterley, Sir Clifford Chatterley, Mrs. Ivy Bolton

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 307

Explanation and Analysis

When Clifford finds out that Connie is leaving him for another man, he feels completely taken by surprise—despite having sensed “inwardly” that such a thing was certain to occur. Clifford's use of “force” to cut off his “inner intuitive knowledge” mirrors all the other ways in which he separates himself from nature; just as he listens to his radio rather than paying attention to his wife, Clifford creates artificial confidence rather than pay attention to his feelings.

But Clifford is not alone in this “cut off” state; fascinatingly, the narrative uses the pronoun “we” to describe this pattern of being, implicating both the omniscient, unnamed narrator and the novel's readers. This “we” acts as a sort of call to action—by showing Clifford's tragic fate and implicating readers in that “dread” and “apprehension,” the novel also suggests another way forward, where intuition is “admitted” and followed instead of pressed down.

Finally, this passage is notable because of the way it uses gender norms to demonize Clifford's pained reaction to Connie's betrayal. The word “hysterical” was, at that time, used to pathologize women's anxieties and griefs, specifically around sex; by using that word to refer to Clifford, the novel paints him as both crazy and unmasculine, perhaps even conflating those two traits.

●● If things go on as they are, there's nothing lies in the future but death and destruction, for these industrial masses. I feel my inside turn to water sometimes, and there you are, going to have a child by me. But never mind. All the bad times that ever have been, haven't been able to blow the crocus out: not even the love of women. You can't insure against the future, except by really believing in the best bit of you, and in the power beyond it. So I believe in the little flame between us.

Related Characters: Oliver Mellors (speaker), Lady Constance Chatterley

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 321

Explanation and Analysis

Lady Chatterley's Lover ends with an extended letter from Mellors to Connie, unusual for two characters who seem to distrust language so much. But by grounding the novel's final moments in Mellors's perspective, Lawrence is able to

leave his readers with a message of real optimism. Though Mellors (the story's most anxious character) feels "there's nothing" in the future besides the "death and destruction" of mechanization, he still finds something—"the little flame" of his desire and caring for Connie—to "believe" in.

In fighting through his doomsday mindset to prepare for his child, Mellors thus accomplishes the goals the novel establishes at its beginning. From his job on a farm, he acknowledges "the ruins" of technological life while also having "new little hopes"; as he tends the livestock and the crops, he literally "builds up new little habitats," preparing a sort of natural sanctuary for Connie and their child to live in. After pollution and war have swept through the country, Mellors is smart enough to know that "you can't insure against the future." All he can do is believe that some flowers (the "crocus" not yet destroyed) will keep growing, and that he can pass down the "flame" he shares with Connie to the next generation their love has created—and nature, somehow, will persist.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

CHAPTER 1

"Ours is essentially a tragic age," Constance Chatterley thinks, "so we refuse to take it tragically." But this is no small feat for Constance: World War I has just ended, leaving destruction in its wake, and Clifford Chatterley, the soldier Constance married in 1917, has come back wounded only six months after their wedding day. Though Clifford's recovery was impressive, he is forever paralyzed from the waist down.

Now it is 1920, and Clifford—having just lost his father—has returned to Wragby Hall, newly made a baronet. Wragby is in the Midlands, and Clifford is proud of the expansive, "melancholy" park he has inherited. Clifford has a mechanized **wheelchair** that allows him to move around his property, and he dresses expensively and with taste. But though he is proud of surviving and grateful to be alive, there is also something unfeeling about him, as if much of his emotional life was wounded along with his body.

Constance, by contrast, is full of energy. She looks like a country girl and has a soft voice, though in actuality, her father, Sir Malcolm Reid, is a prominent R.A.; while Constance's mother was alive, she traveled in prominent socialist circles. Constance and her sister Hilda were therefore raised on art in Paris and Rome, and on socialist politics in Berlin. When Constance was 15, she and Hilda were sent to Dresden, Germany to learn music. While there, the sisters would go into the forests with whatever young men pleased them

The boys would play songs and debate, and eventually, Hilda and Constance slept with the boys whose eloquence most impressed them. For both sisters, "it was the talk that mattered supremely"; "love was only a minor accompaniment." But the boys always wanted sex, so Constance would give in—even as she vowed to never give up her internal, free life to a lover. Constance thus makes sure to always allow her lover to orgasm before she does, as that way, she can "achieve her orgasm and her crisis while he was merely her tool." Still, neither Hilda nor Constance feel that sex ever compares to conversation.

The novel begins with tragedy, both on a global scale (the mass death and poverty inflicted by World War I) and on an intimate scale (Clifford's paralyzed body). Constance's refusal to embrace the catastrophe around her immediately sets her up in contrast to her surroundings; unlike Clifford, whose every moment will forever be shaped by war, Constance is determined to continue on with as much normalcy as possible.



As a baronet, Clifford is a low-ranking member of the British aristocracy; baronets were referred to as "Sir," while their wives were known as "ladies." The Midlands are a region in the geographical center of England, once famous in British folklore for its pastoral beauty. It is important to note that the novel treats Clifford's emotional trauma with sympathy here, a perspective that will change as Constance gets more and more frustrated with her Wragby life.



Even in her youth, Constance is associated with forests: she looks like a country girl (despite her city background), and some of her happiest memories take place in the forests of Dresden, where she spent her teenage years. The fact that Constance's father is an R.A. (Royal Academician) suggests that he is one of the most respected visual artists in the nation, as only 100 artists at a time could ever be named to this prestigious position.



As a young person, Constance values "talk" over physical "love," or sex; in many ways, the novel centers on the way this value system changes as Constance gets older. But in this moment, Constance particularly prides herself on her ability to maintain control during sex, using her partner as a "tool" for her own pleasure. In other words, while Constance's philosophical conversations can be passionate and unrestrained, her approach to sex—arguably one of the most instinctive, natural human behaviors—is transactional, even almost mechanical.



Sir Malcolm and his wife knew their daughters were having sex—it made the women look softer and more rounded, just as it made their young male partners seem quieter and more inward. But neither parent did anything to stop it, so the affairs continued. Hilda and Constance were always able to manage their feelings, though the men they slept with would often bare their full souls during sex (only to resent their girlfriends afterwards).

In 1914, soon after their mother died, Hilda and Constance rushed home to avoid war. Both of their German lovers died, and the sisters wept and then promptly forgot these lovers. Indeed, as soon as they were back in London, the girls started socializing with Cambridge students, who talked about anarchy and wrote philosophical essays. Hilda quickly married a man she met in this group, though he was ten years older than her.

Constance (or Connie, as she is often called) grew close with Clifford Chatterley, a young man only a few years older than her. Clifford, a minor aristocrat, had been studying the science behind coalmining when war interrupted. But Connie's self-assurance and wide scope of knowledge impressed him, especially because she was able to function outside of the small, upper-class circles where they had met.

Though Clifford embodied aristocratic values, he also scorned everything around him as ridiculous: his father, the government, even the deadly war itself. In 1916, Clifford's older brother was killed, leaving him as the heir to Wragby and his father's title—and this, too, felt ridiculous to Clifford. Clifford's father Sir Geoffrey hated his son's casual attitude, and he hoped Clifford would become more serious about Wragby and its traditional ways.

Clifford had grown up with his older brother and an older sister, Emma. At first, the three siblings had vowed to live together forever at Wragby, isolated from the rest of the country. But after his older brother's death, Clifford married Connie (much to Emma's chagrin), and the newlyweds set off on a honeymoon. Though Clifford and Connie did have sex on their travels, both of them viewed it as an afterthought, useful mostly for having children. But then Clifford went to war and returned home "smashed"—unable to conceive a child or even have sex. And soon after, Sir Geoffrey passed away, too.

Perhaps unusually for a man in the early 20th century, Sir Malcolm seems to have a relaxed, liberal attitude to his daughters' premarital sex. The connection here between women's rounded curves—which the narrative paints as an outward manifestation of femininity—and their sexual maturity will recur throughout the novel.



On the one hand, this passage makes it clear how much the war has taken from Constance: not only did WWI leave Clifford profoundly wounded, but the fighting also killed Constance's first love. On the other hand, the sisters' ability to move on so quickly suggests that relationships founded on "talk" are never very permanent or meaningful.



Just as Malcolm empowered Constance and Hilda to have sex when they chose to, he also gives his daughters full agency over whom they marry—so when Constance winds up with Clifford Chatterley, it is of her own accord. Clifford's early interest in coalmining will become an increasingly vital part of his personality, though when Constance first meets him, Clifford is more enchanted by politics than technology.



Clifford's nihilism, or his sense that everything is ridiculous, was a common post-war feeling, especially among young men who returned from the fighting to broken economies and grieving nations. Clifford's lack of investment in either the future or the past stands in stark contrast to his father's pride in the nation, as epitomized by Sir Geoffrey's connection to the centuries-old Wragby manor.



Fascinatingly, this chapter contains more plot than almost the rest of the narrative combined. In ending this brief summary of Connie's early life with a description of Clifford's losses—his damaged legs, his "smashed" fertility, his dead father—the novel also shows how Connie's life has been subsumed into her husband's grief. In other words, despite Connie's refusal to live "tragically," tragedy has entered her life, nevertheless.



CHAPTER 2

When Connie and Clifford moved in, Emma Chatterley left, not wanting to interact with her new sister-in-law. So now, it is just the young couple in this big, dreary house. Worse still, Wragby is adjacent to the Tevershall mine, which produces constant smoke, stinking of sulfur and coal. And Tevershall village is no better, with its small, cramped colliers' houses turning black from the haze. At night, Connie can see the mine's furnaces glowing.

Still, Connie does not protest her new circumstances, as she knows there is no getting out of them. Instead, she learns to accept the strange separation between Tevershall village and Wragby: there is no contact between the two groups except mutual resentment, not because of any personal slights but because of a general sense that the people have nothing in common with each other. Even when the local women pretend to fawn over Connie, she can feel their disdain.

Clifford does his best to avoid the townspeople, treating them only with contempt whenever he sees them. At the same time, despite his haughty outward manner and his expensive clothes, Connie can tell that Clifford is deeply ashamed of his wounded body. And though Clifford bonds with Connie (and depends on her completely), he struggles to forge relationships with other people; the miners are effectively his employees, but he views them as "parts of the pit rather than parts of life."

To alleviate his boredom, Clifford starts writing sharply observed, emotionally detached short stories. His stories appear in the best magazines and garner a mix of praise and criticism, though Clifford only wants praise. Clifford talks about his stories in detail with Connie, who loves these conversations—so much that they almost replace sex for her. Connie cares more about these conversations than other elements of life at Wragby, so she declines to make any renovations to her new home (much to Emma's delight).

When Sir Malcolm comes, he points out that Clifford's stories are empty of emotion or real weight, which upsets Connie. Malcolm also tells Clifford he does not want Connie to become a "demi-vierge": a half-virgin. Clifford resents this comment, even as he knows there is some truth in it. Still, try as he might, he cannot bring himself to have an honest conversation with Connie about their sexual predicament.

The mechanized mines around Connie and Clifford now come to seem threatening; indeed, the sulfur smell and furnace lights suggest that Wragby is a literal hellscape. It is also important that the mines' lights disrupt the natural rhythm of day and night, hinting at just how deeply mining culture has thrown nature off its course. A collier is a British slang word for a miner.



Though Connie was raised on her mother's socialist ideas, in practice, she seems—at least at this point in this novel—to take no real issue with being at the top of this unequal class hierarchy. Instead, Connie at first treats class as an immutable divide, more a character trait than a result of circumstance.



Whereas Connie accepts class as a neutral fact, Clifford uses his high status and wealth to compensate for his physical insecurities. On the one hand, Clifford dresses in expensive clothes, as if to distract from his wounds; on the other hand, Clifford denies humanity to the miners whose physical strength makes him wealthy. In other words, Clifford works to define power not as bodily but as financial, elevating himself above all the unwounded, working-class men in "the pit."



Connie's interest in Clifford's short stories parallels her relationship with her Dresden lover, in which she prioritized talk over all physical intimacy. Though Connie's lack of interest in renovating Wragby pleases Emma, it also demonstrates her lack of interest in building a real future for herself at this estate.



Clifford's stories are verbose and impressive, but as Sir Malcolm—himself a greatly respected artist—notes, these stories lack true feeling. And similarly, though Connie and Clifford talk endlessly about fictional phrases and plot structures, they cannot address the most intimate, bodily realities of their situation with each other.



To pass the time, Connie goes for walks in the park, taking in the autumn leaves and the **flowers** in spring. She plays hostess to the intellectual men that Clifford invites to Wragby, all of whom like Connie but refuse to take her seriously because of her curvy, “feminine” body, unusual for the fashions of her era. Clifford’s older relatives are kind, if sometimes condescending. So, time goes on “as the clock does, half-past eight instead of half-past seven.”

The curves of Connie’s body are important: the novel is set at the height of 1920s flapperdom, when thin, androgynous body types were considered stylish, so Connie’s frame marks her as belonging to an earlier time, which embraced different gender norms. This striking closing line hints at how devoid of meaning Connie’s life is: time is passing, but the only thing different in Connie’s life is the position of the clock hands.



CHAPTER 3

As time passes, Connie begins to feel increasingly restless, though she will not admit this feeling even to herself. Sometimes she goes to the woods just to get out of Wragby, though she feels “no connection” with nature—or with anything, for that matter. Concerned, Sir Malcolm suggests that Connie should take a lover.

Just as Clifford seems to be permanently shellshocked by his time in WWI, Connie now shows some of the same emptiness and remove. As always, Sir Malcolm believes that sex and physical intimacy are the only remedies visceral enough to counteract this kind of intellectual ennui.



That winter, a young Irishman named Michaelis comes to stay at Wragby. Michaelis is a playwright, acclaimed across the U.K. and the U.S. for his satirical plays, most of which poke fun at rich people. Because of this subject matter, London’s high society refuses to engage with Michaelis. Still, his work has made him wealthy (he has an impressive house and great clothes)—and for men like Clifford, a friendship with Michaelis might be helpful publicity. Connie is impressed with Clifford’s strategic thinking, though she resents his obsession with “the bitch-goddess” of success.

Though the novel has thus far presented Clifford primarily as harmed and harmless, his assessment of Michaelis shows Clifford’s calculated approach to status and fame. It is interesting that the concept of success is gendered female, as “the bitch-goddess”; this terminology makes success at once seem tempting (“goddess”) and unkind (“bitch”), a dichotomy to which the men in Connie’s life will hold Connie.



Clifford turns his nose up at Michaelis, who is clearly an outsider in proper society. But Connie finds herself drawn to him, with his strange mix of disillusionment and a childlike desire to fit in. Sometimes, Connie even finds Michaelis handsome, comparing his face to the “timelessness which the Buddha aims at, and which negros express sometimes” as a result of “race destiny.” Michaelis senses Connie’s attraction—and he has had affairs with Englishwomen before.

Connie is drawn to Michaelis because he lacks the very hereditary status that Clifford possesses (and that has trapped Connie into being a “Lady”). Lawrence’s allusions to “race destiny”—and his derogatory descriptions of Black features elsewhere—are a hallmark of his work, which is frequently criticized for its overt racism.



One day, Connie invites a bored Michaelis up to her sitting-room. The two sit by the fire, discussing their families and Michaelis’s status as a “lonely bird.” Again, Connie is struck by how the man can at once see “everything” and seem so much like an infant; she feels her attraction for Michaelis in her “womb.”

Connie’s conflation of attraction with “bird”-like vulnerability hints at one of the novel’s major thematic ideas: like a bird, sex is both a part of nature and something fragile, beautiful but hard to capture.



Michaelis asks to hold Connie's hand, and she gives in, moved by his almost hypnotic power. Soon, the two are having sex. Afterwards, Michaelis is convinced that Connie will "hate" him, while Connie feels no remorse; her only concern is keeping the affair from Clifford. Connie assures Michaelis that she thinks he is "nice," and this cheers him greatly.

It is interesting to note how little courtship there is between Connie and Michaelis; even after they have had sex with each other, the most effusive compliment Connie gives Michaelis is that he is "nice." Unlike with Clifford, then, physical attraction seems to take precedence here over good conversation.



At lunch, Clifford is critical of Michaelis. Privately, Connie respects that Michaelis is unscrupulous about pursuing success, whereas Clifford is so timid. When Michaelis appears, holding **flowers** and looking sad, Connie reflects that she is in love with him. With her lover nearby, it takes all her energy just to stay focused on her embroidery. Later that evening, Connie promises to meet Michaelis again in his room.

Though Connie does not explicitly make this connection, Michaelis's aggressive approach to success (feminized as the "bitch-goddess") is akin to his aggressive sexual desire. Meanwhile, Clifford's more hesitant grabs at success reflect his sexual impotency.



Michaelis looks especially childlike when he is naked and excited during sex; he always orgasms first, leaving Connie unsatisfied. Fortunately, Connie soon learns to use Michaelis's still-erect penis to have her own orgasm, even after he has finished. When Michaelis leaves Wragby, the affair continues via letters and occasional meetups in London. Back at Wragby, Connie is more cheerful than ever, and her new demeanor fills Clifford with joy.

Though Connie appears to be more attracted to Michaelis than she was to her Dresden lovers, she still has some of the same sexual habits: rather than giving herself over to the sensations of sex with Michaelis, she uses him as a "tool" to achieve her own orgasm. This utilitarian approach to sexual pleasure, especially when it comes from women, will be the subject of much critique in the novel.



CHAPTER 4

Connie knows that her affair with Michaelis (or Mick, as some call him), is doomed, especially since his whole personality is built on his isolated, outsider status. Besides, there are now new regular visitors to Wragby: General Tommy Dukes, astronomer Charles May, and a man called Hammond, another writer. All of these men prioritize "the life of the mind," believing that other things—money, love, sex—are secondary.

"The life of the mind" is a useful shorthand for the physically distant, talkative life Connie and Clifford share with each other. The commitment that Dukes, May and Hammond have to their mental pursuits reflect their privilege—only because they have money and sex at their disposal can they dismiss these necessities so easily.



Now, the men are arguing about the "sexual problem." Hammond is still mad about the time May tried to flirt with Hammond's wife, prompting Dukes to argue that Hammond sees women primarily as a means of bolstering his own reputation. May, on the other hand, believes that sex—like money—is a necessary evil if one is to truly have access to focused thought. May thus argues for promiscuity, annoying Hammond.

Just as Connie and Hilda articulated a utilitarian approach to sex when they were with their Dresden men, Hammond, May, and Duke now do the same thing, believing that intercourse is less about pleasure or intimacy than it is about material (or intellectual) gain.



Dukes begins to wonder if sex is just another form of communication, only using bodies instead of words. When pressed, Clifford will only say that he thinks sex can “perfect” preexisting intimacy; he is embarrassed by the whole conversation. Connie listens in, and though she never says anything, she knows the men depend on her presence for their conversation to really flow. She dislikes Hammond and May; she likes Dukes, but none of them compare to Michaelis.

Connie, too, cares about the life of the mind, even if she finds that these men put too much emphasis on it. On another evening, Dukes discusses the difference between mental prowess and real knowledge, which he argues stems from “your belly and your penis as much as your brain.” Dukes believes that severing the body from the mind is inorganic, like “a plucked apple.”

The conversation turns to Bolshevism, which Dukes believes is the most mechanical philosophy of all; in both Bolshevism and capitalist industry, Dukes feels, men become mechanized (“our deepest feelings we force according to certain ideas. We drive ourselves with a formula, like machines”). In his opinion, then, Bolshevik Russia is the only country that is honest about its human machinery.

Dukes even reveals that he does not believe in love—not when it is concerned with property and success (as Hammond’s marriage is), nor when it is about sex between the androgynous-looking young people of the post-war era. Connie breaks into the conversation, arguing that there are still some nice women—and the men are frustrated that she has been listening in, despite the fact that she is sitting right there.

CHAPTER 5

One morning in February, Clifford and Connie go for a walk through the park. A haze of sulfur hangs over the forest, and most of the birds have been killed off during the war. Still, Clifford loves these old oak trees, which have been around since Robin Hood’s time. With Connie guiding, Clifford rolls his **wheelchair** up a hill, coming to a clearing; this is one of the areas that Sir Geoffrey deforested to provide “trench timber.” The chopped-down trees always make Clifford angry.

Though Clifford and his friends pride themselves on their dexterity with words, Connie intuits that real connection relies on things that cannot be articulated—her silent presence is instinctively needed, even if no one in the room could put words to why that is the case.



In this vital passage, Dukes emphasizes not only how “inorganic” or unnatural the modern way of life is—a common rallying cry in the novel—but also how many different forms of knowledge there really are. In Dukes’s formulation, the physical instincts of hunger and desire are just as key to truth and understanding as any theory or literature might be.



At this moment, Bolshevism (a strain of Communism) was spreading through Russia; Bolsheviks aimed for industrial production at grand scales and to erase all forms of human difference, whether of class or gender or religion. But while Bolshevism is one form of mechanized philosophy, Dukes (like the novel) knows that the mines outside Wragby are no less mechanical.



While the men argue about their less traditional views of sex and romance, their expectations of women are far from progressive—Connie is expected to be seen and not heard, even among these supposedly modern men.



This description contrasts the technological present (“a haze of sulfur,” Clifford’s mechanized wheelchair, the gaps where Sir Geoffrey cut trench timber) with the old oak trees and the romantic history they represent. In particular, the folkloric figure of Robin Hood—who wooed women courageously and redistributed wealth across the Midlands—throws into relief how much this place, now capitalist and unromantic, has changed.



While Connie listens to the sounds of a nearby mine, Clifford muses that his forest is “really the heart of England.” Clifford admits that being in the forest, with its mysterious links to old England, always makes him want a son. Clifford desires continuity, seeing himself as “a link in a chain” of old traditions, though Connie does not like to view herself in this way. Still, Clifford presses on, even suggesting that Connie could have a child with another man if she would be willing to raise it as Clifford’s own.

Connie is surprised that Clifford would condone an affair, but Clifford explains that what matters is “what endures”—the “lifelong” marriage they share, not an “occasional spasm.” Connie lets her mind wander to Michaelis. Though she is deeply attracted to him, she has never entertained the idea of leaving Clifford for Michaelis; now, she wonders about conceiving a child for Wragby with the Irish writer.

Clifford pushes Connie to agree that casual sex is less important than years-long matrimony. But while Connie sees the logic, she struggles with the idea that she will be “pinned down” forever by her thoughts in a single moment. Just then, a brown spaniel runs by, followed by a man with a gun. The man surprises Connie, like “the sudden rush of a threat out of nowhere.” Connie learns that this is Oliver Mellors, Clifford’s new gamekeeper.

Though Mellors has been at Wragby for eight months, this is the first time he and Connie have met. When they make eye contact, Connie feels shy; there is something about Mellors that is difficult to pin down. Sometimes he presents himself as a gentleman, and sometimes he speaks with the broad dialect of country people. Connie cannot tell if Mellors is teasing her.

Mellors begins pushing Clifford, in his **wheelchair**, back towards the house, and Connie runs ahead to open the gate. Though Clifford does not notice that anything is wrong, Mellors immediately sees how tired Connie looks. Connie is amazed by how Mellors seems to see “everything”; unlike Clifford, he is “aware of her.”

Clifford’s determination to be “a link in a chain” ignores the “cataclysm” that the novel began with. The world Clifford longs for no longer exists; the nature has been torn down or polluted, and Clifford himself can no longer produce biological descendants. Even though Connie often yearns for tradition in her own way, she resents that Clifford is trying to force a continuous “chain” when such continuity is, after disaster, unnatural.



Just as Clifford downplays physical connection in favor of “the life of the mind,” he also downplays the momentary intensity of orgasm—a passing “spasm”—in favor of the things he sees as more “enduring” (namely his last name, his estate and his baronet title).



Though Connie’s first encounter with the gamekeeper and his dog seems innocuous, it is in fact foreshadowing things to come; while Clifford speaks about an endless, repetitive future, Mellors provides something “sudden” and intense, interrupting any commitment to Clifford that Connie might’ve been about to make. This interruption foreshadows the larger interruption Mellors will eventually pose to the Chatterley marriage.



Mellors and Clifford quickly emerge as a study in opposites. For example, while Clifford does his best to reinforce class hierarchies, Mellors subverts them, even just in the way he speaks (the Midlands dialect was normally associated with working-class status) and holds himself.



Since her Dresden days, Connie has prided herself on keeping her inner thoughts and feelings private in her romantic relationships. But though nothing is romantic with Mellors (yet), he immediately understands Connie better than any other man, including Clifford, ever has.



At lunch that day, Connie asks Clifford about Mellors. Clifford explains that Mellors was a blacksmith in town before joining the army during World War I. Connie asks if Mellors is married, and Clifford informs her that Mellors was married before his wife ran off with another man to Stacks Gate, a nearby village. Connie is disturbed that as he speaks, Clifford's eyes mirror the atmosphere outside, "his mind filling up with smoky mist."

Connie's interest in Mellors's marital status, along with her shyness, hints at her budding attraction to him. This description of Clifford's "smoky" mind is vital: while Connie often compares her inner life to the natural forest atmosphere around her, Clifford's internal state is like the mines, mechanized and polluted.



Slowly, Connie realizes, the physical trauma Clifford suffered in the war is taking its mental toll. Though Clifford can sometimes seem sharp, "the bruise of fear and horror" is spreading within him—and worse, Connie feels that it is beginning to spread to her, too. Connie also sees this bruising in the colliers at Tevershall, who are threatening to strike not out of passion but out of despair. "It was words, just so many words," she thinks; "the only reality was nothingness."

In addition to losing the most men of any nation that fought in the war, World War I also marked the end of British dominance in the international sphere. It follows, then, that the malaise Connie notes in Clifford would be shared more broadly across the country. Tellingly, Connie summarizes this feeling of listlessness as a reliance on "words" instead of true, indescribable "reality"; in Connie's nihilistic mindset, language has flattened and then replaced actual human experience.



Connie begins to resent that Clifford's obsession with "the bitch-goddess" of success has worked out so well for him: he is now a well-known intellectual, with his picture appearing in papers and his bust appearing in an art gallery. But Connie feels that it is all a "display," that there is nothing substantive behind Clifford's short stories or his ideas. Even Michaelis, who has begun to write a play in which Clifford is the central character, seems to lack substance.

If Connie has begun to associate "so many words" with her sense of despair, then Clifford—who has built his entire post-war life on language and "the life of the mind"—must become an emblem of his wife's unhappiness.



When summer rolls around, Michaelis returns to Wragby with Act I of his new play. Everyone loves it, but Michaelis is unsatisfied—in part because Connie takes a while to come to his room, and in part because he craves even more effusive praise from her. Michaelis also wants Connie to divorce Clifford. But though he promises her a life of jewels and jazz clubs, Connie cannot feel anything but frustration that these men are "all the same," each as self-absorbed and obsessed with success as the others.

Though Connie was initially attracted to Michaelis because of his apparent difference from Clifford, she now sees that they are the "same": Clifford works to forget his pain with pompous intellectual conversation, while Michaelis does the same thing with his parties and fancy things. For both Clifford (with his fancy dinner parties) and Michaelis, money is an essential ingredient of this distraction.



That night, Connie finally does come to Michaelis's room, and he is more excited than ever to have sex. But after Connie orgasms, Michaelis becomes cruel, criticizing her for orgasming after he has finished instead of at the same time as he does (and thus making him work to keep his penis erect). Connie is hurt by this sudden brutality, which she feels is "one of the shocks of her life"; "it killed something in her." After this encounter, Connie feels that the only thing left for her to do is accept the total "nothingness" of life.

Earlier, Connie prided herself on her ability to turn sex into something almost transactional, keeping herself from orgasming at the same time as her partner. But now, Michaelis insults her for this practice, largely because it seems to wound his ego. The word choice here explicitly aligns Connie's pain with Clifford's experience in the war; Connie feels "killed" and "shocked," just as combat decimated World War I soldiers.



CHAPTER 6

One day, Connie asks Tommy Dukes why men and women no longer seem to like each other. Dukes is surprised by the question, as he likes Connie a great deal. But to Connie's dismay, Dukes seems to think that desiring a woman sexually gets in the way of wanting to talk to a woman, and vice versa. Then again, there are really no women whom Dukes seems sexually interested in; he feels that the whole "sex thing" is overrated and over-emphasized.

Connie begins to feel that everyone around her is much, much older than she is. She begins to understand why people become obsessed with cocktails and jazz parties: "you had to take it out some way or other, your youth," she reflects, "or it ate you up." Connie wonders if she should have just gone away with Michaelis, turning her life into one long cocktail party.

On one of her saddest days, Connie goes for a walk in the woods—only to be interrupted by the sound of a gunshot, followed by voices arguing. When Connie investigates the sound, she finds Mellors, arguing with a little girl in thick dialect. In an effort to cheer the girl up, Connie leans down, cooing comfort and giving her some change. The little girl explains that she is upset because Mellors—her father—shot a cat, though Mellors winks that it was only "poachers."

The girl, who introduces herself as Connie Mellors, keeps crying, so Connie offers to take her to her Gran's house. Connie can't help feeling that Mellors is disrespecting her authority, though she is also annoyed by the manipulative little girl. When the two Connies arrive at the grandmother's little cottage, the old woman is embarrassed and grateful for "Lady Chatley's" time. Connie Chatterley is relieved to be done with the situation; the grandmother is sad that Connie saw her in her coarse clothes, her face dirty.

As Connie heads home, she reflects that "all the great words [...] were canceled for her generation": "home" is now a physical place more than an emotional feeling, just as "joy" has been reduced to a good night of dancing the Charleston, and "husband" has become a term for a sexless companion. The only word that still has any real meaning is "money," which seems to be the only thing needed for survival, the only thing people still feel any sort of pride about.

Connie is hurt to hear Dukes describe sex and good conversation as opposed, even though she herself felt that way during her time at Dresden. Clearly, Connie's sexless life with Clifford—coupled with her intimate pain with Michaelis—is causing her to rethink the connection between physical and emotional intimacy.



Connie's age group is known, historically, as "the Lost Generation" for their tendencies toward hedonism and reckless spending. Now, Connie examines that instinct in herself; after spending her young adulthood dealing with conflict and injury, Connie now feels eaten alive by the "youth" she never got to have. And again, money becomes the only way she can envision to escape her unhappiness.



As before, Mellors's entrance (this time with a gunshot) signals danger and excitement; also as before, Connie finds Mellors in the woods, as he becomes a literal and symbolic interruption of her repetitive, unnatural life inside Wragby's walls. The little girl is likely Mellors's daughter, the result of the marriage Clifford told Connie about.



Class dominates even simple, quotidian interactions. Connie feels that Mellors is disrespecting her authority as his boss; the little girl, sensing wealth, immediately tries to manipulate Connie; and Mellors's mother seems to have a great deal of internalized shame around her working-class status.



Connie has earlier lamented that "words" are swallowing real experience, but now she gets more specific: material life (houses and parties and marriage licenses) has replaced emotional life, and so words that express feelings—like "joy"—no longer have any meaning. In this critical passage, then, the novel suggests that its characters have replaced the normal, human hunger for sex, peace, and companionship with a single-minded focus on accruing wealth.



Connie returns to Clifford, resolving to help her husband talk through his next short story (though she knows he will be inspired less by creative fervor and more by sheer willpower). And though Connie sometimes collapses into crying fits, she is determined to want “nothing more than what she’d got”; she has sworn off wanting sex ever since Michaelis was so cruel to her.

The only thing Connie will still allow herself to want is a child, though she has not yet met anyone she considers a candidate for this child’s father. She does not feel she needs to love the father of her child, but she still wants him to be “a man!”

Unbidden, a Bible verse comes into her mind: “go ye into the streets and byways of Jerusalem, and see if ye can find a man.”

One day, Connie heads into the woods, even though it is raining. The mines are closed today, and Connie feels that the world is ending; still, she finds comfort in the dark forest, with trees that seem to be patiently awaiting death. She realizes that she has stumbled upon Mellors’s cottage, and the plume of smoke coming from the chimney indicates that he is home. Connie knocks twice, but no one is here, so she goes around to the back of the house.

Connie sees that Mellors is washing himself, shirtless, in the backyard. Though it is by no means unusual for a man to wash himself in this way, Connie feels that it is “a visionary experience” to witness such a thing; she is struck by Mellors’s beauty and by the physical reality of his body, with muscles and contours that she could reach out and touch. Confused and embarrassed, Connie starts to walk away, though she also feels this new admiration for Mellors deep within her stomach.

Eventually, Connie loops back to the cottage. Mellors, now dressed, invites her inside. Mellors explains that he lives in this cottage alone, as his daughter lives with his mother over in the village. Connie notices Mellors’s sharp eyes, which suggest that he has been through a great deal of suffering—but also still contain some measure of warmth. On his end, Mellors reflects that Connie is “real” and “nicer than she knows.”

Artistry, too, has lost its meaning, just like “joy” and “home”; when Clifford writes, it is not because he has something to say but rather because he craves success and mechanically forces himself to go get it. But even as Connie laments this way of living, she also tries to adapt to it, feeling that true desire—like the kind she had for Michaelis—is too painful and unreliable.



Tommy Dukes and his friends bemoaned the modern, androgynous women of their era. Now, Connie feels a similar way about men; she also wants a return to traditional gender roles. By emphasizing the word man in this verse from Jeremiah 5:1, Connie expresses a longing for a kind of rugged, ancient masculinity, very different from the sort that Clifford and his friends possess.



Again, Connie identifies with the trees, though this time the trees are just one more symbol of her despair, perhaps even hinting that she is contemplating suicide. Mellors’s cottage in the woods, so much more exposed to the elements than Clifford’s walled-off digs, further helps to set the two men apart.



Mellors’s muscles signal that he is exactly the kind of “man” Connie wished for only moments ago; indeed, her use of the word “visionary” clearly links Mellors’s body to the Biblical quotation from moments before. It is worth paying attention any time a character feels something in their stomach (or their “bowels,” or their “womb”). As Tommy Dukes pointed out, real knowledge is contained in “the belly” as much as in the mind, so the feelings in Connie’s stomach are perhaps more trustworthy than the “words” she disdains.



Increasingly, Mellors emerges as a figure of contradictions: he is at once gentlemanly and working class, independent and tied down by family, wounded and warm. Mellors’s reflection that Connie is “real” perhaps links to the novel’s description of her as earthy and feminine, unusual for the more styled women of her age.



Connie continues to wonder about Mellors, who at once seems so rugged and so unlike a member of the lower classes. When she asks Clifford about this, Clifford explains that Mellors did well for himself in the army, climbing through the ranks and perhaps picking up some gentlemanly habits there. Connie feels that Clifford is concealing something from her, and she again resents the men of her generation.

English society is notorious for its lack of social mobility, but in the upheaval of wartime, Mellors was able to transcend some of the rigid stratifications of class. Clifford's withholding about Mellors might hint that he has already intuited his wife's attraction to this strange figure.



CHAPTER 7

That night, Connie strips naked and inspects her body in the mirror. But she is upset to see that she is flattening, losing her womanly curves and turning into something “meaningless.” She feels much older than 27, her actual age, and she reflects regretfully on the German boy’s appreciation of her body. Connie still feels confident about her back side, but her front makes her despair.

Importantly, Connie's curves—the thing that, in the novel, mark her as conforming to traditional standards of female desirability—seem to be the only antidote to the modern “meaninglessness” she struggles with. Connie feels that her life is most worthwhile when she is appreciated for her body and for her femininity, one of the many times the narrative directly links Connie's personal happiness to her conformity to traditional gender roles.



Even as her world feels constricting, however, Connie knows that she has to stay at Wragby at all times, since Clifford depends on her for all of the simplest and most intimate tasks. Connie thus begins to resent Clifford, not only for the obligation he poses but for the lack of warmth he shows her. Connie wants to rebel against the injustice—though Clifford and his friends have all the power, Connie thinks that they are actually “as corrupt as any low-born Jew.” Connie misses Michaelis, who is flawed but at least livelier than her own husband.

On the one hand, Clifford's lack of appreciation for Connie's body makes her feel less like a woman. On the other hand, Clifford's physical dependency on Connie makes him—in the novel's framing—less manly and therefore less desirable to her. It is important to note the authorial prejudices that creep in through this passage: not only does Lawrence condemn Clifford for his disability, one of many examples of the novel's ableism, but he also casually inserts anti-Semitism into Connie's voice. This anti-Semitism is a hallmark of Lawrence's writing, and it has been the subject of much the recent scholarship around his work.



One of Clifford's aunts comes to the house, along with Tommy Dukes and a few other guests. The dinner conversation turns to the possibility of breeding babies in bottles, and most of the guests agree that the point of civilization is to put as much distance as possible between people and their bodies. Connie and Dukes are horrified at this, pleading for “the democracy of touch” instead of “the democracy of pocket.”

Months ago, Dukes argued that both Bolshevism and capitalism were mechanical—alienating people from their labor (as Marx put it) and from their bodily instincts. But Dukes and Connie, echoing the perspective of the novel, argue for a different kind of “democracy”: one guided by natural passions and feelings instead of wealth and industry.



Connie's plight gets worse and worse—she becomes afraid of the graveyard on the Wragby property, and she starts losing weight at an alarming rate. Hilda, concerned about her sister, comes to visit. When she sees how ill Connie looks, she scolds Clifford for not taking better care of his wife. Hilda is definitive: it is time for Clifford to hire a servant to relieve Connie of some of her responsibilities. But Clifford, his pride wounded, staunchly refuses.

Connie's fear of the graveyard, like her belief that the trees are awaiting death, signals her anxiety that her life is passing her by. Clifford's refusal to hire a servant suggests that though he does not take the time to make Connie feel cared for, he nevertheless wants her to be solely responsible for taking care of him.



Hilda brings Connie to London, where they go to a doctor; he advises that all Connie needs to get well is to be entertained. Michaelis also hears that the sisters are visiting, and he tries to convince Connie to come to Sicily with him, but she refuses. Instead, the sisters go back to the Midlands, where Hilda threatens that she will send Connie to live with Sir Malcolm if Clifford does not get some new help.

Connie's refusal to go to Sicily with Michaelis (despite the fact that the change of circumstance might be good for her) reflects her knowledge that Michaelis is not really unlike Clifford; neither one of them will make her feel wanted or truly understood.



Clifford relents, provided that the servant is Mrs. Bolton, a well-respected local nurse. The 47-year-old Mrs. Bolton has been a widow for 22 years because her husband was killed in a mining accident. After the death, the law sided with the mining company, so Mrs. Bolton got only a small stipend on which to live. Still, Mrs. Bolton thinks well of the mining company, and particularly Sir Geoffrey, who stepped in to help her train as a nurse.

As the owner of the Tevershall mine, Sir Geoffrey is indirectly responsible for Mrs. Bolton's tragic loss (and her unjust compensation after the fact). But because Sir Geoffrey's privilege insulates him from real accountability, he—and by extension Clifford—gets to swoop in as a hero to fix problems he helped to create.



Mrs. Bolton feels a great deal of sympathy with the colliers, but she also feels superior to them. Similarly, she resents the wealthy classes even as she longs to impress them. Connie is compelled by these contradictions, especially when she notices that Mrs. Bolton—so bossy around Connie and the servants—is deferential to Clifford. The colliers had always looked up to Mrs. Bolton, but Clifford makes her feel small, and so she becomes small to fit his expectations.

Though Mrs. Bolton is proud and competent in her normal life, she quickly shrinks herself to fit Clifford's ideas of what a working-class woman should be. The narrative thus seems to suggest that class hierarchies take precedence over individual personality traits—not only for Clifford and his ilk, made shallow by their wealth, but for people like Mrs. Bolton, too.



Mrs. Bolton is a great servant: she helps Clifford shave and get in and out of bed, attending to all of his needs. But Clifford still does not forgive Connie for outsourcing his care, feeling that she has killed “the real **flower**” of their intimacy. Connie feels that the metaphorical flower was never very beautiful to begin with. Instead, she basks in her new alone time, listening to the servants talk and marveling at the new world of gossip suddenly at her door. Whenever Clifford calls Connie to his room to talk or read, Connie arranges for Mrs. Bolton to interrupt them.

At the beginning of her time at Wragby, Connie did her best to find non-sexual ways of being intimate with Clifford. Now, she actively distances herself from him, preferring the lively world of Mrs. Bolton's gossip to the “life of the mind” conversation Clifford engages in. Importantly, flowers now begin to emerge as an important symbol for desire and companionship—neither of which, as her snarky thoughts demonstrate, Connie shares with Clifford.



CHAPTER 8

Mrs. Bolton, driven by a desire both feminine and professional to protect her friend, urges Connie to go explore the daffodils. As Connie heads into the meadow, she is reminded of Mellors's shirtless body—“like a lonely pistil of an invisible **flower**.” For the first time in months, Connie feels the stirrings of desire.

If Connie's feelings for Clifford are an ugly flower, Mellors's body is conflated with the daffodils, strong and beautiful as they push through the hard ground. Connie's comparison of Mellors to a flower is explicitly phallic (he is like “a lonely pistil”), so it is perhaps unsurprising that this thought arouses Connie sexually.



It is a cold day, but Connie feels cheered by the spring **flowers** (primroses and violets) that have sprung up in the hard ground. When she at last reaches Mellors's cabin, Connie heads to the back, where the daffodils are. The house is empty, but Connie still appreciates the bright yellow flowers, "erect" and "alive." She hates the idea of going back to Wragby, with its thick walls, and when she gets home, she is surprised by how little patience she now has with Clifford.

The next day, Connie explores again; this time, she hears an unexpected hammering, and she follows the sound towards a secret little hut in the woods. Mellors is there with his dog, and Connie asks if she can stay for a bit. Mellors assents, speaking in his thick dialect as he builds them a fire. Connie marvels that she feels both a little afraid and protected by this strange man. Mellors, too, is in turmoil: he does not want to be in contact with anyone, much less a woman, as he is still bruised from his last relationship. Yet Connie is his boss, and she can do what she wants.

Quickly and skillfully, Mellors builds a new chicken coop and takes apart the old, battered ones. Connie is impressed by Mellors's solitary intensity: he seems patient and experienced, which makes Connie feel like she can be wild and irresponsible. Privately, Mellors resents Connie's presence, and he feels only dread at the flicker of desire in his crotch.

Connie asks about the possibility of getting another key so that she could come and go from the hut as she pleases, but Mellors makes this sound like an impossibility. This offends Connie, and she leaves; as she goes, Mellors laments his powerlessness against this upper-class woman. When Connie returns home, Mrs. Bolton explains that Clifford was impatient for Connie to come home to make him his tea. Connie feels frustrated at Clifford's dependency.

In Clifford's study, Connie puts the tea kettle on and gets a jug of water for her violets; though they are drooping, she is confident they will revive quickly. Clifford quotes Shakespeare on **flowers**, and Connie, annoyed, remarks that there is no "connection" between this poetry and the flowers' reality. Connie asks Clifford about another key to the hut and confesses that Mellors was a little rude to her today.

The sexual, phallic symbolism of flowers continues here. The freshness at Mellors's cottage makes Wragby's remove starker, with its thick walls sealing it off from the natural world that Connie now finds herself so profoundly drawn to.



Later, the novel will establish that Mellors and Connie both feel more comfortable when, in keeping with conservative gender hierarchies, Mellors takes control. But for the moment, Connie's class privilege inverts this gendered imbalance, yet another way that the novel paints class divisions as damaging and unnatural.



Clifford operates in the realm of words; he does not even type out his own stories, preferring to cast off even that most basic action onto Connie. But Mellors is skilled with his hands (and in touch with his physical instincts, as seen in the desire he registers for Connie in his crotch).



While Mellors craves power, Clifford wants to be waited on. And crucially, Clifford is concerned not just with his making sure his needs are taken care of but with forcing Connie to take care of these needs; even though Mrs. Bolton is on his payroll, he still waits for Connie to do most of the basic tasks, as if her service is proof of her spousal loyalty.



Flowers, themselves natural and beautiful, have already come to represent the burgeoning attraction between Mellors and Connie. But in converting these flowers into poetry, Clifford once more turns biological fact into something mental and "[dis]connected," destroying the natural vitality that Connie cherishes.



Clifford believes that Mellors has internalized his high status in the military (where he was patronized by a powerful general); now, he needs to relearn lower-class deference. This strange tension also explains why Mellors sometimes speaks in dialect and sometimes speaks without it.

Mellors's use of dialect joins two of the novel's most important themes. On the one hand, the Midlands dialect—as least as Mellors uses it—is shorter and less intricate, getting to the points that Clifford often circles. On the other hand, the Midlands dialect, spoken primarily by the working-class residents of the region, signals Mellors's disdain of the upper classes; though he has access to many of these high-status mannerisms, Mellors insists on sprinkling this dialect into conversation, as if proving how arbitrary these class markers really are.



Clifford decides that he, too, wants to go out in the woods, and so Connie helps him move his **wheelchair** out of the house. Though the air is fresh today, Connie cannot help feeling that the haze and smoke from the mines is toxic; “people are killing the very air,” she laments, with their boredom and discontent and anger. Connie gathers **flowers** for Clifford, and he again begins quoting poetry. This angers Connie: “how she hated words,” she thinks, “sucking all the life-sap out of living things.” The rest of the walk is tense.

Earlier, Connie's despair at the mechanized world was obliquely associated with death. Now, she makes that connection explicit, painting industrialization as a kind of environmental murder. Clifford's use of language then parallels his use of industry: both “words” and mines are hateful and extractive, “sucking” the life force out of natural things.



The next week is rainy, but Connie ventures out to the hut anyway. At first she is alone, but gradually, the brown spaniel arrives, followed by Mellors. Mellors worries that Connie has been waiting out in the rain, but she protests that she is fine. Surprisingly, Mellors gives her his key, assuring her that he will find or make another one.

It is unclear whether Mellors has gotten Connie a key because he wants to be around her or because he feels obligated to fulfill her request. The fact that Mellors is always seen with his dog once more conflates his presence with a return to a more natural, almost animalistic form of life.



Connie asks Mellors why he speaks in dialect instead of “ordinary” English, and Mellors replies that his version of the language is “ordinary.” This annoys Connie, who tells Mellors that she does not need her own key to the hut. But Mellors refuses to take the key back, saying that he doesn't think it right for him to be in the hut at the same time as Connie is. Connie reiterates that Mellors's presence will not disturb her, and eventually he relents. Connie goes home bewildered, not sure if she has been insulted and confused by her own strong feelings.

Though Connie has already started to loathe Clifford and his classist ideas about language, she cannot help but repeat them here. In reframing dialect as “ordinary” English, Mellors then helps Connie see that language itself can be a tool of oppression; when Connie labels Mellors's Midlands dialect as lesser, she is playing into the very class hierarchies she claims to resent.



CHAPTER 9

Connie now feels a new aversion to Clifford—not hate, exactly, but some sort of physical disgust. She starts to feel that everything around her is insane: people are obsessed with money and claim to care about love, but even the most passionate forms of love seem damaged (as with Michaelis). And all Clifford ever does is talk and write, though at least he is directing attention more and more towards Mrs. Bolton these days. Clifford is always able to assert himself over Mrs. Bolton, and Connie reflects that this subtle power is perhaps what once drew her to him.

Mrs. Bolton shaves Clifford every day now, a ritual he initially detested but has come to enjoy. Mrs. Bolton is almost sensual in the way she handles his flesh, though privately, she rejoices that she has (quite literally) got this fancy aristocrat “by the throat.” Mrs. Bolton likes being Clifford’s keeper, boasting to Connie that all men are ultimately babies—even people like Clifford, who at first seem to be real gentlemen.

Originally, Connie had been Clifford’s typist when he thought up new stories, but now, Mrs. Bolton is learning that skill, too. And after Connie goes to bed, Mrs. Bolton sits up late and plays chess and piquet with Clifford, proud to be learning “all that the gentry knew, all that made them upper class: except the money.” More than any physical desire or emotional love, Ivy Bolton is thrilled by this new knowledge. Connie, meanwhile, finds it all revolting, though she knows that Clifford is only just showing his true colors.

Connie feels conflicted about listening to Mrs. Bolton’s gossip. On the one hand, she enjoys it, but on the other hand, she feels that gossip is only appropriate when it is driven by respect and sympathy (even though satire can be part of that). She feels similarly about the novel as an art form—Connie thinks that novels can either “reveal the most secret places of life” or be “vicious” and “humiliating.”

Even if Connie does not outright articulate it, her brief time with Mellors is quickly reshaping how she views her life with Clifford. Increasingly, Connie has little patience for Clifford’s endless writing and talking and intellectualizing. Again, it is worth keeping in mind that the novel sometimes demonizes disability, conflating Connie’s disgust at Clifford’s mannerisms with the fact of his wounded body.



In the novel’s framework, Mrs. Bolton’s care for Clifford represents a double inversion: she at once upends class hierarchies and flips gender roles, handling Clifford with the tenderness that—Mellors will later suggest—men should use during intimate moments with women. The undertone of something illicitly sexual between Clifford and Mrs. Bolton foreshadows what is to come.



Just as Mellors’s inconsistent use of dialect can be read as his challenge to the absurdities of class hierarchy, Mrs. Bolton’s desire to “know all that the gentry knew” is perhaps her own form of rebellion against these stratifications: if she can possess everything that makes the upper class themselves, then she can make clear that the only divide between upper-class people and working-class people is “the money.” In a country like England, where status is inherited over generations, Mrs. Bolton thus subtly counters the belief (which Clifford and his friends hold) that class is a permanent fixture of character rather than the result of chance and circumstance.



This strange passage is perhaps Lawrence’s meta-commentary on [his](#) own project. Because Lady Chatterley’s Lover goes into such detail about sex—arguably “the most secret place” of all—Lawrence is likely signaling his own intentions, communicating to readers that he includes these private sexual details as a way to build sympathy, not just to scandalize.



In Mrs. Bolton's descriptions, Connie reflects that Tevershall feels more like a dangerous jungle than an English village. Mrs. Bolton goes into extreme detail about everyday scandals: remarriages, middle-aged people behaving badly, and, most of all, the obsession with earning and spending money that she sees in the younger generations. Mrs. Bolton especially criticizes younger people for their fixation on clothes.

Clifford begins to worry that the people of Tevershall will turn to Bolshevism, egged on by poor economic conditions and their love of spending. Mrs. Bolton, however, puts this fear to rest—the townspeople have too much interest in consumer goods to ever leave capitalism behind. Privately, Connie thinks that all the classes are alike; “the moneyboy and the moneygirl” are everywhere, she reflects, and “the only difference was how much you’d got, and how much you wanted.”

With Mrs. Bolton at his side, Clifford now takes more interest in the mines, embracing his role as the “real boss” of the Tevershall pits. Unfortunately, the pits are losing money, and many of the men are heading to the fancier mines nearby (in a village known as Stacks Gate). Mrs. Bolton theorizes that Tevershall is about to go under—especially because the Stacks Gate mines are equipped with new chemical technologies and “iron men,” large machines that cut the coal from the walls of the mine (which men used to do by hand).

Mrs. Bolton frets that machines are going to replace men entirely, but Clifford does not fear this idea. For the first time, he is interested in a different kind of success: not the popular kind attained by making stories, films, and other forms of art, but the more “savage” form of success, derived from money and industrial production. Unlike Connie, who encouraged Clifford towards the “sensitive,” inwards pursuits of art and academia, Mrs. Bolton makes “a man out of him” by sparking his interest in business.

Clifford thus returns to the mines, reading his old technical books and remembering the things he had learned before the war. He is amazed by the degree of chemical knowledge and invention that goes into coal mining: “in this field,” he realizes, “men were like gods, or demons,” discovering and then reshaping the earth. Clifford also knows that this kind of technical invention comes with a stunted emotional life, but he is too overwhelmed by his new sense of power to care.

This passage echoes Tommy Dukes's fear that capitalist society wipes clean peoples' individuality, instead rendering them single-minded copies of one another. It is especially salient that young people are so fascinated with clothes, given that fashion obscures the natural nakedness Connie and Mellors will later celebrate.



Unlike Connie and Mrs. Bolton, both of whom take issue with their society's materialism, Clifford's concern is not philosophical but personal—he does not want to lose his position of power and wealth, as he certainly would were bourgeoisie-toppling Bolshevism to take hold. In a novel so obsessed with delineating traditional, distinct gender roles, the terms “moneyboy” and “moneygirl” are particularly frightening, erasing natural gender differences in favor of monolithic consumerism.



Connie and Tommy Dukes have both spoken philosophically about the ways in which machines seem to be replacing men, but the “iron men” technology makes this replacement literal. Moreover, this kind of industrialization is cyclical: machines replace men to extract additional coal, which can then fuel more machines to replace more men.



During her phase of being attracted to Michaelis, Connie reflected that his open drive for success—and especially financial success—was more admirable than Clifford's less straightforward ambition. Now, in turning his focus more squarely to wealth and accumulation, Clifford becomes the kind of man Connie once admired (though ironically, it is too late for Connie to care).



Clifford's new focus on the mines reveals one of the most essential differences between himself and Mellors. While Mellors works closely with the earth, helping flowers grow and (later) birds hatch, Clifford fights against it, embracing his view of himself as a shaping “god.” Indeed, Clifford even celebrates the loss of his natural, internal feelings because it helps him challenge the nature of his external world.



Indeed, Clifford feels that though he has been slowly “dying” in his life with Connie, this new focus on mining allows him to be “reborn.” Clifford dreams of inventing new technologies: first converting coal into electricity, and then concentrating the fuel so it burns more slowly and fiercely. He prides himself on at last having achieved “a man’s victory”—though he only feels this way with Mrs. Bolton. With Connie, Clifford is timid and subservient, and though he would never admit it, he comes to dread her presence.

Clifford’s metaphorical death and rebirth perhaps parallel the British nation as a whole as it struggles to recover from WWI. After mass casualties and great environmental destruction, industrial technology was an exciting avenue for both Clifford and his country to regain a sense of power and “victory.”



CHAPTER 10

Clifford no longer invites guests to Wragby, preferring instead to listen to the new, high-tech radio he has installed. Clifford’s fascination with the radio, like his interest in mining technology, terrifies Connie—especially because the shrewder Clifford becomes in matters of industry, the more idiotic he becomes in his emotional life. Indeed, Connie feels that Clifford is only getting more and more dependent on her, treating her as an idol to worship and fear.

The radio, a technology that took off in the post-war years, allows Clifford to further separate himself from his bodily reality. Connie’s resentment of Clifford’s new toy again shows her frustration at his deviation from the natural world she so craves.



In the hopes of getting some of her own freedom back, Connie again raises the topic of having a child. Clifford confirms that he is all right with Connie having another man’s baby, as long as it does not transform her “love” for him. Clifford even believes (deludedly) that he might one day regain his potency and father the child himself. To Connie’s horror, Clifford confesses that she is the sole purpose of his life: “I live for your sake and for your future,” he tells her, “I am nothing to myself.” Connie feels so alienated from Clifford that she can no longer even bring herself to hold his hand.

Clifford’s logic here is disturbing for several reasons. First, he confuses his new technological power with natural potency, believing that his industrial productivity could translate into biological production (although he has been told such thing is an impossibility). Moreover, just as Clifford’s desire to make Connie part of his family’s unbroken “chain” dating from centuries earlier, his focus on Connie as his sole future disturbs her; in both cases, she just wants to be alert to the sensations and experiences of the present.



Feeling that she might die if she spends too much in the house, Connie starts going to the hut in the woods more and more often. Mellors still keeps his distance from Connie, blaming his lingering cough for his lack of socialization. Connie notices Mellors’s intense blue eyes, and she appreciates that he has tidied the hut for her.

In small ways, Mellors and Connie are each discovering their attraction to the other (and leaving little hints that the feeling is mutual). That none of this is happening with language is particularly important, another contrast between Connie’s life with Clifford and this new flirtation.



One day, Connie notices that the hens in the chicken coops have laid eggs. She is overcome with grief, comparing her own “forlorn and unused” plight with the hens’ “brooding female bodies.” Connie tries to feed them, but they peck at her, protective of their eggs. Still, Connie starts coming to the coops every day, as it is the only activity that brings her any pleasure: Mrs. Bolton has started to frustrate Connie, and even letters from Michaelis now disgust her. Spring begins, and the **flowers** start to grow. But Connie only resents the life around her—it is warm outside, but everything within her is “cold-hearted.”

This passage is laden with symbolism, all of it juxtaposing the vitality of the natural world with Connie’s sense of marital death. The hens’ new eggs are particularly upsetting to Connie because they remind her of her own childlessness (not to mention Clifford’s careless, distorted view of a potential future heir).



Soon enough, the eggs start giving way to chicks. Connie is at once charmed and upset, the “pure, sparky, fearless new life” in the chicken coops reminding her of her own “agony.” In one of her jaunts to see the chickens, Mellors shows her how to hold the baby birds, who attack Connie but seem more peaceful in his hands. Mellors notices that Connie is crying, and her vulnerability with the birds arouses him.

Almost against his will, Mellors lays a hand on Connie’s knee to comfort her. As soon as he does so, Connie starts sobbing; Mellors takes her in his arms and then, slowly, begins caressing her entire body. As if “submitting to fate,” Mellors leads Connie inside the hut, where he instructs her to lay down on a blanket. While she lies passive, Mellors strokes her body, undressing her and penetrating her.

Though only Mellors orgasms, Connie cannot help feeling that this moment has “lifted a great cloud from her and given her peace.” She wonders if this moment has been “real” and reflects that she has a deep-seated desire to be “had for the taking.” When Mellors draws away from her and gets dressed, Connie is surprised by her own sense of abandonment.

Connie is worried that Mellors regrets their encounter, but Mellors explains that he is just worried that Clifford might find out. As Mellors walks Connie to the gate of the park, he muses that he has “begun again” to feel “life.” Mellors kisses Connie goodbye, and they promise to meet again. As Connie walks away, Mellors feels bitter that she has disrupted his existence of peaceful alone-ness. He walks home through the woods, but even there, the lights and sounds of the mines disrupt his feelings of privacy.

Then again, Mellors does feel warmly towards Connie—he mostly blames his anger on the engines and electrical lights. “All vulnerable things,” he predicts, “must perish under the rolling and running of iron.” Mellors cannot help but think that Connie has the tenderness of a **flower**, so unlike the other women of her era.

When Connie first encountered Mellors bathing (and when she saw him taking apart the chicken coop), she was attracted to his strength; here, Mellors is drawn to Connie’s fragility. That these contradicting qualities attract reflects the novel’s insistence that siloed, oppositional gender roles lead to better sex and more fulfilling romance.



Connie’s submissiveness here stands in stark contrast to her earlier sexual experience; with her Dresden lover and with Michaelis, Connie was calculating, at once withholding and determined to control her own sexual pleasure. The use of the word “fate” here suggests that Connie’s lack of agency is in some ways destined, the result of letting nature take its course.



Though modern audiences might wonder if this sex scene is meant to be read consensually, the narrative is firm that Connie’s submissiveness is a product of her own desire to be “had” during sex (instead of being an active participant in the encounter). Indeed, the novel even suggests that Connie’s lack of orgasm is what makes this encounter so pleasurable, because it signals that she has truly given up any control.



The fact that this encounter has taken place in the woods—where “life” grows up out of the ground—is a sign that Connie and Mellors’s affair is natural and healthy, as promising as the spring flowers under their feet.



The sounds from the mines, encroaching on this most private moment, foreshadow how difficult it will be for Connie and Mellors to find lasting peace together. Mellors’s metaphoric imagery—in which the “flower” of his sexual life with Connie is “run” over by metal machines—will take on more literal meaning in a later scene, wherein Clifford crushes flowers by “rolling” over them with his wheelchair.



Mellors gets home, starts a fire, and eats his simple dinner. Though he tries to read a book about India, he is only able to think about Connie. He feels lingering desire for her, but he also feels a sense of foreboding—wanting Connie somehow makes him feel more vulnerable to the mechanized threats of the mines. To calm himself down, he goes out into the woods with his gun, basking in the quiet night.

When Connie gets home, Mrs. Bolton remarks on her lateness. Connie gets through dinner in a haze, listening to Clifford talk (as always) about mining before running upstairs to her room. At last, Connie can think about what has just happened. She feels that though Mellors is not very kind to her when they speak, he is “kind to the female in her,” which no other man has ever been.

The next day, Connie goes again to the woods; she can almost feel spring “in her own body, the huge heave of sap in the trees, upwards, up, up to the bud-tips.” She goes to the clearing, but Mellors is not there; when she returns home for lunch, Clifford is just listening to the radio. Connie thus goes back into the woods, sitting in front of the hut to get out of the rain. She feels that she was “born to wait,” and she marvels at the life that is pulsing around her.

When Mellors finally arrives, he speaks to Connie in dialect, wondering aloud if her frequent visits to the hut will rouse suspicion. Mellors thinks she will feel “lowered” by sleeping with one of her husband’s servants, but Connie asserts that she does not care about her status—especially because she has some money of her own that her mother left to her, a guarantee of financial security. Connie presses Mellors to admit that he is projecting his own anxieties about class onto her. He admits it, then kisses her.

Mellors touches Connie under her dress, and Connie is awed by the “beauty” Mellors finds in her body. Connie feels simultaneously afraid of her desire and filled with a physical yearning for sex—but when Mellors does penetrate her, she feels as if she is still “waiting” for something to begin. Connie feels “a little left out” from Mellors’s ecstasy, even though she knows she is partly responsible for her own feeling of “separateness.” Unlike with Michaelis, Connie has no interest in having an orgasm after Mellors finishes.

Like Clifford, Mellors tried—to a lesser extent—to numb himself to the world, but his intense new feeling for Connie makes his existential anxieties seem more intense as well. Mellors’s gun is another symbol of his physical strength and dominance (and the explosive gun itself has some phallic undertones).



Back in her Dresden days, Connie prioritized conversation above all else, viewing sex as a silly afterthought. Now, even though she sometimes struggles to converse with Mellors, she embraces him because of their physical connection—and because he pays attention to the things that define her as a woman. In the novel, the defining traits of femininity seem to be a curvy body and a sort of tender, submissive, fragility.



Connie’s sexual desire ties her even more deeply to the woods, as she extols (in almost orgasmic prose) the very tree “sap” that Clifford’s words try to “suck” away. Connie’s joy is also evident in her new experience of time. Just a few months ago, time passed quickly and with no distinction, but now, Connie is attuned to every detail of every second, each moment made worthwhile in her “wait” for Mellors.



Just as Mrs. Bolton draws a line between the gentry’s mannerisms and their material wealth, Connie now distinguishes between status (which she does not care about) and financial prosperity (which she does care about). Connie’s financial independence could potentially clear the way for her and Mellors to be together, even as he seems to find her wealth emasculating.



All of the sex featured thus far has been penetrative, but for the first time, Mellors explores a different kind of physical contact, one that is more about appreciating the “beauty” of Connie’s body. Again, Connie’s feelings about sex have shifted dramatically; she now resents being “separate,” blaming herself for the detachment she once prided herself on. Connie’s refusal to pursue her own orgasm shows how much more submissive she is with Mellors (perhaps the result, at least in part, of Michaelis’s cruel comments).



Mellors tries to keep Connie warm with his legs, worrying that she is cold. When she insists she is not, he gets up and starts speaking in dialect again. As they walk back across the park, Connie is conflicted: she knows that Mellors wants her deeply, yet they spend so little time actually talking to each other. Connie even finds that she resents his dialect. Before Connie goes through the gate, Mellors touches her under her dress again, saying that he wishes his touch could “stop time.”

Mellors’s use of dialect, paired with his continued touching, once more emphasizes physical contact over intricate language. Yet even as Connie yearns for this physical connection, she still cannot make sense of the dialect—perhaps another vestige of her classist disdain. Importantly, Mellors’s wish to “stop time” contrasts him with Clifford in a new way; whereas Clifford focuses on the past and future, Mellors wants desperately to hold on to the current moment.



Connie does not go to the wood the next day. Instead, she goes to visit Leslie Winter, Clifford’s old, wealthy, godfather. Winter is an old-fashioned man; years ago, he was close with King Edward himself (and now, he finds Clifford’s modernist short stories silly). Though Connie normally likes spending time with Winter, she finds she cannot think about anything other than her affair.

Connie’s decision to spend time with Winter, one of the more traditional and stable characters in her life, is likely an attempt to distance herself from the turmoil of this burgeoning affair. Winter’s close friendship with King Edward also signals just how powerful the Chatterley circles really are.



Connie does not go to the woods on the following days, either, overwhelmed by Mellors’s desire. When she gets bored, she decides to take a walk in the opposite direction, to a little farm called Marehay. There, she is greeted by Mrs. Flint, one of the Chatterleys’ tenants. Mrs. Flint is excited to have Connie over (though she is embarrassed by the state of her house). As Connie enters, Mrs. Flint rushes to tidy up, making Connie a cup of tea and showing off her baby.

Though Connie comes from much more privilege than Mrs. Flint, the novel depicts Mrs. Flint’s cozy, domestic life as superior to an isolated existence at Wragby. Like Mellors’s mother, Mrs. Flint seems to feel some measure of shame at her relative lack of wealth.



Connie picks up the chubby baby, admiring the child’s “female dauntlessness”; holding the baby brings Connie great happiness. Connie likes the tea (which is better than the tea at Wragby, though Mrs. Flint does not believe her) and the beautiful **flowers**. After about an hour, Connie starts to head home. As she goes, Connie notices an empty milk bottle—which Mrs. Flint fills for Mellors to pick up most mornings.

Every detail of Mrs. Flint’s life seems more pleasurable and authentic than the life Connie and Clifford share; the flowers do not wilt so quickly here, and even the tea (though presumably less expensive) has more flavor.



On her way home, Connie feels some jealousy of Mrs. Flint’s motherhood. Before she can get lost in her thoughts, however, she is stopped by Mellors, who embraces her tightly. Mellors wonders if Connie is giving him the “slip,” and he insists that they have sex in the woods. Connie relents, but she feels that in doing so she is “giving way” and “giving up.”

In this moment, Connie’s submission to Mellors feels less agentic and more like “giving up”; she has been purposefully trying to avoid him, and now he forces her to have sex in the middle of the forest. Many feminist critics of the novel point out that what the story romanticizes as appealing male dominance might in fact be something closer to sexual assault.



As they have sex, Connie has a new feeling: instead of forcing her own orgasm (as she had with Michaelis), she is overwhelmed by sensation, and she realizes that she can “only wait” for Mellors to withdraw and enter her again. Both of them orgasm at the same time: and then “they lay and knew nothing, not even of each other, both lost.” It takes a few minutes before the pair can regain their bearings and start getting dressed.

Now, Mellors remarks on their shared orgasm (“we came off together”); he believes that this is a rare phenomenon, something that many people may never experience. Connie is shocked at the strength of her desire for him, which she feels is “the loss of herself to herself.” As she walks home—alone—Connie cannot help feeling that there is a new, more childlike existence within her. Suddenly, she is overcome with the need to have a child with Mellors.

At the same time, Connie feels that the real power belongs to her, and that Mellors is merely “the phallos-bearer” she needs to access her true depths. She thinks of the women in the Bacchae, and she imagines running through the woods and tearing Mellors to pieces. When she gets home, she tells Clifford only about Mrs. Flint and the baby. Clifford seems vaguely jealous (even if he cannot put his finger on why), and Mrs. Bolton is clearly aware of the fact that Connie is having an affair. Mrs. Bolton feels happy for Connie, though she cannot place who this new lover might be.

Connie refuses to bathe that night, wanting instead to keep Mellors’s body on her. Clifford finds Connie’s new mood intoxicating, and he wants to read Racine to her while she sews. But though this ritual used to bring Connie great joy, now, she does not hear a word of the reading. Instead, she of thinks herself “like a forest,” and the desire within her like “a bird,” awakened by Mellors and asleep with Clifford. When Clifford asks what she is sewing, she explains that she is making a dress for Mrs. Flint’s baby. Privately, Clifford thinks Connie spends too much thinking about children.

Clifford then cruelly opines that (as Racine shows), “emotions that are ordered and given shape are more important than disorderly emotions.” Connie knows the comment is meant to hurt her, but she excuses herself without engaging, not even kissing Clifford on the way out. Clifford wishes that he had spent the night listening to the radio. As he falls asleep, he is consumed with anxiety and anger at Connie for being “callous”; he does not know why she does not respect him for his remarkable recovery.

In their obsession with “the life of the mind,” Clifford and his friends pride themselves on certainty. But in succumbing to physical sensation, Mellors and Connie become “lost”; their instincts introduce the very confusion that Clifford works so hard to keep out.



This shared moment of orgasm, so different from Connie’s previous sexual experiences, will prove essential to Mellors’s conception of intimacy. Connie’s “loss of herself to herself,” in which she gives her conscious brain fully over to bodily sensation, shows how firmly she is grounded in the present moment. But fascinatingly, being present in this way—giving in to her childish impulses—makes her crave a new future, namely a child with Mellors.



Connie’s reference to the Bacchae—the sexually voracious mythic women who destroyed men and worshipped Bacchus, the god of pleasure—seems to contrast with her submissiveness only moments ago. By juxtaposing these two sentiments, the novel suggests that a woman’s true power comes from her lack of sexual agency, once more reiterating the strict, regressive gender norms at the heart of the novel’s message.



Now, the thematic opposition between “so many words” and nature comes even more clearly to the fore: while Clifford reads aloud from inside the thick walls of Wragby, Connie focuses on the feeling of her skin, comparing herself to the plants and animals growing outside Wragby’s walls. Clifford’s pained reaction to Connie’s sewing demonstrates his own insecurities about being unable to bear a child.



It makes sense that Clifford would be drawn to the French author Racine, who embraced organized, Neo-classical principles of style, and who depicted most sexual desire as ill-placed and doomed to tragedy. But while Racine appealed to Connie before her time with Mellors, she now embraces the “disorder”—the sense of being “lost”—that intense physical connection brings to her.



Instead of lying restlessly all night, Clifford calls Mrs. Bolton to his room. Though she is half-asleep, the nurse plays chess and piquet with Clifford. Mentally, Mrs. Bolton drifts to thoughts of Connie's lover and of her own dead husband. Later in the night, Clifford wants to play cards, so they do, even gambling with real money.

This strange scene suggests that both Clifford and Mrs. Bolton try to swap out people in their lives like parts in a machine: Mrs. Bolton uses Clifford to imagine her way into Connie's shoes, even as Clifford uses Mrs. Bolton to reenact the routines he used to do with Connie. The use of real money in the gambling once more complicates and confuses the normally strict class separation between Clifford and his employee.



Connie is fast asleep, but Mellors is awake. He thinks about his "brutal" wife (Bertha Coutts), whom he has not seen since he joined the army in 1915, even though she lives just three miles away. He reflects on his war years in India, where he bonded with a colonel and was thus promoted. After the war, Mellors no longer wanted to social climb, so he returned to working-class life—but now he also finds the working class distasteful. Though everyone is always concerned with the "wage-squabble," Mellors thinks this obsession is pointless. But he also knows that for poor people, money is a question not of philosophy but of survival.

This passage, the first time the book has dwelled solidly in Mellors's perspective, demonstrates just how different his values are from Clifford's (and from those of Tevershall as a whole). Though Mellors is one of the few working-class men who has had meaningful options to advance through British society, his refusal to do so shows just how little he cares about wealth, status, and accumulation.



Worst of all, Mellors knows his situation with Connie is hopeless: they will only get closer and closer, even though there is no feasible way for them to be together. To calm his thoughts, he walks around the woods with his dog. Though it is quiet and still in the woods, the lights and sounds of Stacks Gate continue, even at two in the morning.

Though Mellors does his best to find calm in his natural environment, the mechanized world he detests is always encroaching, both literally and figuratively. Again, the mines disrupt even the natural progression of time, brightening the night and ending its quiet.



Even after his walk, Mellors cannot sleep—he wants nothing but to have Connie with him. So he walks over to Wragby hall itself, where he sees that Sir Clifford's light is still on (he does not know what room Connie sleeps in). Mellors also does not notice Mrs. Bolton peering out of her own window—though Mrs. Bolton sees him. With a start, she realizes that Mellors must be the man Connie is having an affair with.

Even to himself, Mellors does not use language to process the extent of his feeling for Connie; instead, he just trusts his bodily impulses, instinctively following his feel to ending up outside her window.



Mellors, frustrated that Connie is not coming to him, turns around and heads home. Meanwhile, Mrs. Bolton reflects on her own youthful crush on Mellors. At the time, she was only 26 and he had just gotten a scholarship to a prestigious grammar school. Now, Mrs. Bolton knows that Mellors has been through a great deal: his marriage to the horrible Bertha Coutts, his time in the war. But still, she approves of Connie's decision. Absentmindedly, Mrs. Bolton wishes she could tell this news to her dead husband.

Mrs. Bolton was married to her husband for only a short time, but the lifelong impact of that relationship seems to reverberate throughout every aspect of her current life. As the novel continues, Mrs. Bolton's short-lived marriage will come to parallel the intense connection Connie and Mellors share with each other.



CHAPTER 11

Connie has started clearing out some of the junk in Wragby, including a number of very ugly pictures that Sir Geoffrey had collected. While she works, Connie suggests to Mrs. Bolton that she might have a child soon. To Mrs. Bolton's shock, Connie hints that Clifford may be regaining his potency—an idea that Clifford himself put in her head. Silently, Mrs. Bolton wonders if Connie is actually going to have a baby with Mellors instead of her husband.

As Connie goes through the old objects, she comes across a giant box, filled with secret compartments and expensive toiletries. Mrs. Bolton loves the box, so Connie gives it to her—much to the nurse's delight. Over the coming weeks, Mrs. Bolton has a variety of friends over to see her new treasure. And each time a new person comes to see the box, Mrs. Bolton spreads the surprising rumor of Clifford's returning virility.

One day, Squire Leslie Winter comes over to Wragby to discuss Clifford's idea for a new coal-mining technique. Even Winter has heard the rumor of Clifford's newfound potency, which prompts Clifford to bring it up with Connie while she is putting some flowers in a vase. Connie is baffled that this news has traveled so far, but Clifford hopes that these rumors are actually "prophecy."

Connie tells Clifford that Sir Malcolm has invited her to a three-week trip in Venice. Clifford is nervous about letting Connie go, but Connie fervently promises that she will return (though the real reason for her passion is her commitment to Mellors, not to her husband). Connie also thinks that a trip to Venice might give her a cover with Clifford were she to become pregnant with Mellors's child—Clifford would just assume she'd had a lover in Venice.

At the same time, Connie has no real desire to go away, preferring to stay with Mellors. She laments that her life is always "arranged" for her: "wheels that worked one and drove one, and over which one had no real control!" On a drive, Connie feels that everything is ugly—the rainy weather, the soot-blackened buildings of Tevershall, the trashy movies, even the off-key singing of the village schoolgirls. Connie feels that "the living intuitive faculty" is dead in all the Tevershall villagers, replaced only by "mechanical yells" and will-power.

Connie is now using her husband's words against him; if Clifford is deluded enough to believe that his material gains could have biological repercussions, then Connie will use that belief to conceive a child with Mellors.



Earlier, Mrs. Bolton decided to stay quiet about Connie's affair out of some sense of female solidarity. Therefore, her decision to spread this rumor can now be read as her covert way of helping Connie; if more people believe that Clifford could have a child, then it will be easier for Connie to execute her secret plan.



The frightening extent of Clifford's delusion starts to come clear: though he is the person who started the rumor of his returning fertility, he has come to see it as a divine "prophecy." After reflecting that mining could make men like "gods, or demons," Clifford seems to have fully internalized this belief in his own godlike powers.



Though Clifford has let much of his emotional life go, his nervousness around Connie's trip suggests that he intuitively at least something about her new affair. Interestingly, Connie and Mellors have yet to articulate this commitment to each other, though they both feel it—another way in which language takes a backseat in their relationship.



Connie seems to enjoy relinquishing agency during sex, but outside of an intimate context, her loss of "control" feels like one more of mechanized destruction (wheels that "worked" and "drove"). This despair at the spread of technology is then reflected in Connie's physical surroundings, in which all "intuition" seems to have been replaced by the "mechanical," polluting mines.



Once, the Midlands were emblematic of old England ("Shakespeare's England," as Connie jokes to herself). But now, this area has become too focused on money and politics and not at all alive to emotions, beauty, and art. Even as Connie feels so little hope, however, she desperately wants to bring a child into this world. Connie's car drives south, past the new mine at Stacks Gate, which has giant chemical works in "shapes not known to man," "new on the face of the earth."

The Midlands of Shakespeare's time, romantic and picturesque, are gone. But this passage contrasts two different visions for the region's future, one hopeful and one bleak. On the one hand, Connie hopes to restore some of the natural tenderness that came before, creating change and continuity via natural childbirth. On the other hand, the mines herald a completely foreign future, never before "known to man."



On the other side of the road, Connie notices a beautiful old manor, and she thinks of the "ancestors" who must have enjoyed their lives there. Connie feels that grand houses like this (and, to some extent, like Wragby), are the only places where the old England really exists. In reality, though, even villages like Tevershall and Stacks Gate have old mining houses and pubs at the center of them—rundown buildings which have some real history, but which are not the version of old England that Connie romanticizes.

Though the novel valorizes Connie's pastoral ideal, her romanticized version of Shakespeare's England is still predicated on her own upper-class status: plenty of historical traces remain in Tevershall and Stacks Gate, but because they speak to poverty and not wealth, Connie dismisses them.



Indeed, the grand old England of Robin Hood is being torn down everywhere Connie can see; on her drive, she sees many of these stately Elizabethan homes being demolished. "This is history," Connie thinks, "one England blots out the other." The mines that had made these houses rich now destroyed them, just as industrial England was overtaking the agricultural England. And Connie, raised with wealth and therefore devoted to the older version of the nation, hates that this "continuity is not organic, but mechanical."

In this vital passage, Connie speaks explicitly to the way that "mechanical" continuity—in which technology forces change—differs from "organic" continuity (like childbirth or plant growth). It is perhaps unsurprising that this artificial change would follow immediately on the heels of WWI, in which the old forms of fighting and national pride—based on valor and tradition—were replaced by brutal machines, killing and depleting soldiers on all sides.



Connie visits Leslie Winter at his mansion, which is called Shipley. Shipley has beautiful gardens and big windows, and Connie thinks it is much prettier than Wragby. Still, Shipley is now bordered on all sides by colliers, and Winter feels that he is being pushed out by the very men that (in his mind) he used to encourage. Instead of walking around, Winter just hides inside; he knows the colliers resent that their work pays for his house, and while he feels some guilt, he has no intention of bucking the system.

Like Connie (and unlike Clifford), Winter acknowledges the basic unfairness of the stratified class hierarchy. But also like Connie, Winter is hesitant to alter the system in any meaningful way, in part because it benefits him and in part because he associates his own personal wealth with beauty and historic tradition.



In less than a year, Winter will die, leaving Clifford a great deal of money in his will. None of his heirs will want to preserve Shipley so it, too, will be torn down. But now, Connie does not know any of this; all she knows is that she fears the future terribly. Her most awful realization is that the men of today are no longer men—Connie thinks that "something that men should have was bred and killed out of them," ruined by the iron and coal. Only Mellors feels different to Connie.

This flashforward, a complete structural anomaly in the book, points to Winter's rarity: he is the only living character in the novel who truly represents England's past, so his death—though not within the confines of the narrative—also signals the death of old England. For the first time, Connie begins to explicitly equate mechanization with a loss not only of humanity but of masculinity in particular; Mellors is an exception because he works with the land (and similarly detests industrialization).



When Connie returns home, Clifford wants to hear about her interactions with Winter and various townspeople. Connie implores Clifford to venture out into the world again, pointing out that he cannot expect to be adored by the working classes if he does not show his face to them, but he has no interest in doing so. Later that evening, Clifford brings up Venice, hoping Connie will not have a serious love affair there; she jokes that she would only have a minor affair. Clifford wants Connie to acknowledge marriage as something “eternal,” but Connie is troubled by the thought.

The next morning, Connie is surprised to see Mellors’s dog in the halls of Wragby—and even more surprised when she sees Mellors talking to Clifford. She is curious how Mellors ended up as a servant, and a line of Shakespeare comes into her head (“the fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars but in ourselves, that we are underlings”). Connie wonders how class impacts the way that Mellors sees her.

That afternoon, Connie and Mrs. Bolton work in the garden together, planting **flowers**. The two have gotten closer recently, and Connie now starts asking Mrs. Bolton about her deceased husband. Mrs. Bolton believes that her late husband, Ted, was “too sensitive” to ever go in the mines; she sometimes wonders if he would rather have died than stayed working there. Mrs. Bolton admits that even now, 23 years later, she has not gotten over “the touch of him.” Mrs. Bolton feels that people are distrustful of true attraction between men and women—but despite her pain over Ted’s absence, she feels lucky to have known real love.

CHAPTER 12

After lunch, Connie goes into the woods again, which are overflowing with **flowers**. Mellors is not at his hut, so she goes to his cottage, where he is eating a simple lunch. Mellors offers to make Connie tea, but she insists that she will make it for herself. Though she does not know why, Mellors seems distant. Connie looks around the house, which is small but well-kept.

In an attempt to get to the bottom of Mellors’s mood, Connie asks why he continues as a game-keeper. Mellors explains that though he could afford to work for himself, he needs the structure of a boss to help him get through the day; even so, Mellors admits he is almost always in a bad mood. Connie announces that she is going to Venice, and she pleads with Mellors not to forget her, but he stays quiet and crabby.

Just as Connie’s relationship with Mellors has changed her, Clifford’s new fascination with the mines has freed him of his earlier need for approval; now, all he cares about is material wealth. Interestingly, Clifford is still obsessed with the idea of something “eternal” and continuous, perhaps not realizing that his new technologies are the very things responsible for the region’s lack of continuity.



With this quotation from Shakespeare’s play [Julius Caesar](#), Connie briefly wonders if Mellors’s lower-class status marks him as somehow lesser in character. But this thought quickly passes—and it is worth noting that, just as Connie disdains Clifford when he quotes Shakespeare to describe the flowers, the pristine language of Shakespeare is often depicted in this novel as untrustworthy (like all “words” are, to some extent).



Since flowers so often symbolize new life and new love, it is significant that Connie and Mrs. Bolton bond over planting flowers together. Just as Connie’s lust for Mellors makes her want to build a future with him, Mrs. Bolton’s reflections on her intimate life with Ted demonstrate how momentary passion is—at least in the novel’s framing—the seed of real romantic longevity.



Connie and Mellors’s relationship neatly parallels the seasons; as their love deepens, more and more flowers start to boom, now filling the forest.



Though Mellors does not articulate it in exactly these terms, it is possible to read his insistence on a working-class job as a small-scale protest against capitalist ideology (which dictates that financial and professional advancement are some of the chief goals of life).



Connie then describes her conversation with Clifford about having a child, even telling Mellors her plan to pretend the father is someone she met in Venice. Mellors, feeling that he has been “made use of” for Connie’s pregnancy plans, grows nonchalant and cold. Only when Connie assures him that she likes his body does he return to normal, asking her to go upstairs with him. Connie does not want to have sex at the hut, though she confesses that she does want to “feel” Mellors’s body just as he feels hers.

Mellors’s horror that his body might have been a tool in Connie’s larger plan to have a child links back to Michaelis’s resentment when Connie sought her own orgasm against his body. In both cases, the men are disgusted by the idea that sex could be utilitarian and mechanical. But whereas Connie had no real desire for Michaelis’s body on its own terms, with Mellors, she wants to “feel” as much as much of him she can—sensation for sensation’s sake.



Connie heads home, again feeling conflicted and frustrated—so frustrated, in fact, that after tea-time she returns to the hut in search of Mellors. He is there, tending to the hens. Connie is touched by the “blind devotion” of the mother hens, but her observations are interrupted by Mellors asking her to go inside the hut. Each lover wants reassurance that the other one wants them; only when they get it do they head inside.

Mellors will not verbally assure Connie of his readiness to have a child, but his kindness to the hens silently demonstrates how tender he is capable of being to new life. For the first time, Mellors and Connie use their words to affirm the desires they have already revealed to each other physically.



Mellors begins kissing Connie’s breasts, sighing that “tha’rt nice!” But for some reason, Connie does not feel swept away this time. Instead, she sees sex as absurd: she notes “the ridiculous bouncing of the buttocks” and “the wilting of the poor insignificant” genitalia. She wants to throw Mellors out of her body—yet when he finishes, Connie feels deeply lonely and abandoned. She begins to cry, and Mellors agrees that the sex was bad because Connie “wasn’t there,” mentally.

When she first started sleeping with Mellors, Connie struggled to be present in the physical facts of sex; now, she finds herself overwhelmed by the logistical silliness of intercourse. These two extremes suggests that there is a balance—intellectualized sex loses its meaning, but so does sex that is exclusively about physical contact. Once again, Mellors understands Connie deeply, realizing that she was not present before she even says anything.



Connie sobs that she can never love Mellors, though this sentiment does not seem to bother him. Instead, he just gets dressed, speaking in dialect the whole time in a way that drives Connie insane. Still, despite her annoyance, Connie does not want Mellors to leave. “It was from herself she wanted to be saved,” Connie realizes, “from her own inward anger and resistance.”

Mellors here uses dialect to distance himself from Connie, reminding her of the circumstantial and financial divides between them. Connie’s desire to be saved from her “resistance” once more demonstrates that the ideal woman in the novel is passive and submissive, giving herself over instead of acting on her own agency.



Mellors embraces Connie again, and she melts in his arms, becoming small and vulnerable. This vulnerability then causes a new wave of attraction in Mellors, and they have sex again. This time, Connie imagines that she is on the ocean, billowing away into some “primordial” peace. Connie feels at once that “she was gone, she was not, and she was born: a woman.”

Connie’s rebirth as a “woman” in this moment provides the clearest definition of femininity thus far: a true “woman” is vulnerable, passionate, and passive, relinquishing herself to a man. In finding herself “gone,” Connie also reaches back in time to something “primordial” and permanent, long before there were baronets or coal mines.



Similarly, once Mellors rolls over, Connie is struck by his “strange potency of manhood.” She touches all of the parts of his body, amazed that she now finds beautiful what only a few minutes ago seemed ridiculous. They have sex again, and when it is done, they lie together in a long silence. Of this moment, they both realize, “they will never speak.” Connie asks Mellors to say he loves her, so he does, his hands stroking her as if she were a **flower**.

As they get dressed, Mellors says, “I love thee that I can go into thee.” But when Connie presses for commitment, Mellors hesitates, arguing that everything gets too complicated once people start “thinkin’” about it. Instead, Mellors wants Connie to come sleep with him in his cottage. Connie agrees to go on Sunday, and she, too, begins speaking in dialect, as a flirtatious sort of game.

Mellors praises Connie as the “best bit o’ cunt left on earth.” Connie does not know what the word “cunt” means, and she wonders if it has the same meaning as the word “fuck.” Mellors explains the distinction—“animals fuck,” he argues, “but cunt’s a lot more than that. It’s thee [...] an tha’rt a lot besides an animal, aren’t ter?” Connie asks Mellors if he cares for her, but he just kisses her goodbye. As she goes home, Connie marvels at how alive the woods seem.

CHAPTER 13

On Sunday, Clifford wants to go for a walk, though being in his **wheelchair** in the middle of springtime always frustrates him. As they walk, Connie wonders aloud if the miners are going to go on strike again. Clifford thinks even the suggestion is ridiculous and points out that the miners will starve if the mines close. He chides Connie for approaching the situation “like a woman.”

While the church bells ring, Connie presses Clifford on why he does not do anything to mitigate the wealth disparities that have led to conflict. Clifford feels that “somebody’s got to be boss.” When Connie snaps that she doesn’t think Clifford uses his power very well, Clifford retorts that Connie similarly does not take her duties as the lady of Wragby very seriously. Connie protests that she does not want to be a lady, but Clifford insists that it is her “fate.”

If Connie defines her own femininity as powerlessness, it follows that Mellors’s masculinity is defined by physical “potency”—the very force that Clifford seems to lack. Once again, language fails (“they will never speak” of their deepest connections), and the couple instead leans into instinct, as the recurring floral imagery symbolizes.



Mellors now essentializes Connie to her anatomy, articulating his “love” for her in terms of his ability to penetrate her. Connie’s embrace of dialect in this moment shows her ultimate refusal of the “life of the mind” (or “thinkin’,” as Mellors says); now Connie, too, can speak in the straightforward vernacular that so many people of her class disdain.



The use of the words “cunt” and “fuck,” impolite and onomatopoeic, show just how much embodied, carnal communication has triumphed over language (at least for Mellors and Connie). Similarly, Mellors refuses to put his feelings for Connie into words, instead communicating them only with a kiss.



Clifford’s cavalier attitude about the strikes is a reminder that, while he profits from the mines, he does not depend on them to survive, a glaring example of class inequity. Whereas Mellors praises Connie for her femininity, Clifford still wields the word “woman” as an insult.



Increasingly, Connie is able to see the absurdity and arbitrariness of Clifford’s wealth and powerful title. But Clifford has only gotten more stuck in his ways, insisting that his status as “boss” is a matter of “fate” and his own essential, immutable character.



Connie feels that Clifford has taken “natural life and manhood” away from the miners, but Clifford insists that the miners were never men to begin with. Instead, he argues that “they are animals you don’t understand,” shocking Connie with his cruelty—even though she feels that there is something “devastatingly true” in it. Clifford boasts that his mind and his will remain strong, so he can continue to hold power—after all, he says, “I don’t rule with my legs.”

While Connie continues to insist on a “common humanity,” Clifford asserts his belief that there is an “absolute” divide between people who rule and people who serve. At last, Connie refuses to argue any longer, so they continue in silence. Connie notices that Clifford’s **wheelchair** is squashing **flowers** as it wheels across the forest. Privately, she wishes that the natural life around her could exist within men like Clifford, who seem so “stale” inside.

When Connie and Clifford pass by the cottage, Connie is surprised to hear someone whistle behind her. Mellors appears, unseen by Clifford, to ask if Clifford plans to come to the cottage. Connie assures him that he does not. Clifford honks the horn on his **wheelchair**, summoning Connie—but before she leaves, Mellors touches her breast, just out of Clifford’s eyesight.

Once Connie and Clifford come to a well at the top of the hill, Connie draws some cold water for them to drink. As they sip, they admire the clouds and a nearby mole digging in the ground, which Clifford jokes about killing. Then they turn around, back down the hill towards Wragby. But this time, Clifford’s **wheelchair** starts and stops, then grinds to a halt.

Connie wants to push, but Clifford refuses: “what’s the good of the damned thing,” he exclaims, “if it has to be pushed!” Connie suggests that Clifford should call for Mellors to help fix the **wheelchair**; Clifford again refuses, instead fiddling hopelessly with the motor. A bird sings a birdsong until Clifford silences it with the horn on his chair. Mellors appears, and Clifford snappily explains the situation.

On the one hand, Connie detests Clifford’s classism; on the other hand, she agrees with Clifford that the participants in the mechanized mines are somehow less than human. Rather than depicting Connie as radical and Clifford as conservative, then, the novel suggests that they value different things; Clifford emphasizes ideas and material acquisition (“I don’t rule with my legs”), whereas Connie emphasizes “natural” skill, “manhood,” and physical strength.



This vital moment pits the novel’s most important symbols against each other. Clifford’s wheelchair, which—in a literary move that is widely considered to be ableist—signals his mechanized impotency, crushes the flowers, which represent natural vitality. This moment thus foreshadows the plot to come, in which Clifford tries to inorganically destroy Connie and Mellors’s passionate love for each other.



Again, Clifford is rendered literally as a machine—a honking out of sight—while Mellors shines with carnal charm. Mellors is getting braver in displaying his affection, perhaps his non-verbal way of displaying his commitment to Connie despite the consequences.



Even Clifford’s jokes are about destroying nature, suggesting that he is aware of what his mining obsession is doing to his environment. The fact that the wheelchair ceases to move, however, hints at victory for Connie and Mellors’s way of life; the wheelchair may allow Clifford some measure of agency and control, but mechanization is no match for the elements.



Clifford’s harsh, humiliated reaction here shows how much he has outsourced his masculinity to this wheelchair; the idea of having to be pushed deprives him of the little potency he has left. Again, the depiction of Clifford here as imperious and incoherent, instead of as legitimately struggling, perhaps reflects authorial biases around disability.



Mellors lies on his back under the **wheelchair**, trying to fix the motor, and Connie notes how pathetic all men seem to look in this position. Mellors, too, struggles to identify the problem, so Clifford tries restarting the motor. This doesn't work either, prompting Clifford to get increasingly frustrated as he tries different levers on the chair. Constance thinks back to Clifford's speeches only a few moments before, and scoffs at the idea that there is anything special at all about the ruling classes.

Finally, Clifford's brake gives out, and he laments that "it's obvious I'm at everybody's mercy!" Then Clifford collects himself and, with a tone of cold superiority, he asks Mellors to push him, in the **wheelchair**, back to Wragby. Mellors does so, though Connie sees what an extreme physical toll this labor is taking on him. Mellors's face goes pale, and Connie, feeling worried for her lover's health, angrily joins in the pushing.

As Connie and Mellors work, Connie looks over at Mellors's hand on the **wheelchair**. Though this hand has touched her many times, Connie has never seen it in the light. Now, she is overcome with a desire to clutch Mellors's hand, just as he feels all his attraction to her come rushing back. With Clifford faced forward, Mellors takes this opportunity to hold hands with Connie. Connie secretly kisses Mellors's hand.

For the first time, Connie feels real hate for Clifford, and this feeling frees and emboldens her. Connie no longer cares who notices her closeness with Mellors, and she feels that this moment of shared labor has brought them closer than ever before. Though Clifford tries to be polite, neither Connie nor Mellors will really engage with him.

At lunch, Connie lashes out at Clifford for treating Mellors so poorly. Clifford expresses no guilt, believing that because he pays Mellors he has a right to "rule" him. Connie is disgusted by this thinking, and each spouse accuses the other of being improper with their language. Connie storms off, frustrated that Clifford thinks he can simply buy people.

As frequently happens in this section of the novel, Clifford's "life of the mind" is betrayed by physical reality; despite professing his superiority, Clifford's weakness (both physically and mentally) is evident as he struggles, unreasonably, to force his chair to work.



The lack of empathy for Clifford's plight is striking, especially given how much the novel pities Mellors for the slight physical discomfort he feels when asked to push the wheelchair. Clifford's weakness now necessitates Connie's strength, once more inverting the traditional gender roles at the center of the novel.



Early in their courtship, Connie praised Mellors for seeing and perceiving her so immediately. Now, Clifford's obliviousness signals that despite his protestations to real knowledge, he is completely (and sometimes even intentionally) unaware of the things that go on right under his nose.



Connie's behavior almost verges on self-destructive, as if she is daring Clifford to notice the affair and try to do something about it. Again, the narrative aligns its own perspective with this moment of desire between Connie and Mellors, while continuing to leave readers at a satirical remove from Clifford's point of view.



In addition to their different views of class hierarchies, the couple now splits on the very definition of what constitutes proper language. Connie and Clifford have never been able to communicate physically; this scene marks the moment in which they are no longer able to communicate with each other linguistically, either.



That night, Clifford tries to engage Connie in a conversation about Proust, but Connie feels only that Proust is “self-important” and “dead.” Though she does not want to fight with Clifford, preferring instead to disentangle herself from him, she cannot shake her rage. After dinner, while Clifford and Mrs. Bolton gamble, Connie slips out of Wragby and heads, secretly, towards Mellors’s cottage.

Marcel Proust, a French writer and contemporary of Clifford’s, is not at all the author Connie makes him out to be. In fact, Proust prioritized the use of stream of consciousness in writing, a focus on the present moment that might actually appeal to Connie and Mellors. But at this moment in her life, any literature seems “dead” to Connie, who wants only physical intimacy.



CHAPTER 14

When Connie gets to the gate, Mellors is already there. As they walk back to the cottage, Connie worries again that Mellors hurt himself when he was pushing Clifford’s **wheelchair**. Connie is angry with Clifford, but Mellors only feels that Clifford lacks “balls”—meaning, as Mellors puts it, that “he’s got none of that spunky wild bit of a man in him.”

Once again, Mellors uses anatomy to define both gender at large and an individual’s personality. In this case, Mellors more or less equates Clifford’s disability with his lack of “spunky wild” manhood, perhaps the novel’s most blatant instance of ableism.



Mellors offers Connie food, but she is not hungry. He then tries to feed his dog, but the dog refuses to eat, and Mellors accuses it of being temperamental and jealous of Connie, saying “tha’rt a female, tha art!” While Mellors undresses, Connie looks around the room, noticing a large portrait of Mellors and his wife, Bertha, when they were young. The picture is in a hideous frame, and Connie suggests that Mellors should burn it.

Mellors’s prejudices against women, many of which he has kept under wraps, now come out in his dismissal of his dog. The fact that Mellors and Connie have begun to primarily speak Midlands dialect with each other affirms their commitment to carnal feeling over intricate language.



Mellors likes this plan, so he takes the picture off the wall and begins to disassemble it. As he does so, Connie asks Mellors if he ever loved Bertha. After Mellors explains that he does not even want to think about her, Connie encourages him to get a divorce. Mellors is hesitant at first, but when Connie points out that his wife could now claim legal rights to him and his property at any moment, he agrees that a divorce is a good idea. Mellors throws the picture from his wedding night into the fire.

Though Mellors and Connie have never actually agreed to spend their lives together, Mellors’s burning the picture—combined with his promise to get a divorce—suggests that both partners are very much on the same page about sharing their future together.



Finally, Mellors tells Connie the story of his past romances. When he was young, he fell in love with a school-master’s daughter, who was beautiful and literary but who dreaded having sex. So Mellors left her and wound up with an older woman (“a demon”) who loved cuddling and foreplay—but this woman, too, hated the actual act of penetrative sex. So again, Mellors left, desperate to find a woman who wanted him sexually as much as he wanted her.

Mellors wants Connie to be passive, but his scornful recollection of past sexual partners makes it clear that he wants Connie’s passivity to stem from her own desire to explore an aspect of her identity, not from her disinterest. Mellors’s quite literal demonization of women he deems sexually deviant is another manifestation of the novel’s conservative notion of gender roles; though Mellors ostensibly encourages female desire, he also believes that desire should exist only on his own terms.



Mellors met Bertha Coutts when he was 21, working as a blacksmith, like his father before him. Though he had known Bertha since they were young, she had just come back from working as a fine lady's companion, and Mellors was impressed by the "sensual bloom" she had taken on. Soon after reconnecting, Mellors and Bertha got married, and he was happy that she was "common" and seemed to actually enjoy sex.

But after a while, Bertha started to resent how much Mellors enjoyed having sex with her, and the two began to squabble, even occasionally getting into violent fights. When they did have sex, Mellors would finish first, and then Bertha would use his still-erect penis to have her own orgasm, an act that horrified Mellors with its "selfishness." Indeed, Mellors came to believe that Bertha only had sensation at "the top of her beak," a place he associates with "whores."

Soon after their child was born, Mellors left for the war, and he refused to come back until he knew that Bertha was with another man. Yet even though he hated his years with Bertha, Mellors still prefers her to the women who refused to have sex with him. He also criticizes the women who want him to "go off" in unusual places and the women who rub themselves up against him and thus are, in his mind, "lesbian." Mellors speaks with a great deal of rage about all the women that he sees as sexually deviant.

Mellors confesses that though he sometimes fears what will happen once he and Connie get more entangled, he is deeply "glad" to have found her. Connie reflects that they are both "battered warriors," having survived many awful intimate experiences in order to find each other. By the time this conversation is done, the picture of Bertha and Mellors on their wedding day has been burnt to ash.

Mellors goes outside with the dog, and Connie takes a moment alone, too. Then they cuddle by the fire, and though Connie feels at ease, she cannot help but notice the "black void of despair" inside her lover. Connie tries to push back on Mellors's logic about his past sexual encounters, but each new comment only frustrates him further. When she presses him to confess what he believes in, Mellors that "I believe in being warm-hearted [...] in fucking with a warm heart." But before Connie can agree, Mellors snaps at her, accusing her of "self-importance" and telling her to go home.

Fascinatingly, in his memory of Bertha Coutts, Mellors conflates her "sensuality" with her working-class, "common" status. Though Connie (and to some extent her father) are exceptions to the rule, Mellors seems to feel that upper-class people are particularly alienated from their passions and instincts.



Mellors's description of Bertha's sexual habits closely resembles Connie's routines with Michaelis and her Dresden boy. But here, Mellors turns that act into something "selfish" and shameful, implying that women who prefer clitoral orgasms to penetrative sex are in some way unnatural. Subtly, Connie's persistent conflation of sex and procreation aligns with Mellors's view that penetrative sex is the most legitimate form of intimacy.



In listing all the ways that women can be sexually deviant, Mellors creates an ideal female sexuality almost by process of elimination. In his mind, women should be passive and adoring, orgasming only via penetrative sex and only at the same time as men do. Notably, Mellors's sexual preferences line up almost exactly with what Connie has recently learned to enjoy.



Symbolically, the burning of Bertha's picture represents the removal of an obstacle to Connie and Mellors's union. It is worth noting that this moment of closeness comes only after Mellors's surprising rage; to Connie, perhaps, this rage is just one more proof of his "spunky wild" masculinity.



Mellors's belief in being passionate and "warm" comes to be the guiding principle for the couple in this final chunk of the narrative; rather than espousing the importance of emotional intimacy, Mellors emphasizes the importance of tender, instinctual passion ("fucking," in his lingo). At the same time, Mellors's sudden coldness toward Connie suggests that he, too, has some fear at the strength of his feelings, despite his clear values.



This comment hurts Connie, and she wonders aloud what has happened to make her lover so nasty. Seeing Connie's real sadness melts Mellors, and he takes her in his arms, feeling for her vagina under her dress. As he holds her, Mellors asks to never fight again, and he vows to be faithful to Connie, "heart an' belly an' cock." Connie cries a little, and they go to sleep, her curled up against him.

Mellors's commitment to be faithful to Connie "heart an' belly an' cock" almost perfectly mirrors Tommy Dukes's earlier reflection that true knowledges comes from "the belly" and "the penis" as much as from the brain. The novel thus seems to assert that both real knowledge and real care are corporeal as much as mental, built on feeling and instinct even more than they are built on thought.



The next morning, Connie is almost surprised to realize that she is still in Mellors's cottage. Mellors, grateful for the new day, strokes Connie's breasts and takes off her nightgown. Mellors, too, undresses, and Connie reflects that he is as beautiful now as he was the first time she saw him washing himself. Mellors is ashamed that Connie sees him in this aroused, naked, state, but Connie wants only to admire his body.

Mellors and Connie are newly able to be naked with each other, but more than that, they are no longer shy about their appreciation for each other's naked forms. Perhaps because she knows that Mellors finds women's desire attractive, Connie at last allows herself to admire Mellors's body as he has long admired hers.



Connie particularly admires Mellors's penis, which she reflects is "like another being [...] a bit terrifying!" Mellors now names their genitalia: he calls his penis "John Thomas" and Connie's vagina "Lady Jane." Mellors and Connie continue to joke with these new pet names, and then have sex again. After they have sex, Connie marvels that Mellors's penis, which had been so large only moments before but has now gone flaccid. Tenderly, she touches Mellors's genitalia, cooing to Mellors that "he's mine too. He's not only yours."

In this vital passage, sex breaks down class hierarchies in several ways. First, by using the title "Lady Jane" for Connie's genitalia, Mellors pokes fun at the entire system of English aristocracy (while also elevating Connie's genitalia to something close to royalty). And perhaps more touchingly, Connie breaks down the idea of possession, suggesting that something of Mellors's can belong to her not because of wealth (as Clifford would have it) but because of desire and care.



Mellors and Connie have sex again. When they have both finished, Connie hears the sounds of the mine at Stacks Gate, a sign that it is now seven in the morning. Connie confesses that she wants to live with Mellors "always," which both gratifies and upsets him; he loves her, but he also fears that committing to her will bring dire consequences. The two sit in naked silence for a moment, and then Mellors gets dressed.

As has happened during several of their intimate encounters, the sounds of the mine here remind Connie and Clifford of the dangerous, mechanized world that their love must survive.



Connie again looks around the room, noticing Mellors's books: he has works on Bolshevik Russia, on atoms and electrons and the causes of earthquakes, and even some novels. Connie wishes that she could stay here forever and that "there weren't the other ghastly world of smoke and iron." When she voices her desire that the rest of the world should disappear, Mellors reminds her that no such thing is possible. Before she leaves, Connie affirms that she wants to come and live with Mellors soon, for real this time.

In this fascinating passage, Mellors's opposition to language takes on a new cast; he is a voracious reader, just as politically savvy and literary as Clifford himself. But whereas Clifford reads instead of existing within the natural world, Mellors merely uses his books to complement his embodied experience. Seeing Mellors's bookshelf allows Connie to realize that what she must fight is the mechanical, "ghastly world of smoke and iron"; her enemy is not language itself, but rather the destruction that Clifford's overreliance on language makes possible.



CHAPTER 15

Hilda writes a letter to Connie informing her that she will pick her up for the Venice trip on June 17; again, Connie resents that other people make decisions on her behalf. Clifford also does not want Connie to leave—not because he will miss her, but because her absence makes him feel insecure. Connie knows Clifford will be fine, given his almost “mad” focus on finding the cheapest new ways to run his mines.

One day, Connie finds out that Mrs. Bolton and Clifford have been gambling with real money—and that when Clifford wins, he keeps his winnings. This disgusts Connie, who insists that Clifford start paying Mrs. Bolton more to cover these gambling losses. Clifford agrees, largely because he is still worried that Connie will leave him for good on her Venice trip. Clifford wants Connie to have fun—and he even sort of wants her to get pregnant—but he is terrified at the thought that she might disappear forever.

Indeed, privately, Connie and Mellors plot for her to leave Clifford almost as soon as she returns. Mellors wants to run away with her to America, and Connie is thrilled by stories of his past experiences in Egypt and India and South Africa. The mention of the Colonies makes Mellors think about his beloved colonel. Though the colonel sometimes ran Mellors's life, he also influenced him a great deal, particularly in his ideas about class and masculinity.

Mellors again discusses the link between the popular hunger for money and the death of real manhood: he says people are becoming “all alike.” Mellors also believes that sanity is located “in the balls,” and he fears that if men keep going in their current direction, they will become insane, killing each other until humanity is completely wiped out. Mellors even feels that bringing a child into such a world is irresponsible—and this deeply wounds Connie.

Connie makes Mellors promise to have hope for their future, and her passion arouses him. While they snuggle, Mellors vows to turn his attention away from money and towards carnal desire and beauty. But Connie is barely listening; instead, she is threading forget-me-not **flowers** through Mellors's pubic hair. Connie wants to share her observations about Mellors's body, but Mellors cannot break himself out of his bad mood. As he puts it, thinking about the future makes him feel as if he has “swallowed gall.”

Again, Connie's newfound sexual passivity makes her want to take more agency over other aspects of her life. The novel increasingly pathologizes Clifford's perspective, painting him less and less as a complicated, hurting character and more and more as a “mad” man.



Even in games with his much less wealthy servant, Clifford cannot let go of his acquisitionist mindset; to Connie, class hierarchies now seem like a form of insanity. Clifford's intuition once more warns him of Connie's betrayal, even if Clifford is too stubborn to admit this truth to himself.



The novel has thus far presented numerous examples of masculinity, from the old-fashioned squire Leslie Winters to the intellectual ramblings of men like Hammond and May. But perhaps no group of men is painted with as much admiration as military generals (like Tommy Dukes and Mellors's mentor), who turn physical strength and aggression into service for their country.



Mellors shares Connie's fear that society is becoming too mechanical, but his concern—perhaps inspired by the technologically wrought carnage of World War I—is that these humanmade machines will eventually kill out humanity entirely. Once again, Mellors uses anatomy as a statement on personality, now locating sanity in the same part of male genitalia that he previously located potency and manly “wildness.”



As foreshadowed by the sounds of the Stacks Gate mine, Mellors is having trouble focusing on his present happiness, instead finding himself disturbed by the poisonous (“galling”) mechanization around him. But Connie, now making the sexual symbolism of flowers literal, tries to keep Mellors focused on the beauty of nature, as it appears both in forget-me-nots and in human desire.



It starts to thunderstorm, and Connie gets up and takes off her night clothes. As she does so, she feels a little triumphant in her knowledge that Mellors's sadness is linked to her going away, even though he does not say so. Invigorated, Connie runs out into the rain, dancing wildly in the storm. Mellors laughs and follows suit, stripping and heading outside to dance. He grabs Connie from behind, surprising her, and they share a naked embrace in the rain.

Mellors goes back to the house, but Connie takes her time in joining him, picking **flowers** as she goes. Connie sits by the fire to dry herself off, and Mellors admires the shape of her posterior. "Tha's got the nicest arse of anybody," he tells her, "it's the nicest, nicest woman's arse as is!" Mellors is particularly enchanted by how curvy Connie's rear is, unlike the "button-arsed lasses as should be lads" that are so in style. Mellors even loves to think of Connie going to the bathroom, as it proves her real womanhood all the more.

Now it is Mellors's turn to weave **flowers** into Connie's pubic hair; he wants to make sure she will "remember" him even in her most private places. Mellors and Connie discuss her trip, and their plan to leave Wragby—hopefully with a child in tow—after she returns. For the first time, Mellors admits to feeling self-conscious about his lack of wealth and his status as Connie's husband's game-keeper.

Moreover, Mellors informs Connie that he has gone to a lawyer about his divorce—and the lawyer has warned Mellors that in order for the divorce to go through, he will need to live a scandal-free life for the next several months. The mention of scandal makes Connie especially sure that she must see Mellors again before she leaves, even though Hilda is arriving soon. Connie decides that she will ask Hilda to drive her away from Wragby—but then, secretly, she will have Hilda bring her back for one more night with Mellors before they head to Italy.

Connie and Mellors go back to cuddling, giving each other new nicknames: Connie calls Mellors the "Knight of the Burning Pestle," while Mellors calls Connie "Lady of the Red-Hot Mortar." Mellors goes out and gets more flowers, and he lays them all over Connie's body. "This is John Thomas marrying Lady Jane," Mellors says, "and we mun let Constance an' Oliver go their ways. Maybe—"

Despite the fact that Mellors never outright states his love for Connie, she is able to feel his care for her in his gestures and moods—much more than she feels Clifford's affection, even though he articulates it endlessly. Connie's rainy dancing is another way that she links her own natural nakedness to the nature around her.



This important passage shows the extent of Mellors's love of nature; whereas most people prefer to ignore the bodily logistics of going to the bathroom, Mellors calls attention to it, embracing Connie's body because it works to sustain itself, no technology needed. Mellors's praise of Connie's voluptuous figure once more sets her apart from her more androgynous ("button-arsed," flapper-esque) female contemporaries.



When Clifford craves permanence, he writes a story or builds a mine, hoping to produce some new commodity and thus earn fame, wealth, and a bust of himself in a museum. By contrast, Mellors and Connie seek permanence in "memory"; indeed, the fast-wilting forget-me-nots are the only tangible proof they have of their love for each other.



If news of Mellors's affair with Connie—ostensibly his boss—ever came to the light, it would be a gigantic scandal. In order to allow his divorce to go through, Mellors and Connie will need to take some time apart from each other, making one last pre-Venice visit feel all the more imperative.



Again, Mellors's nicknames poke fun at the idea of English ladies and knights, using these supposedly sacrosanct titles to refer to genitalia. Mellors has never mentioned marriage in a legal form, but his decision to wed John Thomas—his penis—to Lady Jane—Connie's vagina—suggests a different form of union, one based not on paperwork and finances but on sexual desire and connection.



Connie desperately wants Mellors to finish his sentence, but he doesn't. This cliffhanger is one of the biggest disappointments in Connie's life. As Mellors walks Connie towards the gate, he switches back into his heavy vernacular, and Connie feels (as always) charmed and a little confused by the dialect. The happy couple runs into Mrs. Bolton, who takes in the love in both their eyes. Mellors kindly salutes Mrs. Bolton and heads back to his cottage.

The fact that Constance does not know what Mellors might say here emphasizes that part of being in true love is being confused (or "lost," as the novel put it earlier). There will always be parts of Mellors that Connie does not understand, but she is learning to embrace the confusion. Mrs. Bolton's tacit support of this couple reveals that ultimately, her loyalty is to women and others of the working class, even if Clifford's high status has momentarily enchanted her.



CHAPTER 16

When Connie arrives home, Clifford cross-examines her about her whereabouts. Despite Mrs. Bolton's best efforts to calm him, Clifford hates the idea of Connie out in the woods during a rainstorm—especially because Connie doesn't come home after the rain stops, making it unlikely that she simply got caught in the rain. Mrs. Bolton, of course, knows that Connie has actually been with Mellors.

Clifford's suspicion is mounting, though he does not ever name—seemingly even to himself—his belief that Connie is having an affair. Whereas Connie and Mellors act on their intuitions and instincts, Clifford ignores his, much to his own detriment.



Though Connie resents that Mrs. Bolton has discovered the affair, she cannot hide her joy—her rosy cheeks and starry eyes give it away. Connie even feels bad for Mrs. Bolton; after all, whenever Clifford flies into one of his rages (often provoked by her absence), it is Mrs. Bolton who has to deal with him. Connie tries to soothe Clifford, telling him that she went to the hut and took a shower in the rain, leaving out that she took this shower with Mellors.

As Connie's affair with Mellors deepens, the novel begins to ascribe even more femininity to her physical appearance, again suggesting her fulfilling sex stems from a more conventional understanding of gender roles.



Clifford senses that Connie is lying to him, but despite himself, he cannot help admiring her, both for her obstinacy and her flushed beauty. That evening, Clifford tries to be kind to Connie, reading her his "scientific-religious" books, all of which focus on leaving the body behind in favor of high-minded mental pursuits. But all Connie can think about is Mellors, particularly his praise of her "arse." Unlike talking to Mellors, Connie feels that conversation with Clifford "had to be made, almost chemically."

The main thing Connie and Mellors talk about is their bodies, using four-letter words to praise and please each other. Clifford's focus on leaving his body seems particularly inorganic in contrast, a juxtaposition that is reflected in the almost "chemical" way Clifford has to force companionship.



As Clifford wistfully imagines vanishing into abstract form, Connie—still thinking of Mellors's words—insists that she likes her body. Clifford feels that it is cruel for Connie to wave her newfound happiness and bodily freedom in his face, but Connie is hardly bothered. That night, Clifford, disturbed by his wife's words, again struggles to sleep; instead, he forces Mrs. Bolton to stay up all night gambling with him.

Before having sex with Mellors, the sight of Connie's body in the mirror made her cry; now, seeing herself through Mellors's eyes, she learns to love her body. More and more, Clifford gets his way through force, requiring Connie to sit next to him or Mrs. Bolton to gamble with him as if they were parts in one of his machines.



It is almost time for Connie to head off. First, she tells Mellors that if everything looks like it will work out for their last night together, she will hang a green shawl out of her window (if there is trouble, she'll hang a red shawl). Then, Connie works with Mrs. Bolton to pack for the trip. While they pack, the two women gossip about men. Mrs. Bolton believes that caring for a man means “giving in” to him—but so few women know this because so few women ever truly care for their lovers.

Mrs. Bolton reaffirms the lesson the novel has already taught Connie: true passion, for a woman, is about submitting (“giving in”) rather than controlling the situation. Though it has been decades since Mrs. Bolton last was intimate with a man, her memories of her dead husband Ted are sustaining—affirming Connie’s newfound belief that momentary intimacies are powerful enough to determine the future.



At last, the day of Hilda’s arrival rolls around. Hilda is in the middle of her own divorce, and when she learns that Connie is sleeping with the game-keeper, she makes her displeasure clear. Hilda loathes Clifford, but she also doesn’t want Connie to “lower” herself with a servant. Still, despite Hilda’s anger (which reminds Connie of their mother), she agrees to help Connie in her plan to have one last night with Mellors. Connie hangs the green shawl on her windowsill.

In their adolescent years at Dresden, the sisters were unified, both preferring intellectual connections to passionate sex. But now, Connie’s experience with Mellors has caused the sisters to diverge; whereas Hilda still retains rigid ideas (not only about sex but about class and propriety), Connie is happier and freer.



As Hilda drives off with Connie, she feels new sympathy for Clifford; personally, Hilda hates sex, and she thinks Connie should appreciate her husband’s impotency. And when Connie challenges her sister’s distaste for Mellors on a political level—“you’re always on the side of the working classes!”—Hilda insists that she is only allied with working-class people in the abstract. Hilda thinks it should be impossible for rich people to “mix” their lives with the poor.

Hilda and Connie were both raised in socialist circles, so Hilda’s hypocrisy is especially striking. In satirizing Hilda and Clifford, the novel critiques upper-class intellectuals, many of whom espouse ideas in theory (like the end of class hierarchy) that they have no interest in actually putting into practice.



After Hilda has checked in to a nearby hotel, the two sisters drive down the road near Mellors’s cottage. Connie introduces her sister to her lover, and the three walk in total silence through the woods. Once they arrive at the cottage, Hilda looks around the room, and then at Mellors himself. When Hilda takes a seat, Connie softly corrects her that she is in Mellors’s chair (though Mellors himself does not mind).

Connie’s quiet ask that Hilda shift her chair is yet another mark of Connie’s newly submissive attitude; rather than allying herself with her sister, as she used to do in their youth, Connie puts Mellors’s comfort above everything else.



The conversation quickly sours after Hilda accuses Mellors’s dialect of sounding “a little affected.” Mellors strikes back that Hilda will criticize anything he does, given that she does not approve of this affair in general. For her part, Hilda hates that Mellors has an instinctive grace and good breeding that she herself lacks. When Connie tries to make peace, Hilda just scolds her, telling her, “You’ve got to have some continuity in your life. You can’t just go making a mess.”

In this important passage, Hilda’s discomfort with Mellors stems from his contradictions: he possesses the grace she lacks even as he speaks a working-class dialect and lives in a small hut. In fact, Mellors’s grace comes from his ability to follow his instincts, the very skill Hilda (and Clifford) lack. Hilda’s emphasis on “continuity” further links her to Clifford, who hopes to force Connie into being a “link in the chain.” But even if Hilda cannot see it, Connie is establishing a private, more natural form of continuity, intending to turn her passionate love for Mellors into a child with a future of its own.



Mellors, angered by this, starts using explicitly sexual language to describe his relationship with Connie, which offends Hilda so much that she gets up and leaves. Once Hilda is gone, Connie, unbothered, just wants Mellors to kiss her. He feels that he needs to “simmer down” first, however, so he does chores in silence while Connie admires his “handsome” anger.

They have sex for a final time, and it is rougher and more sensual than usual. Connie feels that she needs to be Mellors’s “passive, consenting thing” in order to burn out all the “deepest, oldest shames” she carries. After they both finish, Connie wonders why people have been trying to tame sex for centuries—since the ancient Greeks—when in reality it is such a messy, fiery thing. “What liars poets and everybody were!” Connie thinks. Instead of wanting “sentiment,” what she has always really wanted is this “piercing, consuming, rather awful sensuality.”

Connie goes to sleep. The next morning, she is woken by Mellors’s lustful gaze. For the first time, Connie sees herself from Mellors’s perspective, and the voluptuous image of herself in his eyes delights her. Mellors brings her breakfast in bed, and she lets herself imagine a life with him. As they eat, Connie makes Mellors again promise that they will live together when she returns.

The postman arrives, bringing some photographs from British Columbia; this is one of the places Mellors thinks they could go to after leaving Wragby. Slowly, the two of them get dressed and walk to the road, where Hilda is waiting. Connie feels that the whole purpose of life is nights like the one they just shared, but Mellors reminds her that “there’s the rest o’ the times to think on,” too. This comment plunges Mellors into a sad and anxious mood, and when Hilda arrives, he hides in the bushes instead of facing her.

CHAPTER 17

At lunch, Connie lectures Hilda about all the things she is missing out on. This annoys Hilda, who insists that all she wants is “complete intimacy”—even though that idea seems boring to Connie. Hilda feels that Connie has become a “slave” to Mellors’s desires, while Connie uses her resentment of Hilda to conjecture that she must resent all women.

Mellors’s insistence on crude language is a rebuke of Hilda’s taut, mannered way of being; whereas Hilda refuses to name the reality of the situation, Mellors names it with four-letter words, brusque and effective.



In addition to reiterating that Connie most enjoys sex when she is “passive” instead of active, this important passage also explains Connie’s critique of language; so often, she feels, language tries to simplify the hard-to-understand, “awful” appeal of intercourse. Connie prefers rough, “consuming” sex to any words that one might use to flatten that experience. And just as she once reflected that words were “meaningless,” Connie now believes that literature itself is a “lie,” trying to contain sex to the page rather than embracing its inarticulable realities.



Connie’s appetite around Mellors contrasts with the disinterested attitude toward food she used to have around Clifford. Perhaps her new awareness of—and pride in—her body makes her more willing to fuel it, just as Clifford’s lack of attention to her body made Connie ignore it, too.



Though Connie mentally links her present happiness to an exciting future, Mellors struggles to take the long view. Interestingly, of all the characters in the novel, only Connie seems to have a healthy relationship with time: Clifford and Hilda focus too much on the future, men like Sir Geoffrey and Leslie Winter focus too much on the past, and Mellors feels terrified of “the rest o’ the times” outside of his encounters with Connie.



Hilda’s focus on “complete” connection ignores the mystery and sense of feeling “lost” that Connie has so loved with Mellors. While Hilda feels that Connie’s passivity is a kind of “slavery,” Connie believes that there is power in submission.



When they get to London, Connie is glad to reunite with Sir Malcolm, who has recently gotten remarried to a rich young woman. Connie has always been her father's favorite, and the two have go on fun excursions together. As they walk or sit, Connie observes her father's masculinity in his strong—albeit aging—legs. She realizes that her time with Mellors has made her newly attuned to “the existence of legs.”

Unfortunately, Connie thinks everyone else around her seems tired and blank. When they get to Paris, Connie sees a little more “sensuality”—but here, too, all people think about is “money, money, money.” Connie begins to feel afraid of the world, which she sees is being overrun by the Americans and English, all of whom lack “tenderness.” Indeed, Connie now agrees with Mellors that people are “alike” everywhere; even travel, supposedly leisure, feels determined and money-grubbing. Connie wishes she were at Wragby.

Finally, they arrive in Venice. They are staying at a little place called the Villa Esmeralda; on the way over, Hilda and Connie take a gondola, steered by a gondolier named Giovanni. Giovanni convinces the sisters to hire him for the duration of their trip so that they can have easy transport away from the dull Scottish couple who is hosting them.

Though there are a good deal of other people staying at the villa, Hilda and Connie think that most of them are very boring. Sir Malcolm takes his daughters to restaurants and plays, and to the Lido—but through it all, Connie can only think of the excess. “Too many ices, too many cocktails,” she thinks, “too many men-servants wanting tips [...] altogether far too much enjoyment!” Even Michaelis has found his way to Venice, and he follows Hilda and Connie around.

Hilda likes this drugged kind of pleasure, especially when she goes to jazz clubs and dances intimately with strangers. But Connie just wants to get in the gondola and go to some quiet part of the city, where she can bathe alone. Unfortunately, even this peace is complicated when Giovanni—thinking the two sisters are looking to have sex—hires his friend Daniele as a sort of sex worker. Connie and Hilda want no such thing, and Connie thinks it is extremely sad that even sex can be converted into money.

Every element of Connie's perception has been shifted by her affair with Mellors: she now pays attention to new parts of the body, focused on physical strength and vitality more than just someone's head and features.



Mellors's perspective clearly shapes Connie's experience of Europe, which she sees as just as mechanical and impersonal as her English home. Even Paris, allegedly the city of love and “sensuality,” feels materialist.



The Italian city is filled with canals; to get around, people ride on long, flat-bottomed boats known as gondolas. Though this languorous form of transportation is traditionally associated with romance and sensuality, Connie feels embittered here, too.



The Lido is a barrier island, but being close to the sea does not make Connie feel any closer to nature. Instead, she sees only the inorganic effort behind all these tourists' “enjoyment” (as Michaelis, who seems to be wherever there are cocktails and dancing, symbolizes).



Hilda's appreciation of this forced enjoyment once more testifies to the absence of real, joyful intimacy in her life. Importantly, Connie's sadness at Giovanni's attempted prostitution is twofold. Explicitly, it makes Connie sad that sex can be so baldly commodified, turned not into instinct but into transaction. But implicitly, the idea of male prostitution seems particularly dismal within the novel's framework of desire, which suggests that women should be passive participants instead of active seekers in sexual pleasure.



As the weeks pass, Connie discovers two things. First, she now senses that she is pregnant; there is something full and “stupefying” about the way her body feels. And second, Clifford writes to inform Connie that Mellors’s wife, hearing that Mellors had started on a divorce, returned and claimed residency in his cottage. Connie writes to Mrs. Bolton to get more information. Around this time, Duncan Forbes, an artist and longtime friend of the Reid family, arrives in Venice.

Mrs. Bolton writes back clarifying the story. Apparently, Bertha broke into Mellors’s cottage, forcing Mellors to stay with his mother. While at the cottage, Bertha found evidence that Mellors was having an affair, and she spread rumors of this to the entire town of Tevershall. Connie is horribly depressed by this news, feeling that Mellors’s association with the awful Bertha somehow implicates him, too.

Connie confides in Duncan Forbes, who comforts her by telling her that people merely hate those who have good sex—“it’s the one insane taboo left.” Duncan’s words allow Connie to feel fondly towards Mellors again, and she impulsively includes a note to him in her next letter to Mrs. Bolton. In the note, Connie assures Mellors that she is on his side and that this trouble with Bertha will pass.

Soon, Clifford writes again, updating Connie on the scandal and saying that all the colliers’ wives are now on Bertha’s side. He mocks Mrs. Bolton as being a bottom-feeder, obsessed with the lowest gossip; he also hints that he is firing Mellors because of the rumors. Clifford even shares a particularly odd conversation he had with Mellors: when he chided Mellors for the affair, Mellors merely replied that, “it’s not for a man i’ the shape you’re in, Sir Clifford, to twit me for havin’ a cod atween my legs.” Finally, Clifford encourages Connie to stay on vacation until the scandal dies down.

Connie is irritated and confused until she gets a letter from Mellors himself. Mellors’s letter clarifies what exactly Bertha knows; she found Connie’s initials (“C.S.R.”) scribbled all over the house and put together that Mellors was likely having an affair with Lady Chatterley herself. Mellors ends his letter by announcing that he is leaving Wragby and will go to London instead. Connie is angry that Mellors did not ask about her at all in this letter.

It is telling that, despite all the external, purchasable forms of enjoyment around her, Connie only finds real happiness within her body, through the feeling of her pregnancy. The return of Bertha Coutts spells trouble for Mellors and Connie, as Bertha’s unwillingness to go through with the divorce will surely make the illicit couple’s already complex circumstances even more difficult.



Mellors now hates Bertha, but at one time, he did find himself drawn to her—and because so much of what attracts Connie to him is his intense, unfiltered desire, his long-ago love of Bertha makes his judgment (and Connie’s attraction to that judgment) seem suspect.



Like Sir Malcolm, Duncan is a painter, preferring to communicate his ideas in images instead of words. Perhaps that is why, like Malcolm, he embraces frank conversation about sex rather than shying away from it. So, just as the novel (somewhat ironically) critiques literature, it seems to praise painting as a more truthful medium of artistic expression.



While Mrs. Bolton, having had her own intense moment of passion years ago, tends to ally herself with Mellors and Connie, most of the colliers’ wives have had no such intimacy, and so they sympathize not with Mellors’s true love but with Bertha’s vengeful commitment. Mellors’s retort to Clifford—said in dialect to mock Clifford’s upper-class mannerisms—makes explicit the novel’s ableist linking of Clifford’s disability (the “shape” he’s in) with his errant masculinity.



Though Connie prides herself on not needing language to communicate with Mellors, when they write letters to each other, words are all they have. Mellors’s refusal to express care or concern with language thus poses a problem for Connie here, especially given their newly precarious circumstances. On the other hand, though, the fact that Connie’s scrawled initials gave the couple away to Bertha again signals the untrustworthiness of written language.



To distract from her anxiety, Connie spends her days with Duncan Forbes, whose longtime crush on her has been reignited. Duncan thinks that everyone feels as lonely as he does, remarking that Daniele—despite being so handsome—looks so solitary. But Connie knows that Daniele is married with two young children. “Perhaps,” Connie muses, “only people who are capable of real togetherness have that look of being alone in the universe.”

In this reflection, Connie's insights into Daniele perhaps hint at her own desire to feel calm about separating from Mellors, instead of anxious to be even momentarily “alone.”



CHAPTER 18

Despite her confused emotions, Connie makes a plan: she will leave Venice to meet Mellors in London. Connie travels back with Sir Malcolm, revealing on the trip that she no longer intends to return to Wragby. She also shares the news of her pregnancy, though she does not tell Sir Malcolm who the father is.

Connie's confession to her father reminds readers how unusual Sir Malcolm's approach to gender and sexuality was for the time; rather than begrudging his daughter her affair, he helps her make sense of it.



Sir Malcolm counsels his daughter to go back to Wragby, despite her lack of love for Clifford (“[...] emotions change. You may like one man this year and another the next. But Wragby still stands”). Yet contrary to his advice, Malcolm is happy that his daughter has at last found a “real man,” and he treats Connie with new tenderness.

There are two vital, contradictory details in this passage. On the one hand, Malcolm echoes Clifford and Hilda, arguing that only solid structures—human-made things, forced out of the earth—will “stand.” But on the other hand, Malcolm shares Mellors's view of “masculinity,” linking rugged potency to individual happiness; even as he counsels Connie to stay with Clifford, Malcolm knows why his daughter might not.



Connie and Mellors reunite, and she is surprised at how easily he blends into his nice clothes and London setting. Instantly, she feels at ease and realizes with delight that she is always happier when Mellors is around. After they catch up, Connie tells Mellors the news of her pregnancy. He refuses to celebrate, instead reminding her just how anxious the future makes him.

The way each character handles time again comes to the fore, as Mellors cannot focus on his intimate future—Connie and the baby—because he is so distracted by the more generalized threat of mechanization.



Connie teases Mellors by saying she could easily go back to Wragby and raise the baby as Clifford's own. But when she gets serious (saying simply, “I want to live with you”), Mellors cannot resist his intense physical desire for her. Still, Mellors worries that he won't be able to “offer” Connie enough status or security—and he refuses to be “just my lady's fucker.” Connie reassures him that he has something no other man has: “the courage of [his] own tenderness.”

Mellors struggles now at the intersection of class and gender, believing that his male dominance should extend to finances; otherwise, he will become a tool for Connie to take advantage of—“just [his] lady's fucker.” But in this important response, Connie emphasizes that “tenderness” is its own form of masculine courage—because every time Mellors delights in Connie's body, he affirms the traditional gender roles that they both so seem to crave.



This statement makes Mellors happy, and he brings Connie back to his rented room. While they have sex, Connie begs Mellors to celebrate their child. Mellors is still nervous about bringing a newborn into this grim future, but Connie reassures him: “be tender to it, and that will be its future.” Lovingly, Mellors kisses Connie’s belly, and they both orgasm. As he finishes, Mellors adjusts to the idea that, even if Connie has money and he has none, he will feel happy and proud of their life together.

After having sex, Connie wants to hear about Bertha Coutts. She is worried that, just as Mellors once cared for Bertha and now loathes her, he will turn against her. But Mellors argues that people like Bertha and Clifford “only frustrate life” and that he could never feel about Bertha how he feels about Connie. Mellors also reveals that he will need to stay away from Connie until March in order for the divorce to go through. This upsets Connie, as her baby is due in February. Connie wonders if they could run away without getting divorces—but she knows that “the far ends of the world are not five minutes from Charing Cross, nowadays.”

Connie finally tells Sir Malcolm that her affair has been with Clifford’s game-keeper. Sir Malcolm, having fought for his family’s own wealth and status, is frustrated, especially because he fears that Mellors is a gold-digger. Still, Malcolm helps his daughter with her next steps: she will get Duncan to claim paternity over the child, so as not to add scandal to Mellors’s divorce. In exchange, Connie will allow Duncan to paint her, something he has wanted to do for years.

Though neither Mellors nor Sir Malcolm particularly wants to meet, both agree it is necessary. After the men have a couple of drinks, however, Malcolm congratulates Mellors on getting Connie “warmed up,” and the two men connect over their shared commitment to sexual freedom. Malcolm is proud that Connie feels comfortable with her sexuality.

The next day, Mellors has lunch with Hilda, who is much less welcoming. To Connie’s surprise, Hilda rushes to broach the idea of having Duncan Forbes claim paternity over the child. Mellors is hesitant at first, but Connie and Hilda convince him that this is the most practical way forward. The next step is for the sisters to introduce Mellors to Duncan.

Moments ago, Connie equated tenderness with courage and masculinity. Now, she equates it with futurity, suggesting that physical warmth and intimacy are a way to fix the broken time that Mellors (and everyone else in the narrative) struggles against. Perhaps nowhere else does the novel so cleanly articulate its project: rather than recovering from World War I with technology and brute force, as Clifford does, Connie and Mellors will move forward from this cataclysm through “tenderness.”



As with their time at Wragby, reminders of the unnatural world around Connie and Mellors interrupt their warm, organic time together. As both Mellors and Connie have to admit, making a run for it would be impossible, because new technologies have shrunk the earth to a fraction of its former size.



Unlike Hilda, Malcolm is able to put his daughter’s desire for love and passion over his own desire for status. By using Duncan as a cover, Connie can avoid staining Mellors with the kind of “scandal” that would make the courts rule against his divorce from Bertha.



This moment marks the novel’s uneasy fusion of progressive and conservative views on gender and sexuality. Malcolm and Mellors share an appreciation of and frankness about sex, marking them as more progressive. But at the same time, Malcolm’s comment that his own daughter has been “warmed up” reflects a crude, more regressive form of objectification.



Hilda’s desire to introduce Duncan into the equation likely stems from anxiety about her own reputation. The depiction of Hilda as anxious and ill-behaved adds fuel to the novel’s mockery of upper-class mannerisms.



When the quartet has dinner, Mellors is struck by Duncan's personality (like a "taciturn Hamlet") and his art, which is all "tubes and valves and spirals." When Duncan asks Mellors for his opinion of the work, Mellors is insulting, saying that the paintings murder compassion. Still, Duncan agrees to the plan—only, as predicted, on the condition that Connie models for him. Mellors is jealous that Connie will pose for Duncan, but Connie assures Mellors that she shares his antipathy towards the paintings.

Mellors compares Duncan to a Shakespeare character; in Connie's framing, all poets are "liars." Duncan's work is mechanical, resembling the inside of an "iron man" or other coal-digging machine; Mellors works with the earth. By juxtaposing Mellors not only with Clifford but with Duncan, the novel makes clear how rare this natural, instinctual man really is.



CHAPTER 19

Now, Connie must write to Clifford to tell him that she is in love with Duncan and that she hopes Clifford will divorce her. Though Clifford has long intuited that something like this might happen, he still falls into a state of shock when the letter arrives, turning so pale that Mrs. Bolton rushes to call a doctor. When Mrs. Bolton realizes what has happened, she labels it as a case of "male hysteria." Privately, she feels frustrated that Clifford is even a tiny bit surprised.

Clifford's time ignoring his instincts now comes back to haunt him, as he is doubly humiliated by Connie's letter because he has not ever allowed himself to anticipate it. In using the word "hysteria," a term historically used to pathologize female emotion, Mrs. Bolton demonstrates just how far Clifford has strayed from the novel's conception of proper gender roles.



However, Mrs. Bolton knows that her job is to comfort Clifford—and in this case, that means joining in his sadness. Mrs. Bolton thus starts to cry and rushes to hold him, and he rests his head on her bosom. In a strange twist, this first moment of bodily contact turns Clifford into something "like a child" with Mrs. Bolton. From then on, he begs her to give him sponge baths and kisses, touching her breasts in a way that is both sexual and infantile. Mrs. Bolton finds this thrilling and shameful, though she never stops it.

This strange passage illuminates the ways Clifford is passive instead of active, suggesting that receiving sponge baths and comfort make him weak and "like a child." But though Mrs. Bolton believes this behavior to be inappropriate and even deviant, her desire to have power over a member of the upper class wins over her disgust at Clifford's behavior.



But while Clifford leans into his childlike demeanor at home, this reversion allows him to be an even sharper and more successful businessman in the outside world, almost "inhuman" in his ability to make decisions based on cost and chemistry. Mrs. Bolton is both proud of and revolted by Clifford's business success. More than that, she is upset by Clifford's refusal to divorce Connie, especially because he seems less interested in reuniting with his wife than he is in faulting her for breaking a promise.

In highlighting Clifford's business acumen, the novel portrays him as unnatural in two ways. Just as Clifford's sexual behavior is a far cry from the natural masculinity Mellors embodies, his focus on calculations and chemicals over people and landscapes is similarly mechanical, "inhuman."



Though Connie dreads it, she feels bullied into going back to Wragby; as soon as she returns to the house, she is struck by how "evil" the place feels. Connie is relieved to see that Clifford is behaving haughtily instead of pathetically, greeting her in his best black-tie clothes. With cold rage, he accuses her of going back on her word. Despite Connie's acknowledgement and apology, Clifford still refuses to believe that she really loves Duncan Forbes. So Connie confesses the truth: she loves Mellors.

Whereas Connie associates Mellors with naked beauty, Clifford tries to gain power through clothing, bought in an attempt to compensate for his physical insecurities. Even at the end of his marriage, then, Clifford still hopes to use his wealth as a distraction from (or compensation for) his lack of bodily strength.



Clifford's eyes bulge with anger at this confession; "if he could have sprung out his **chair**," thinks Connie, "he would have done so." Still, it is clear that he has known, deep down, that the rumors about Connie and Mellors were true. Clifford hates the idea that Connie would marry this working-class man, much less have a baby with him. In his anger, Clifford tells Connie that she is perverted, "not normal." Stubbornly, he vows that he will never give her a divorce.

Hilda convinces Connie that her only option is to pack up and leave and hope that Clifford will change his mind. Connie does so, saying goodbye to Mrs. Bolton and resolving to wait for six months until Mellors's divorce comes through. The plan is that he will work farming jobs, saving up enough so that soon they can get their own small farm together. "So they would have to wait till spring was in," Connie thinks.

In a letter, Mellors tells Connie about the farm he is working on. He likes the owners, who are grieving a son lost to the war. Mellors also enjoys farming, though this new town, too, is filled with mines and colliers. Mellors continues to rail against these "apathetic" men, worked to the bone and always anxious about money; "if you could only tell them," he laments, "that living and spending isn't the same thing!" Mellors feels that this shift in mindset is the last defense against the doom wrought by industrialization.

Indeed, Mellors feels that the one thing that gives him hope for the future is believing in "the little flame" between himself and Connie. Even as he turns 40, Mellors still struggles to balance "patience" with the "tortur[ous]" desire he feels every time he thinks about Connie. Eventually, though, he writes that he has come to "love chastity," because it is a kind of peace that can only come between bouts of passionate sex.

Mellors ends his letter by promising Connie that he will keep his faith in "the little flame, and in the unnamed god that shields it from being blown out." He knows their separation is necessary, though he thinks that sex creates everything good in the world; even the **flowers**, Mellors believes, are born from the sun and the earth copulating. Finally, he signs off with their old pet names: "John Thomas says good-night to Lady Jane, a little drooping, but with a hopeful heart."

Clifford's accusation that Connie is "not normal" is ironic, given how much the novel has just dwelled on Clifford's own abnormalities. The narrative again conflates Clifford's disability with his personal failings, as even in his moment of rage, all Connie can think about is his inability to get out of his mechanical wheelchair.



It is perhaps unsurprising that Connie and Mellors, hoping to embrace a more natural way of life, have chosen to escape to a farm. In an interesting detail, Connie's resolution to "wait" for spring parallels her physical experience of sex, in which she waits for Mellors to set the pace of their mutual pleasure.



Mellors's rant against colliers and their machines is familiar, but more salient is his unusual respect for this family. Because this farm family grieves World War I, Mellors seems to hint, they are able to move on from it naturally, rather than distracting themselves with new technologies and endless "spending." The novel mostly emphasizes pleasure and sexual intimacy as a key to meaningful continuity, but here, grief emerges as another critical part of that equation.



In Mellors's final letter to Connie, the novel's omniscient narrator disappears, at last allowing readers directly into the communication between the story's central couple. Now, Mellors learns to let the passionate sex he had with Connie—"their real togetherness"—animate and sustain his time alone. In other words, because he has known powerful physical intimacy, Mellors is able to embrace things beyond that intimacy, whether that means picking up his pen or approaching the future with new patience.



Lady Chatterley's Lover began with the mention of cataclysm; in this touching conclusion, Mellors emphasizes the value of "hope," of finding one "little flame" still burning amidst the rubble of violence and mechanization. As always, Mellors focuses on sex and nature—both symbolized by flowers—as the ingredients of this hope. But in signing off with a "drooping" "John Thomas" (perhaps a reference to his flaccid penis), Mellors moves from thinking purely in terms of passion to valuing "heart," emphasizing not only rugged sex but patient, lasting commitment.





HOW TO CITE

To cite this LitChart:

MLA

Sabel, Francesca. "*Lady Chatterley's Lover*." *LitCharts*. LitCharts LLC, 21 Jul 2023. Web. 24 Jul 2023.

CHICAGO MANUAL

Sabel, Francesca. "*Lady Chatterley's Lover*." LitCharts LLC, July 21, 2023. Retrieved July 24, 2023. <https://www.litcharts.com/lit/lady-chatterley-s-lover>.

To cite any of the quotes from *Lady Chatterley's Lover* covered in the Quotes section of this LitChart:

MLA

Lawrence, D. H.. *Lady Chatterley's Lover*. Signet. 2011.

CHICAGO MANUAL

Lawrence, D. H.. *Lady Chatterley's Lover*. New York: Signet. 2011.